

THE REAL-LIFE EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING WORKBOOK

A Handbook of Exercises to Help Unique Learners
Build Real-World Skills and Success

CHRIS HANSON
AMY SIPPL, MS, BCBA



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To Build Real-World Skills and Success



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INTRODUCTION

We begin our executive functioning guidebook with a story:

Sam is a sixteen-year-old student with autism and ADHD who struggles with homework tasks. Sam likes drawing complex sketches of buildings and wants to be an architect someday. However, her smartphone sometimes gets in the way after school, and she regularly procrastinates with projects and assignments late into the evening. Her parents, Andy and Joan, must ask her repeatedly to get started on her homework, each time more and more insistent. Sam thinks her parents are constantly nagging at her, so she spends as much time in her room as she can. Sometimes she likes to spend time with her older sibling Loren, but Loren is usually out with friends. Loren gets her homework done during study times at school, which never happens for Sam.

On a typical Tuesday evening, it's around 10 pm when Sam finally gets around to doing homework. She's tired and rushes through the project so she can go to sleep. The next day Sam turns in her assignment. Her teacher can see that Sam didn't do her best work, so Sam has to keep working while her friends get time to talk and text at the end of class.



Frustrated and angry, Sam yells at her teacher. "You're just another person out to get me!" storms out of the classroom, bumping another student hard into the wall on her way out the door. As Sam storms down the hallway, she knows her teacher is already calling Andy or Joan.

In far too many of the homes and classrooms we've worked in over the years, we've heard and witnessed stories just like Sam's. We've worked with hundreds of children, teens, and young adults with a great deal of potential, using problem behaviors to respond to every day demands.

EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING IN 'REAL-LIFE'

For Sam, what started as an issue with procrastination led to an aggressive behavior likely to get her in trouble at school. Sam has some excellent skills to build on, but her procrastination gets in the way. Over time, organization, time management, and planning challenges contribute to deteriorated relationships with her family members, teachers, and peers.

It's easy to try to pinpoint Sam's troubles on a diagnosis, on her academics, or her struggling social skills. But what if there's another explanation for Sam's procrastination? Like so many other students with unique learning needs, Sam's underlying challenges may relate to executive functioning or how she organizes, plans, and completes goals. The reason for Sam's struggles is not her 'bad behavior' or lack of social skills. It's a 'real-life' problem with executive functioning.

WHAT IS EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING?

While there are no set definitions of executive functioning behaviors, most professionals agree it includes behaviors that help us effectively and efficiently complete tasks and interact with others. Executive functioning includes:

- Planning and organizing
- Managing time
- Problem-solving
- Working memory
- Controlling our emotions and our impulses
- Monitoring and learning from our behavior and past mistakes.



ASSESSING EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING SKILLS AND PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

In special education and vocational programs, a growing body of research demonstrates that the most successful way to address challenging behaviors in individuals with unique learning needs is to identify **why** the behavior occurs and teach an appropriate alternative replacement behavior.

As we examine different scenarios like Sam's, it becomes apparent that many children with autism and related developmental disabilities struggle with challenging behaviors in part because of underdeveloped executive functioning skills. As parents, teachers, and professionals dealing with problem behavior, evaluating deficits in executive functioning skills can pinpoint the root cause or 'function' of problem behavior and create a plan for replacement. By evaluating deficits in executive functioning skills, parents, teachers, and professionals dealing with problem behavior, we can pinpoint the root cause or 'function' of problem behavior and create a replacement plan.

The example below demonstrates how improvements in time management skills can work to address the 'function' of verbal refusals to complete homework:



WITHOUT EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING:



AFTER TEACHING EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING:



TEACHING EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING

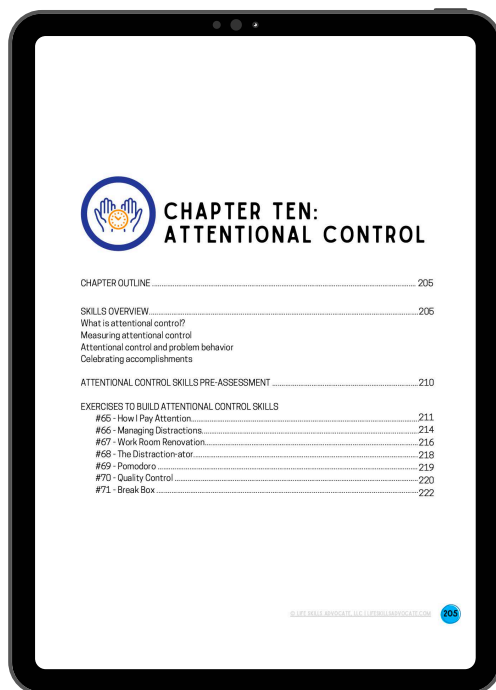
If we know that boosting executive functioning skills can help reduce the barriers to success for many students, then why don't we spend time teaching these behaviors at a young age? Unfortunately, with so much emphasis on academic performance and meeting IEP goals, for many non-traditional learners, executive functioning falls through the cracks. Most schools emphasize executive functioning as secondary skills, taught through repeated experience with academic-based projects. Rarely do schools dedicate time to a curriculum or directly teaching executive functioning behaviors.

WHO IS THE REAL-LIFE EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING WORKBOOK FOR?

That's where *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook* comes in. This workbook was designed to fill the gaps for teens and young adults struggling with under-developed or delays in executive functioning skills. Written with both individuals and the adults who support them in mind, it's a multi-faceted toolbox of evidence-based strategies and supports that can generate meaningful life changes.

If you or your learner could benefit from a booster or a complete executive functioning curriculum, the exercises in these pages can help you:

- Identify and assess problem areas and pitfalls.
- Learn about the different types of executive functioning skills.
- Practice new strategies and behaviors to promote academic and vocational success.



HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook is designed to be useful both across years of skill development, but also useful from the very first day.

Each chapter and exercise has been thoughtfully designed to help you and your learner find the skills you need right away.

CHAPTER TITLE PAGES

Each chapter in the workbook targets one of the core executive functioning skills. The chapter title page provides a detailed, page-by-page list of the chapter contents and specific exercises designed to build fluency in that executive functioning skill.

KEY ICONS

Each executive functioning skill targeted in the workbook has a specific icon to visually guide you throughout the workbook. Icons can be found on each chapter page and at the heading of each workbook exercise.



PLANNING



TIME
MANAGEMENT



TASK
INITIATION



ORGANIZATION



PROBLEM
SOLVING



FLEXIBILITY



WORKING
MEMORY



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL



IMPULSE
CONTROL



ATTENTIONAL
CONTROL



SELF
MONITORING

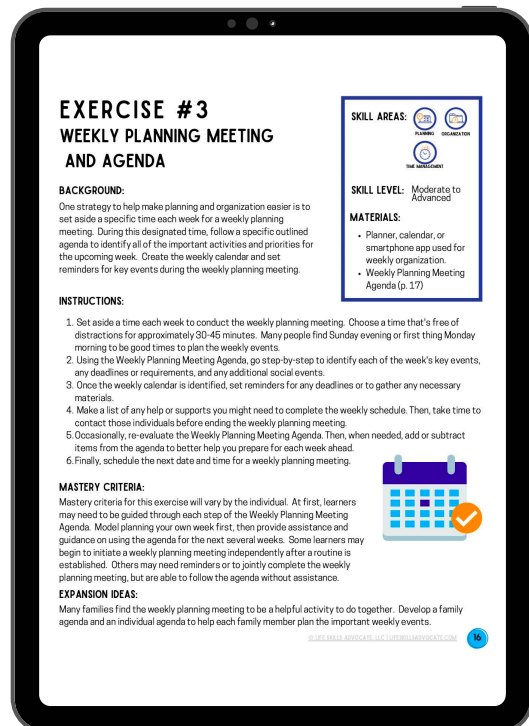
CROSS-REFERENCE LINKS

For exercises that target more than one skill area, easily jump between chapters and supporting exercises by clicking on the corresponding icon.

EXERCISE OUTLINE

The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook exercises have been written and tested to help individuals and families build real world success. Each exercise contains:

- background information to help you and your learner understand the "why" and "how" for each executive functioning strategy.
- skill level ranked for easy, moderate or advanced learners
- materials list.
- easy-to-understand instructions.
- any required printables, including assessments and worksheets.
- an outlined mastery criteria so you and your learner know you've achieved this skill.
- when appropriate, adaptations and expansion ideas for beginning and advanced learners.



GETTING STARTED

In our work with clients, we always emphasize individualized learning. The same course of action that works for one individual may not work for everyone. Learning new executive functioning skills should be personalized to build on each person's strengths and motivations.

We recommend starting *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook* with the pre-assessments located at the start of each chapter. These short assessments take approximately 3-5 minutes to complete and provide direction on which executive functioning exercises might be most valuable based on responses you provide about your current behavior or the behavior of your learner.

After that, choose the individualized learning style that suits you the best. Some may find it helpful to review and practice each exercise in order, like reading a traditional textbook. Others may find it more useful to flip around, choosing exercises by topic or executive functioning skill. Choose the path that fits your learner's current skills, strengths, and learning preferences.



CHAPTER ONE: PLANNING

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PLANNING

Before launching into the first chapter, take a few minutes to consider how many tools you've already used today to plan your life. Three? Seven? One extra ambitious reader once told us they used more than 30 different tools to help order the day, plan out tasks, and stay on track.

Our environment is filled with devices to keep us on time (watches, smartphones, calendars, etc.) and on track (folders, labels, checklists, etc.) with the demands of daily life. Thousands of different planning and organization tools are available at our fingertips. Many of these tools we've integrated so seamlessly into our daily life we rarely even stop to consider how they keep our behaviors in check.

But none of these tools are helpful if we never learn the planning skills to use them in the first place. Among all the different executive functioning skills to teach teens and young adults with unique learning needs, planning can be the most helpful to learn first.

As parents, we want our children to recognize and perform daily tasks efficiently without many challenges or disruptions. As teachers, we see value in how planning ties directly into problem-solving and academic achievement. However, when our children struggle with planning, we see the breakdowns, frustrations, escape, and avoidance behaviors, and in some cases, even severe problem behaviors like aggression and self-harm. Therefore, it's essential that parents and teachers not only understand the ins and outs of planning but also understand how deficiencies in these and other executive functioning skills might be causing broader behavioral challenges for your child.



WHAT ARE PLANNING SKILLS?

Planning skills fall into a group of executive functioning behaviors related to a child's ability to identify and manage future-orientated tasks. Planning behaviors involve how an individual identifies future responsibilities and events, sets goals to complete them, and analyzes the steps needed to complete the task ahead of time. Planning skills are often closely tied to the executive functioning skills of organizing and prioritizing. We use planning along with these other skills to gather information or resources and assemble it into main ideas and processes. When we use planning with organization, we have the right information and tools and know what to do with them to solve a problem.

WHY ARE PLANNING SKILLS SO IMPORTANT?

Once you understand the basics of planning skills, it quickly becomes apparent why parents and teachers highly value them and how they tie to the success of children, teens, and young adults. Studies show that executive functioning skills like planning and organization directly correlate to a variety of different performance indicators, including:

- Increased academic performance and thoughts about one's own academic achievement (Bailey, Andrzejewski, Greif, Svingos & Heaton, 2018; Jacobson & Parkinson, 2015)
- Successful social engagement with family members and peers (Dawson & Guare, 2018)
- Employment and occupational success later in life (Barkley and Fischer, 2011)



EXAMPLES OF PLANNING SKILLS

- Identifying the order and sequence to complete a task or activity
- Identifying a designated place for materials needed to complete a task
- Creating a structure or order around frequently performed tasks
- Creating an orderly plan to complete multiple tasks
- Using an organization tool like a calendar, timeline, planner, or datebook.

PLANNING SKILLS AND PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

Deficits in executive functioning skills like planning can also influence problem behaviors and how others perceive a child's problem behavior. Can you or your child identify with any of these scenarios?

- Your child can complete tasks fully, but only if there's a clear, step-by-step organization.
- Your child experiences meltdowns or has problem behaviors when tasks don't go smoothly when things feel out of control, or they hit bumps in the middle of a task.
- You frequently find your child missing the right materials at the right time, including leaving for school or work without all the required materials, leaving behind personal belongings at friends' and family members' homes, etc.

- Creating and following daily schedules creates conflicts for you and your child.
- Others are responsible for planning, coordinating, and following through with social events with your child's friends and family.
- Your child can identify the end steps of a goal but struggles to determine the initial point to get started or intermediate steps that need to happen first.

In each of these scenarios, the problem behavior and frustration could be eliminated or substantially reduced by reducing the failures in planning behavior.

TEACHING PLANNING SKILLS AND THE PLANNING SKILLS PROGRESSION

just like many other skills for unique learners, every individual will have strengths and areas of need when it comes to planning skills. Understanding where to begin teaching planning skills is important to avoid additional frustration and problem behavior. The planning skills of a five-year-old may be different from a young adult. But if your child is missing some of the foundational planning skills at a young age, more advanced skills may not be possible to teach without backing up to the basics first.

The key is to identify component goals and treat them as a slow progression towards a wide range of planning skills. Consider this sample progression of component goals one might teach starting with the skill of selecting a meal and moving all the way to complex meal planning for special occasions.



When you consider planning skills in a progression, it becomes more clear that a child who struggles to plan meals for an entire day lacks the foundational skills to evaluate nutrition or select new recipes. By starting with smaller, foundational goals and following a progression forward to more challenging steps, you're setting yourself and your child up for more success.

Some steps in a planning skills progression may come easier than others. That's okay.

Remember that long list you created earlier of the different tools you use for planning and organization? We use these tools to help at times when planning may be more challenging. If your child is struggling with a particular component goal in the progression, keep working at it.

GETTING STARTED WITH PLANNING SKILLS

To get started with planning skills, take the pre-assessment on the next page which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your learner. Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and planning how you might accomplish your planning-related goal.

PLANNING SKILLS

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the planning exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

1. I use a weekly planner or calendar.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

2. When I start tasks, I complete them to the end.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

3. I stick to a daily routine.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

4. Planning out chores, homework and meals comes easy to me.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

5. I write down things I need to remember or my priority tasks.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

6. I know which task to start first when I begin a project.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

7. I know how to put steps in order for a bigger project.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For goal planning and rewarding success

12

For learning to use planning tools like calendars, reminders, and agendas

23578

For help with homework, studying and planning projects

589

EXERCISE #1

SMART GOAL SETTING

BACKGROUND:

There are many behaviors that can support the development of planning skills. Use these beginner, intermediate, and advanced planning skill ideas to generate a SMART goal.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Start by completing the pre-assessment for the chapter. This will help you generate ideas for an initial planning skills goal.
2. Using the pre-assessment questions and the list of planning goal ideas below, select one item to use as a beginning goal to develop planning skills.
3. Set a timer for 15 minutes. During this time, write a draft of 2-3 different SMART goals (see *Introduction* for more information on writing SMART goals) to build this skill. When the timer goes off, choose the best goal. Write it in the SMART goal box.
4. Set a timer for 5 minutes. Write down all of the strengths and barriers that may help or get in the way of achieving this goal.
5. Set a timer for 5 more minutes. Complete the remaining questions about motivation and developing a "why" for this goal.
6. Set a timer for 3 minutes. Write down 3 milestones to help you measure the goal.
7. Once you've identified milestones, record a target date to achieve the goal.
8. Begin working on your SMART goal.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Many learners will need assistance with setting SMART goals and completing them. Continue working with your learner on completing the worksheet and executing the goals until they have drafted and achieved 2 different goals using the SMART method.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The SMART goal-setting process can be used for a variety of different goals. Once you've achieved a planning goal, apply the goal to other academic, vocational, and social goals.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Printable SMART Goal Setting Worksheet (p. 14)
- Timer

PLANNING GOAL IDEAS:

BEGINNER	INTERMEDIATE	ADVANCED
• How to identify a main goal. • How to identify the main idea vs. minor details. • Using a checklist. • Ordering simple activities.	• Use a calendar or planner. • Set reminders. • How to use visual maps, drawings, and diagrams for planning.	• How to use the 'next best step' strategy. • How to communicate a plan to others. • Managing when things don't go according to plan.

SMART GOAL SETTING WORKSHEET

SMART GOAL SETTING

S

Specific - What is the behavior we want to achieve?

M

Measurable - How will you know we've achieved it?

A

Attainable - What is the realistic outcome?

R

Relevant - Why is this important?

T

Time Bound - When will we achieve this by?

Target Goal Date:

STRENGTHS

What tools do I have to succeed?

BARRIERS

What's getting in the way right now?

Why do I want to accomplish this goal?

Why might others want me to accomplish this goal?

What good things will happen when I accomplish the goal?

Milestones To Know I'm Making Progress

1

2

3

EXERCISE #2

PLANNING STRATEGIES VISION BOARD

BACKGROUND:

Once you have tested several of the strategies in *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*, you may find yourself coming back to the same worksheets and exercises again and again. It can be helpful to organize them in one place so it's easy to find the right planning tool at the right time. Each time you need to plan something important or complete your weekly planning session (see Exercise #3), open up your vision board and choose one of the tools.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Begin by making a list of the four or five primary areas of your life where you frequently use planning tools. These areas might include home, school, friends and family, work, finances.
2. Open the file folder and lay it out flat.
3. Segment out the folder into the primary areas you identified on your list by drawing lines or cutting and gluing different colored papers. Label each area.
4. Under each area identify the planning tools that you've found to be most effective in those areas. Write keywords, draw pictures, or cut out images to serve as reminders in each area. For example, under "SCHOOL" you might write "Exam Study Plan" or cut out the header for "Exercise #9" to remind yourself where to look in the workbook.
5. In the file folder, place additional copies of key worksheets and printables that you use regularly.
6. Each time you encounter a new project or find yourself struggling to plan ahead, take out your planning vision board and select a strategy that you've already identified as helpful.
7. As you work through the workbook or identify a new useful planning tool, add to the list under each different primary area.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Vision boards can be completed once or can be working archives that are added to or subtracted from as needed. Work with your learner to develop a vision board, and then continue the process until they can independently open the folder and select a strategy for planning.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate

MATERIALS:

- File folder
- Basic art materials (markers, scissors, glue, tape, etc.)
- Printable worksheets *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook* exercises and worksheets

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner finds the planning strategies vision board helpful, consider creating a file folder vision board for other executive functioning skills like time management, problem-solving, and self-monitoring.

EXERCISE #3

WEEKLY PLANNING MEETING AND AGENDA

BACKGROUND:

One strategy to help make planning and organization easier is to set aside a specific time each week for a weekly planning meeting. During this designated time, follow a specific outlined agenda to identify all of the important activities and priorities for the upcoming week. Create the weekly calendar and set reminders for key events during the weekly planning meeting.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Set aside a time each week to conduct the weekly planning meeting. Choose a time that's free of distractions for approximately 30-45 minutes. Many people find Sunday evening or first thing Monday morning to be good times to plan the weekly events.
2. Using the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda, go step-by-step to identify each of the week's key events, any deadlines or requirements, and any additional social events.
3. Once the weekly calendar is identified, set reminders for any deadlines or to gather any necessary materials.
4. Make a list of any help or supports you might need to complete the weekly schedule. Then, take time to contact those individuals before ending the weekly planning meeting.
5. Occasionally, re-evaluate the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda. Then, when needed, add or subtract items from the agenda to better help you prepare for each week ahead.
6. Finally, schedule the next date and time for a weekly planning meeting.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise will vary by the individual. At first, learners may need to be guided through each step of the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda. Model planning your own week first, then provide assistance and guidance on using the agenda for the next several weeks. Some learners may begin to initiate a weekly planning meeting independently after a routine is established. Others may need reminders or to jointly complete the weekly planning meeting, but are able to follow the agenda without assistance.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Many families find the weekly planning meeting to be a helpful activity to do together. Develop a family agenda and an individual agenda to help each family member plan the important weekly events.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



ORGANIZATION

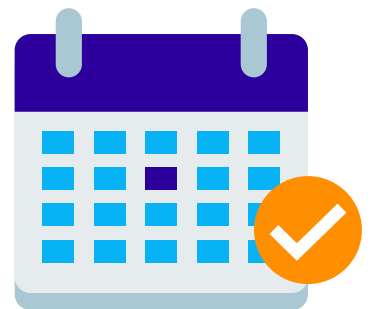


TIME MANAGEMENT

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Planner, calendar, or smartphone app used for weekly organization.
- Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda (p. 17)



WEEKLY PLANNING AGENDA

Dates:

START WITH MY REQUIRED ACTIVITIES:

STEP ONE:

What events/activities do I have to do this week (work, school, medical or therapy appointments, etc.)?

Enter these appointments into the calendar.

STEP TWO:

What important deadlines do I have this week? What do I have to complete before the deadline occurs?

Enter each deadline into the calendar. Designate time to complete each activity prior to the deadline.

STEP THREE:

What time do I need for my daily routines and household chores this week (e.g. morning routine, meals, laundry, sleeping)?

Designate time to complete each activity and enter it into the calendar.

THEN, ORGANIZE MY ADDITIONAL TIME:

STEP FOUR:

What are my current SMART goals? What time do I have to work on meeting my next milestone?

Designate SMART time each day to work on your current goals.

STEP FIVE:

Looking ahead in my calendar for the next few weeks and months, what important deadlines do I have coming up?

Use available time during the week to work ahead on upcoming deadlines and projects.

FINALLY, PLAN SOME FUN!

STEP SIX:

What fun activities do I have this week?

How will I reward myself for staying on track with my plans and goals?

What do I want to do with the free time I have if I manage my time well?

WHEN IS MY NEXT WEEKLY PLANNING MEETING?

Date:

Time:

EXERCISE #4

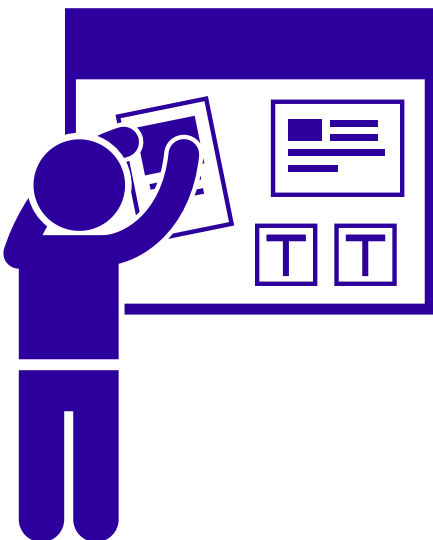
PRIORITIES POST-ITS

BACKGROUND:

For learners who respond well to visuals, it can sometimes be helpful to have the week's tasks all presented at once. In this exercise, the learner places each requirement of the week on a sticky note and then sorts them into the priorities of the week on a large wall. The wall then serves as a visual reminder of what's most important and what needs to be completed throughout the week.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Choose a time that's free of distractions for approximately 30-45 minutes. This exercise can also be completed along with the Weekly Planning Meeting (p. 16).
2. Create one sticky note for each of the following headings: "Daily Tasks" "Must Do and Deadlines", "Would Like To Do", "Overdue Tasks," and "Have to Wait" These headers will serve as main topics to sort the priorities of the week. Create other columns if needed, but avoid more than 7-8 total.
3. Write each key task, assignment, deadline, or daily routine on an individual sticky note. Post them on the wall under the corresponding header.
4. Once all the task notes are placed, step back and examine the priorities. Are there tasks in the must-do or deadlines that need to be separated into more sticky notes? Are there too many tasks in one category? Are there reminders that need to be set for any of the tasks?



SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



TIME MANAGEMENT

SKILL LEVEL: Easy

MATERIALS:

- Sticky notes adhesive papers
- Weekly calendar
- Large wall space or whiteboard.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

At first, some learners may need to be guided through each step of putting priorities on the wall. Provide assistance and guidance to make sure all tasks are posted on the wall in the accurate priorities area. Other learners may be able to create and adjust a wall of priorities with less guidance.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If you find the activity valuable, use it to set priorities for projects with multiple steps, or to plan out a month or year of priorities. It can also be helpful for prioritizing SMART goals to identify which to target first (p. 13).

EXERCISE #5

TASK ANALYSIS GENERATOR

BACKGROUND:

Task analysis is the process of breaking a larger skill down into component sub-tasks and teaching each simpler step as a building block to a larger goal. Creating a task analysis can be a helpful tool during the planning stages of a household chore or project with many different steps. It can also be helpful to overcome struggles with task initiation since the next step or sub-task is already laid out for the learner.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Task Analysis Printable Worksheet (p.20).
2. Write down the ending objective at the top of the task analysis. Task Analysis works well for academic tasks, household chores, or any project to break apart into different sub-tasks. Tasks that work well for a task analysis should have multiple steps and sub-tasks with a discrete skill (i.e., clear start and endpoint.)
3. Break down the task into simple sub-tasks. It can be helpful to do the task yourself and record each step as you go, or have a second person perform the task. Observe that person complete each step of the task and write down what they do.
4. Add visuals (optional). Some learners will benefit from visuals paired with the written instructions. Take photos or use an app-based tool to generate a corresponding visual or symbol representing each step.
5. Confirm that the steps are effective in reaching the end outcome. Having a second person follow the steps in your written task analysis. Identify any areas where they may have stumbled or needed clarification to complete a sub-task. Revise if needed.
6. Implement the task analysis. Place the task analysis in an easy-to-reference location. Each time the learner needs to complete the activity, practice following along with the step-by-step guide.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Generating a task analysis can take practice, even for professionals. Start with simpler tasks (5 or fewer steps) first until you are comfortable and fluent with the procedure. Then move on to more complex tasks with more steps. Consider this exercise mastered when you can generate a task analysis for new projects.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

As mentioned above, task analyses work well with visuals. Consider using video to record each individual step of a task. Keep different task analyses together in your Project Planning Vision Board (p. 15). Collect data. If using the task analysis to teach a new skill, use the attached data collection log to track how much prompting each step requires. Gradually fade the prompting your learner becomes more successful.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



TASK INITIATION

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Task Analysis Printable Worksheet (p.20)
- A second person to assist with the task
- Camera or smartphone (optional)

TASK ANALYSIS GENERATOR

TASK:

ENDING OBJECTIVE:

STEP ONE:

STEP TWO:

STEP THREE:

STEP FOUR:

STEP FIVE:

STEP SIX:

STEP SEVEN:

STEP EIGHT:

STEP NINE:

STEP TEN:

TASK ANALYSIS GENERATOR

TASK:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

STEP:

TASK ANALYSIS GENERATOR (SAMPLE)

TASK: washing dishes

ENDING OBJECTIVE: sam will wash and put away the dishes after each meal.

STEP ONE: Gather dirty dishes near the sink.

STEP TWO: Put plug in the sink drain.

STEP THREE: Turn on hot water.

STEP FOUR: Squirt in a small amount of soap.

STEP FIVE: Get rag and dish rack.

STEP SIX: Turn off hot water.

STEP SEVEN: Wash silverware.

STEP EIGHT: Wash cups and glasses.

STEP NINE: Wash plates.

STEP TEN: Wash pots and pans.

STEP ELEVEN: Rinse the dishes.

STEP TWELVE: Put in the dish rack.

STEP THIRTEEN: Dry the dishes.

STEP FOURTEEN: Put away the dishes.

STEP FIFTEEN: Remove the drain plug.

STEP SIXTEEN: Empty the drain.

STEP SEVENTEEN: Put away dish rack.



EXERCISE #6

THE SANDBOX

BACKGROUND:

It's been said that our brains were designed for thinking, not for remembering. Brain dumping is the intentional act of freeing up space in our brain by dumping its contents (not literally of course) out regularly on a sheet of paper so that our brains can do what they're best at, like problem-solving, critical thinking, turning our thoughts into reality, etc. The Sandbox exercise creates a space and habit to 'brain dump' anything we encounter across the day.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Choose a notebook to be used only as your Sandbox.
2. Open the notebook and on the first page, write your name and contact information. In the event your Sandbox gets left behind somewhere it will hopefully be returned to you.
3. On the next page, write the word INDEX. This page will serve as a guide for you to list out important things that are in the Sandbox so you can easily reference them later.
4. Turn the page and begin numbering the pages in the top corner. On each fresh page, begin brain dumping. You can title pages by topic (e.g. This Month's Goals, Birthday Gift Ideas, My Morning Routine) or each day, write the date at the top of the page, and begin 'dumping' any important information that you encounter during the day.
5. When you encounter something you know you'll need to reference later, write the page number and topic on the INDEX page.
6. At the end of the day, review the new items that have been added to the Sandbox. Any action items that need to be completed should be added to your daily planner for the next day (See Exercise #15).

MASTERY CRITERIA:

There's really no right or wrong way to use the Sandbox. Each learner should establish a habit of writing down notes, topics, and important information across the day in whatever way you find most helpful. Some people use a template for the Sandbox, others just write notes and shorthand as they go. Mastery for this exercise happens when all-important information finds its way into the Sandbox.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Many people find The Sandbox to be helpful when paired with the Weekly Planning Meeting. Write events and reminders for the upcoming week in the Sandbox, then plan them out with the Weekly Agenda (see page 16).

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Easy

MATERIALS:

- Notebook
- Pen & Paper



EXERCISE #7

CALENDAR CONSTRUCTION

BACKGROUND:

Not every learner uses calendars in the same way. What's important is to individualize your monthly calendar in a way that makes sense to you and your lifestyle. In calendar construction, you'll use a basic calendar template to create a color-coded calendar with all the important information you'll need this month.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Print a copy of the Printable Calendar Template (p. 25) for each month you plan to construct. Select a time to complete this exercise when you have approximately 20-30 minutes of time without interruptions to construct your calendar.
2. Write the month and the year on the calendar template.
3. Using a dark neutral color like black or navy blue, fill in the numbers on the calendar to match the days of the week, (e.g. the 1st of the month is the first Thursday).
4. Next, choose a color you associate with positive feelings or that reminds you of important personal events. Use that color to write birthdays, holidays, vacation days, or other special remembrances.
5. Next, choose a bright, bold color like red or orange to represent any deadlines. Include deadlines for projects or homework, or personal SMART goals (See Exercise #1).
6. Choose a third color that reminds you of appointments. These could include medical or therapy appointments, appointments with friends, or appointments with yourself like the Weekly Planning Meeting (see Exercise #3).
7. Continue selecting colors for each important category you plan to add to the calendar.
8. The final stage of calendar construction is to customize. Decorate the outside of the calendar with stickers, drawings, washi tape, or other craft items to give it some personal flair. Have a special goal this month? Is there a holiday or season you are excited to celebrate? Show off your individual personality with a custom calendar style.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Some individuals may need support to create a monthly calendar, especially to know when key dates and deadlines occur that need to be transferred to the calendar. Begin by modeling creating your own calendar, and then work to fade out support until the learner creates and uses the monthly calendar to track important life events and deadlines.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Easy

MATERIALS:

- Printable Calendar Template (p. 25)
- Colored Pens, Highlighters or Markers
- Stickers, Washi Tape, Decorative Papers, etc.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

As mentioned above, many people find Calendar Construction to be a helpful exercise to pair with the Weekly Planning Meeting (see Exercise #3) and the Sandbox (see Exercise #6). If you have a learner that finds this to be a helpful strategy, create daily or weekly calendar templates as well.

MONTH:

SUNDAY	MONDAY	TUESDAY	WEDNESDAY	THURSDAY	FRIDAY	SATURDAY

EXERCISE #8

DAILY HOMEWORK PLANNER

BACKGROUND:

Many students report the hardest part of homework is getting organized. Knowing what needs to be done when, what tasks need to be completed first, and where to start can be debilitating for some of us. Instead of stumbling to the point of frustration, start each homework session with a simple planning exercise. Review the tasks, budget time, and create priorities so there's a clear road map to help you get started.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Daily Homework Planner Worksheet. You may also copy the template into your Sandbox notebook (see Exercise #6) before starting each homework session.
2. Begin by making a list for each of the school subjects you may have homework for. Being in the habit of listing out each subject, even if there are no immediate deadlines, can ensure that you don't inadvertently forget something on the list.
3. For each subject list out the assigned readings, tasks, or projects in the "Assignments" section. Whenever possible, list homework assignments with multiple parts with each sub-step separately.
4. Next, make a list of the materials you'll need to complete the reading, task, or project. Use notes like "math textbook" or "graphing paper" to help you gather materials later.
5. Under "Time", create a time estimate for how much time it will take to complete each task on the list. Don't worry about the exact timing, but this will allow you to budget the right amount of tasks for the time available in your homework session.
6. Under "Priorities" decide which order to complete tasks in. Some people find it helpful to start with the shortest tasks first to build momentum. Others find it helpful to mix up the order of easier and harder tasks.
7. When the worksheet is completed, gather all of the materials on the materials list. Start with the first item in the priorities list and work through all of the homework tasks in order. Check off each task as you go.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Some learners may need assistance to develop a homework plan. Others may find it easier to work through a plan once it's developed for them. Work towards being able to create and execute the daily homework planner without support each day for one week.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



ORGANIZATION



TASK INITIATION

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to
Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Daily Homework Planner Worksheet (p. 27)
- Homework materials

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Daily Homework Planner process can be used for other tasks and routines including household chores, meal planning, and prep, and special projects.

DAILY HOMEWORK PLANNER

Today's Date:

PRIORITY	SUBJECT	ASSIGNMENT	MATERIALS	TIME	DONE

EXERCISE #9

EXAM STUDY PLAN

BACKGROUND:

Never get caught pulling another all-nighter or panicking about an upcoming exam again with this step-by-step exercise to create an outline and study plan for the next big test.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Exam Study Plan Worksheet.
2. Begin by entering the exam title and the planned date of the test.
3. Next, list out each of the tasks or topics that may be tested on the exam.
4. Survey your understanding of each topic. In the orange circle, put a checkmark (✓) next to the orange circle for each topic that you already have mastery over.
5. From that survey, generate a list of the high, medium, and low priority topics and the order in which you intend to study them.
6. Depending on the number and difficulty of the priority topics identified, plan out all available study times between now and the exam. Write a location, date, and time for study sessions so it's easier to commit to them later.
7. For each study session, record the total number of minutes studied. Graph the total number of minutes on the Study Minutes Graph to track your progress towards your goal score.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Some learners may need assistance to develop an exam study plan at first. It may be helpful to show the exam study planner to your course instructor and ask them for guidance on the topics, priorities, and study time required to succeed on the test. Work towards being able to create an exam study plan that results in meeting the goal score for at least three exams.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Exam Study Planner worksheet can be used with the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda (see Exercise #3) or Calendar Construction (see Exercise #7) to promote long-term planning for exams. For larger tests with multiple chapters or sections, create an exam study planner worksheet for each area of the exam, highlighting key topics and a study plan for each area.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



ORGANIZATION



SELF
MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Exam Study Plan Worksheet (p. 29)
- Study materials



EXAM STUDY PLANNER

Exam:

Goal Score:

Date of the Exam:

EXAM TOPICS:

PRIORITIES TO STUDY:

HIGH

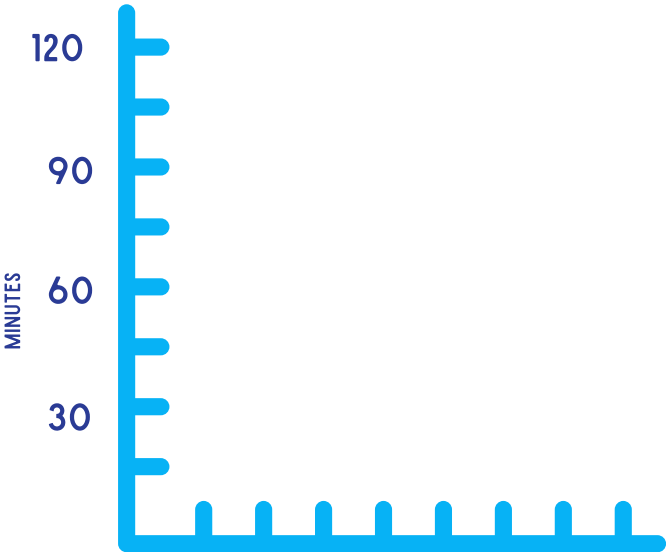
MEDIUM

LOW

STUDY SESSIONS

DATE	TIME	LOCATION	TOPICS

STUDY MINUTES GRAPH



EXERCISE #10

WEEKLY MEAL PLANNER

BACKGROUND:

We've all encountered the frustrating times when you open the refrigerator only to discover there's nothing to eat. So many executive functioning skills go into maintaining a healthy, well-balanced diet. One of those is having a weekly meal plan prepared to help organize and implement food preparation.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Weekly Meal Planner Worksheets (p. 31-32)
- Cookbook or Online Recipe Resource

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Weekly Meal Planner Worksheets. Identify a time with at least 30-45 minutes without interruptions to complete this exercise. It can be helpful to reference the Weekly Planning Meeting at the same time as the Weekly Meal Planner (see Exercise #3).
2. Begin by entering in any meals that will be eaten out, either at a restaurant or at a previous special event.
3. In the brainstorming section, list out all potential meal ideas. It can be helpful to reference ingredients you might already have in the pantry or freezer or cookbooks and food blogs for ideas.
4. Beginning with breakfasts, fill in the meal planning grid for the week with brainstorming ideas. Be sure to allow enough days to eat leftovers.
5. When the meal plan grid is completed, start back at the first meal and write down all the necessary ingredients you need to purchase from each recipe on the grocery shopping list.
6. Post the meal plan and recipes in an easy-to-find location in the kitchen to reference throughout the week.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Meal planning skills can be adapted in many different ways. Start by mastering a pre-made meal plan (there are many of these available online) and then moving towards developing a meal plan from recipes that you've made before. Choose from familiar meals first and then work towards expanding to new recipes and meal planning for special events.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

For many learners, having visuals to help with meal planning can be helpful. Consider adding step-by-step task analyses for recipes (see Exercise #5) with visuals to help as a learning step.



WEEKLY MEAL PLANNER

	BREAKFAST	LUNCH	DINNER
MONDAY			
TUESDAY			
WEDNESDAY			
THURSDAY			
FRIDAY			
SATURDAY			
SNACKS:			

WEEKLY MEAL PLANNER



BRAINSTORMING

Write down as many meal ideas as you can think of prior to menu planning.

Ask:

- What do I have ingredients for already?
- What am I hungry for?
- What meals have I not eaten for awhile?
- What new foods would I like to try?

GROCERY SHOPPING LIST



EXERCISE #11

JOB PLANNER

BACKGROUND:

For many teens and young adults, undergoing the job search process is the most complex planning task they will have encountered. Having a plan and organization tools can help make the process of finding a job easier and less stressful. Complete the worksheets in this Job Planner to successfully move from job search to hire.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download the printable Job Planner worksheets included in this chapter. Identify 60-90 minutes of time with limited distractions to complete this exercise.
2. Review the hiring process checklist on the cover page of the job planner. While each job search experience is different, this checklist provides a general outline of the steps to take when searching for a new job.
3. Begin with the Career Builder Brainstorming Activity to generate ideas for the types of skills and experiences that might be useful in a new job. Brainstorm individuals who may be helpful to you, potential employers where you might like to work, or jobs you might be interested in doing.
4. Next, complete the Job Posting Organizer. Use printed job boards, online search tools, or a local career center to look for potential positions in your area that match your skills and interests. For each position, record the requirements to apply and important contact information.
5. Keep all of your documents in one place during the job search process to easily access important contact information and notes about each position.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for the job search planner is simple -- continue working on these steps until you land that first position! In the meantime, it's important to note that many adults need support through the hiring process, regardless of skill and experience. Don't be discouraged by asking for support to complete the job planner, it might just be the steps you need to connect with a job you love.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Job Planner Worksheets can be useful if incorporated into a larger planning strategy (see Exercise #3) and SMART Goal Planning (see Exercise #1). If you're stuck in one place in the job search process, try strategies for task initiation (see Chapter 3) and problem-solving (see Chapter 5).

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Job Planner Worksheets (p.34-36)



JOB SEARCH CHECKLIST

PREPARE

☐

Identified the types of jobs I would like to apply for.

☐

Identified my skills and previous experience.

☐

Identified friends, family members or community relationships who might be able to help me in my job search.

☐

Identified 3-5 potential employers or job postings.

APPLY

☐

Gathered required materials (resume, references, cover letters, applications for each job posting.)

☐

Contacted employers or submitted applications.

INTERVIEW

☐

Scheduled and reviewed the location of the interview.

☐

Conducted interview preparation.

☐

Attended interview.

☐

Sent thank you email or handwritten note within 24 hours after the interview.

IF OFFERED THE POSITION

☐

Accept the offer.

☐

Complete the pre-work requirements (e.g. paperwork, background check)

☐

START NEW JOB!

CAREER BUILDER BRAINSTORMING

ABOUT ME:



What are my:

- Current Interests
- Values
- Likes/Dislikes

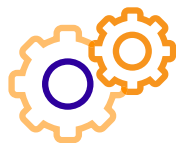
SKILLS:



What am I good at? What type of work do I like to do?

POTENTIAL JOBS:

Who might I want to work for?
What types of jobs do I want to do?
What jobs do I know are available?



MY CONNECTIONS:

Who do I know in my circle of friends, family, neighbors or community that could help me in my job search?



JOB POSTING ORGANIZER

JOB TITLE:

COMPANY:

Address:

Website:

Email & Phone:

Date of Posting:

Location of Job Post:

APPLICATION REQUIREMENTS:

KEY DATES:



Research

☐

Network

☐

Apply

☐

Prepare

☐

Interview

☐

JOB TITLE:

COMPANY:

Address:

Website:

Email & Phone:

Date of Posting:

Location of Job Post:

APPLICATION REQUIREMENTS:

KEY DATES:



Research

☐

Network

☐

Apply

☐

Prepare

☐

Interview

☐

EXERCISE #12

REWARDING SUCCESS

BACKGROUND:

Part of the planning process before a big project or task should always include examining the rewards that will happen at the end of the task. Knowing the types of rewards you enjoy the most (and selecting a reward for yourself when you begin planning) can make tasks easier to start and easier to finish.

SKILL AREAS:



PLANNING



SELF
MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Timer
- Paper & Pencil
- Notebook or Sandbox (see Exercise #6)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Begin by finding a quiet place free of distractions. You will need approximately 8-10 minutes to complete this exercise.
2. Draw a vertical line down the center of the page to divide the paper in half. Draw a second, horizontal line to divide the paper into four sections. At the top of each section write the headings:
 - a. INDOOR ACTIVITIES - rewards you enjoy doing indoors when you finish activities.
 - b. OUTDOOR ACTIVITIES - rewards you enjoy doing outside or places you enjoy going when you finish activities.
 - c. RECOGNITION/PRIVILEGES - rewards you enjoy getting from others or things others can do for you
 - d. GOOD THINGS - rewards that happen later on from doing tasks well (e.g. getting good grades, getting a promotion, making family members happy, etc.)
3. Choose one section to brainstorm rewards first. Set the timer for 2 minutes. Before the timer goes off, list as many different rewards in each section that you might enjoy. Rewards can be small or large, and general (watching TV), or specific (watching 5 minutes of cooking shows).
4. Repeat the 2-minute timer for each section of the rewards sheet.
5. Once each section is complete, review each section. Circle the top two rewards in each section that you prefer the most.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

This activity can be done with another person or independently, but it should be completed often. Our preferences for rewarding activities can change, sometimes hour by hour. Before each big project or SMART Goal (see Exercise #1), review the Rewarding Success exercise you created last time or create a new one to identify the best motivation along the way.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

For learners who struggle with short-term rewards vs. waiting for the long-term payoff of completing difficult tasks, Rewarding Success can be a helpful exercise to focus on rewards at different stages. Divide the sheet into time-based sections (e.g. Short-Term Vs. Long-Term; In 1 week, 1 month, 1 year, etc) and create lists to motivate at different stages of a project or goal.



CHAPTER TWO: TIME MANAGEMENT

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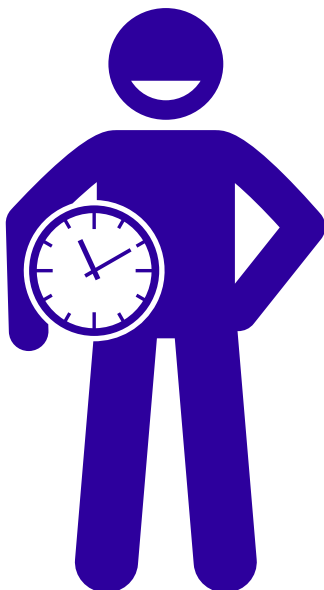


TIME MANAGEMENT

Among all of the resources available to us, time is the great equalizer. We all have the same amount afforded us each day, and no amount of wealth or skill can create more time. That being said, how we manage and utilize our time can make a tremendous difference in our productivity and happiness. It's so important to us that we spend a significant amount of time and effort in learning how to efficiently and effectively manage our time.

According to The Productivity Institute, the average American uses 13 different resources to help manage and control their time (Wetmore, 2018). Teens and young adults with diverse learning needs also need time management skills. Practical time management skills are learned behavior, taught through a variety of different learning experiences as we grow and become more independent.

When working with children, teens, and young adults with unique learning needs, the way we teach time management may look different, but the skills are just as important to overall success.



WHAT ARE TIME MANAGEMENT SKILLS?

Time management refers to a broad set of skills related to understanding time and how to use time effectively. According to leading executive functioning researchers, Dr. Peg Dawson and Dr. Richard Guare (2018), time management skills relate to how we effectively use our time and how that use impacts ourselves and others around us.

Children and adults with good time management skills not only understand how long tasks will take, but they're also able to budget time effectively and complete routines with ease. Time management includes our capacity to estimate time, allocate time, and stay within time limits and deadlines.

WHY ARE TIME MANAGEMENT SKILLS SO IMPORTANT?

Researchers have carefully examined how time management skills, along with other executive functioning skills, relate to academic, vocational, and social success. It's also been well documented that students with diverse learning needs often struggle with time concepts and have poorly developed time management (Manganello, 1994).

Once you understand some of the benefits of time management skills, it becomes clear why parents and teachers pursue ways to teach these skills at home and in the classroom. Children with well-developed time-management skills have higher academic achievement, experience improved economic benefits of stable employment, have a higher quality of life, and improved social relationships.



EXAMPLES OF TIME MANAGEMENT SKILLS

- Identify and understand time concepts (minute, hour, tomorrow, week, month, etc.)
- Complete simple tasks within an allotted amount of time.
- Follow a timeline to finish chores or homework tasks on a deadline.
- Accurately estimate how much time it will take to complete a task.
- Budget and prioritize sufficient time to complete a task.
- Arrive on time for appointments and social activities.
- Create a schedule with sufficient time to complete all necessary activities in a week.
- Increase work speed to complete a deadline but avoids 'rushing around' except on rare occasions.
- Avoids procrastination or putting tasks off to the last minute.

TIME MANAGEMENT AND PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

Not only is time management important for academic, vocational, and social independence, but also deficits in time management can connect closely to a child's challenging behaviors.

Recall the scenario in our introduction chapter of Sam and the late-night homework session:

"On a typical Tuesday evening, it's around 10 pm when Sam finally gets around to doing homework. She's tired and rushes through the project so she can go to sleep. The next day Sam turns in her assignment. Her teacher can see that Sam didn't do her best work, so while her friends get time to talk and text at the end of class, Sam has to keep working."

What might happen if Sam's parents and teachers spent time teaching Sam some of the time management skills in the box to the left? If Sam could follow a timeline of her evening activities, it might give her enough time to enjoy her leisure activities *and* still finish all her homework tasks. If Sam could better estimate how much time it takes to complete tasks, it might also improve how productive she is at home and at school. Less procrastination will also reduce how often Sam's parents Andy and Joan need to intervene.

Here are some questions that might indicate to Sam's parents that the problem behavior they experience with her may be related to time management behaviors:

- Does your child take way too long to complete tasks?
- Is your family regularly late to events or appointments because of waiting for your child?
- Do they frequently miss deadlines, arrive late, or fail to allow enough time to complete tasks?
- Does your child frequently jump into tasks at the wrong point or gather the wrong materials?
- Do you have to remind your child multiple times about an upcoming deadline or provide warnings before an event is about to start?

All of these questions may indicate a need to focus on the executive functioning skill of time management.

SUPPORTING SOMEONE WITH TIME MANAGEMENT CHALLENGES

There's a wide range of skills and abilities when it comes to time management. Evidence supports that all individuals can make progress towards achieving executive functioning goals. We wrote this workbook full of exercises after all! As you work through the pre-assessment and exercises in this chapter, consider some of these additional strategies to build time management success.

STAGE THE ENVIRONMENT FOR A POSITIVE OUTCOME.

Most adults use at least one tool to help manage their time. Collectively we spend thousands of dollars each year on planners, timers, and app-based systems to help us be more efficient and effective with our day. There are hundreds of different tools on the market right now geared towards teens and young adults with unique learning needs, including free options. Investigate low-tech tools like timers, a watch, a calendar, or the planner worksheets in this workbook.

You may also need to stage the physical environment for better time management. For example, if your child struggles to effectively manage time in the morning to arrive at school or work promptly, try staging the environment by storing required 'gear' near the door, so it's easier to complete the routine. Arrange the items in order on a rack or shelves so your child can match their steps to the sequence of objects as they appear.

USE VISUALS

More than likely at some point in your life, you've used a visual tool to help you manage your time. Creating task lists, checklists, visual timelines, and to-do lists are among the most effective long-term time management strategies. Some learners may need visuals created for them over the long term. Once built, though, they're able to move along with tasks

independently. Over time, some learners may be able to generate their lists and visual reminders without assistance. Every child is different, so it may take time to explore which strategies work the best.

USE YOUR CHILD'S INTERESTS

Another long-term strategy to explore is building in your child's interests into time management. We know that motivation and time management are closely tied to the success of teens and young adults. Finding ways to incorporate a child's favorite leisure and recreational activities into teaching time management can be a way to connect the abstract concepts related to executive functioning in more concrete ways.

For example, if your child has challenges estimating how long a task should take or has challenges finishing less preferred jobs in a required time, arrange the task in the context of their favorite music. Let them know that they have one or two songs to finish the task. Or choose one song to listen to every time your child completes a particular activity, like 'the getting ready song' or the 'homework prep song.' When the song is up, your child has a clear signal to move on to the next item.

Does your child have a favorite sports figure, movie character, or celebrity they closely follow? Watch clips and videos online of how these figures use time management successfully. Talk with your child about how time management helps these characters be successful (score more points in a game, accomplish the goal of the plotline in a movie, etc.) and the consequences of what might happen if they don't use time wisely (lose the game, not fulfill a mission, etc.)

GETTING STARTED WITH TIME MANAGEMENT SKILLS

To get started with time management skills, take the pre-assessment on the next page which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child.

Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and plan how you might accomplish your time management-related goal.

TIME MANAGEMENT SKILLS

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the time management exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

1. I'm on time for appointments and family events.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

2. I can accurately estimate how long it will take me to complete a task.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

3. I make a plan for the day that includes everything I need to get done.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

4. I make lists or use a calendar so I know what to do each day.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

5. I complete my daily routines and to-do lists easily.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

6. When I have a lot to do, I can prioritize what tasks to do first.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

7. I understand that when I don't manage my time well, others may be impacted.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For learning to complete tasks within a specific time

13 16 18

For learning to use time management tools like calendars and agendas

14 15 17 19

EXERCISE #13

TIME ESTIMATION

BACKGROUND:

One of the most important steps to learning effective time management skills is to accurately estimate time. Start with everyday tasks and practice determining how long they might take. *Does it take 5 minutes to brush your teeth? Does it take 30 minutes to get to school or work?* To manage and budget time, you must first be able to estimate and understand the length of tasks.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Printable Time Estimation Worksheet (p. 45)
- Timer or stopwatch
- Observer (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Time Estimation Worksheet.
2. Select an activity from our daily routine. Start with something simple that you already know how to complete all of the steps.
3. Write down each step of the task on the worksheet.
4. For each step of the task, estimate how much time it will take you to complete. Then add up the total time that you estimate the task will take.
5. When you're finished estimating the time of the task, then complete the task. Set a timer and record the total amount of time that it takes to complete each step. It can be helpful to have an observer watch you complete each step and record the time.
6. When you're finished with the task, complete the reflection questions at the bottom of the worksheet.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

To learn about time estimation, it works best to first start with tasks that are familiar and easy to complete (e.g. dressing, eating a meal, brushing teeth). When you're consistently estimating these familiar tasks correctly, then move on to more challenging sequences, including homework, a morning routine, or getting to work. These tasks require more focus and there's a greater chance that interruptions and distractions might get in the way. Continue to complete time estimation worksheets until you can estimate 5 different sequences of activities accurately (within two or three minutes of the actual time).

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Time estimation doesn't have to stop with daily living activities and routines. Consider using the time estimation worksheet any time you encounter a new project or large task. By breaking it apart into separate steps (see Task Analysis Exercise #5) and then estimated time you can better plan and budget time into your Weekly Planning Agenda (see Exercise #3).

TIME ESTIMATING WORKSHEET

One of the difficult skills for individuals learning good time management is budgeting how much time a task will take and staying within those time limits. Complete this worksheet by writing out the steps of a task and estimating how long the task will take. Then use a kitchen timer or stopwatch to measure the actual time it took to complete each step of the task. Follow up with the discussion questions below.

MY TASK: _____

STEPS OF MY TASK	ESTIMATED TIME	ACTUAL TIME
TOTAL:		

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Was there a difference between
your estimated time and actual
time?

What did you learn from writing out the steps of the task? Did it make the task easier or more challenging?

What steps can I take to improve how I estimate tasks?

EXERCISE #14

TIME LOG

BACKGROUND:

Do you ever finish the day and wonder to yourself, *where did all that time go?* Or get to the end of another week frustrated that there's so much left to do? Sometimes issues with time management happen not because we didn't budget enough time, but because other things end up getting in the way. The only way to uncover the barriers to getting things done is to explore how you use time in the first place.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print five days of the Daily Time Log sheet (or one for each day you intend to log).
Download and print a copy of the Time Log Summary worksheet.
2. For each activity during the day, complete the daily time log sheet. For each activity during the day, record the start and end time, along with what you were doing. The more accuracy and detail you provide on the daily time log sheets, the easier the summary reflection will be.
3. Repeat the process for several days. We find that it's helpful to record at least 5-7 days of activities and to use a typical week rather than a week with vacation, holidays, big exams or assignments, etc.
4. For each step of the task, estimate how much time it will take you to complete. Then add up the total time that you estimate the task will take.
5. When you're finished with the time logs, summarize the information on the Time Log Summary worksheet. Use the summary to create time management SMART goals (see Exercise #1) or create a progress monitoring program (See Exercise #75) to improve your time management.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise fall less on accurately completing the time logs--although this is important since it informs the analysis--and more on being able to adjust behavior after the time log summary is completed. After completing the time logs, mastery involves making adjustments to the weekly use of time so that a follow-up time analysis shows improvement in time management. Continue to target weekly time logs until meeting the SMART goals towards time management.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

There are many digital and app-based tools for time logging. Many smartphones will automatically log time on different apps, including social media. Consider one of these tools paired with the Time Log Summary to help change your tech-based behaviors.

SKILL AREAS:



TIME MANAGEMENT



SELF
MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Time Daily Time Log (p. 47) and Time Log Summary (p. 48)
- Timer



DAILY TIME LOG

DATE: _____

[illegible]

TIME LOG SUMMARY

CATEGORY ANALYSIS

Tally up the time used in each category on the daily time logs.

What are the top three categories?

1

2

3



Do these categories match with your current SMART goals?

STRENGTHS

How am I managing my time well right now?

BARRIERS

What's getting in the way right now?

What surprised you about the time log?

What disappointed you about the time log?

What might you do differently next time?

Brainstorm 3 ideas for new SMART goals from this time log:

1

2

3

EXERCISE #15

DAILY PLANNING WORKSHEET

BACKGROUND:

While some of us find it easier to manage our time across the week (see Exercise #3), others may find it helpful to break apart planning into a day-by-day agenda. Using this daily agenda, plan out the most important tasks of the day and then use it to track your progress on important goals.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the My Daily Agenda worksheet for each day you intend to plan.
2. Record the date.
3. In the "Today's Schedule" area, begin by creating an outline of the day's tasks in the order they are likely to occur. Record appointments, classes, assignments, and household chores that need to be completed. Estimate how much time it will take and any materials that are necessary to complete the task. Having a plan and time estimation will help you adjust other items around the schedule.
4. After completing the schedule, choose 2-3 items that are "High Priority." These are key things that must be done by the end of the day.
5. Next, plan out meals for the day (See Exercise #10 for Meal Planning strategies). Pre-planning meals can save time and decision-making later on.
6. Make a plan for what chores and exercise activities need to occur during the day.
7. Throughout the day, record daily water consumption and new ideas in the Brainstorming Box.

SKILL AREAS:



TIME MANAGEMENT



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable My Daily Agenda Worksheet (p. 50)

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise include planning the daily agenda independently across multiple days. Some learners may need assistance with identifying all tasks and determining high-priority tasks. If meals, chores, and physical activity are planned for the learner, mastery would include recruiting that information.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Daily Agenda can be used in combination with many of the other tools in this workbook. For individuals who would rather plan at the end of the day, try out the End of the Day Checklist (Exercise #32). Use these worksheets during the Weekly Planning Meeting (Exercise #3). Place important materials needed for daily tasks in Designated Places (Exercise #29).



MY DAILY AGENDA

TODAY'S DATE:

MEALS



BREAKFAST

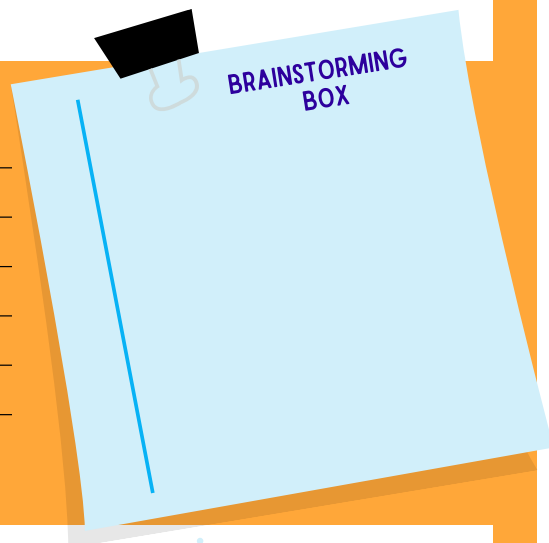
LUNCH

DINNER

SNACKS

HIGH PRIORITY

TODAY'S SCHEDULE

[illegible]

CHORES



EXERCISE

WATER



Eight circles are arranged in two rows of four. Each circle contains a square. The squares are oriented such that their sides are parallel to the horizontal and vertical axes. The circles are arranged in a grid-like pattern.

EXERCISE #16

PACE YOURSELF

BACKGROUND:

For some learners, time management goes well as long as there are no surprises. But when extra work gets piled on or things get messy, it can be difficult to manage the stress. In this exercise, you'll practice sorting different items into bins within a certain amount of time. After practicing a few times, your work level will suddenly change. Understanding how your body responds when you need to speed up and slow down your work pace in this simulated sorting task can make a big difference in learning how you effectively manage time in the face of real-life changes.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Gather the materials for this activity, including downloading and printing a copy of the Pace Yourself Reflection worksheet.
2. Set out 15 items and the timer for 30 seconds. Practice sorting these 15 items into the bins until you are comfortable with the pace and workload.
3. Complete Part A of the Pace Yourself Reflection about how you approach time management.
4. When comfortable, now practice what it's like to have work removed from your workload unexpectedly. Again set the timer for 30 seconds. During this trial, your observer will remove half of your remaining items to sort.
5. Complete Part B of the Pace Yourself Reflection about how you approach time management when you have plenty of time.
6. Next, practice what it's like to manage your time when you're distracted. Set the timer for 30 seconds and set out all 30 items to sort. This time, your partner/observer tries everything they can to distract your attention from the task.
7. Complete Part C of the Pace Yourself Reflection about how you approach time management when you have to work with distractions or challenging conditions.
8. Next, practice what it's like to have work added to your workload unexpectedly. Again, set the timer for 30 seconds. During this trial, your observer will add 15 more items to your workload unpredictably. The goal is to still finish before the timer. Complete this step several more times. Each time the observer adds items unpredictably, mixing up adding them at the beginning, middle, end of the trial.
9. Complete Part D of the Pace Yourself Reflection about how you approach time management when your workload grows.

SKILL AREAS:



TIME MANAGEMENT



SELF
MONITORING



FLEXIBILITY

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Timer
- 30 Household objects that can be easily sorted (office supplies, clothing, flash cards, etc.)
- 5-7 containers for sorting
- Partner/Observer
- Pace Yourself Reflection Worksheet (p.53)

MASTERY CRITERIA:

The Pace Yourself exercise can be a powerful teaching tool to incorporate in any executive functioning training program. Even though it's a simulation, it can help inform us about how we respond to changes in our workload and where we can improve.

Mastery of this activity includes completing the exercise and identifying 1-2 areas of behavior change or SMART goals resulting from the Pace Yourself Reflection Worksheet. Complete each trial as many times as needed to clarify these goals.



EXPANSION IDEAS:

This exercise can be modified and changed to support different learners. While the task here is a simple sorting simulation, it can be adapted and modified to target areas of need for a particular learner. Try using math problems, household chores, or reading tasks for teens and young adults that struggle with time management of academic and daily living skills. This activity can also be adapted for vocational skills if a learner needs practice with time management at work. Pace Yourself can also be combined with a Daily or Weekly Agenda, allowing the partner/observer to throw in unpredictable tasks to practice flexibility and emotional control.

PACE YOURSELF REFLECTION

Date:

PART A: BASIC TIME MANAGEMENT

REFLECTION: What was this activity like?

Do you like knowing how much you have to do and how much time you have to finish it?

How do you know if you are pacing yourself correctly?

What does this tell me about how you manage time?

PART B: WHEN YOU HAVE PLENTY OF TIME

REFLECTION: What was this activity like? How was it different from Part A?

Do you tend to slow down your work when you have plenty of time, or keep working quickly so you have free time in the end?

What does this tell you about how you could manage your time differently when you have fewer things to do?

PART C: WHEN DISTRACTIONS GET IN THE WAY

REFLECTION: What was this activity like? How was it different from Part A and Part B?

What does it feel like in your body when you're distracted from your work?

Are some distractions easier than others to manage?

What strategies did you use to manage the distractions?

What does this tell you about how you could manage your time better when faced with distractions?

PART D: WHEN THERE'S MORE WORK TO DO

REFLECTION: What was this activity like? How was it different from the others?

What does it feel like in your body when you had more work added? At the beginning vs. at the end?

How did you know if you were pacing yourself correctly when you had to adjust?

What strategies did you use to manage the changes?

What does this tell you about working under pressure or working faster to finish on time?

EXERCISE #17

THE JUGGLER

BACKGROUND:

Time management gets more difficult with the more tasks and demands we have to handle at one time. When we need to keep multiple projects and deadlines moving forward, while still managing our daily living activities like meal planning (see Exercise #10) and household chores, it can feel like we're juggling with fire. Creating timelines is one strategy to improve how you juggle multiple tasks at once and more effectively manage your time.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Timelines Worksheet for each project you are currently juggling. Timelines worksheets are most effective for projects that have multiple stages and will take several weeks to complete.
2. Record the start date and deadline of the project.
3. Divide up the project into steps. For each step, write down a header and a simple description in the box. Write a tentative deadline for when the step needs to be completed.
4. Repeat the worksheet for each project.
5. Compare timelines to determine which tasks you need to complete first and what steps should be the priority.

SKILL AREAS:



TIME MANAGEMENT

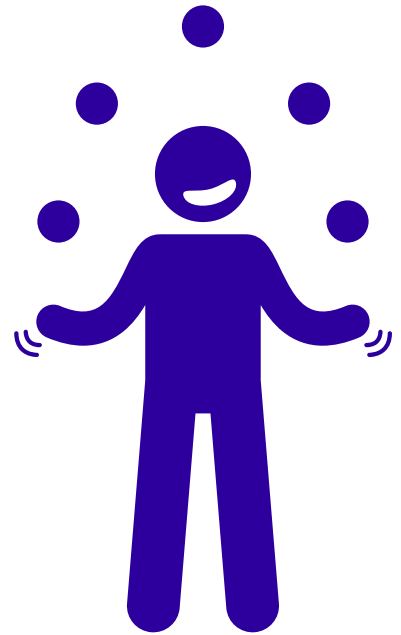


PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Timelines Worksheet (p. 55)



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise include using the timelines to successfully accomplish at least two different projects at one time. Once you've mastered two projects, create timelines for three or four projects at once.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Timelines can be brought into the Weekly Planning Meeting (see Exercise #3) or the Daily Planning Agenda to help you better keep track of multiple activities at once.

PROJECT TIMELINE

PROJECT:
START DATE:
TARGET END DATE:

Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:



Task:

Deadline:

PROJECT COMPLETED:

EXERCISE #18

LATE LOG

BACKGROUND:

If you've already established SMART Goals (see Exercise #1) around time management, it's important to know when you're making progress towards those goals. One way to know if your hard work at improving time management is paying off is to log when deadlines are missed. This exercise prepares a visual graph of running late and missed deadlines so as your time management skills improve you can visually see the progress.

SKILL AREAS:



TIME MANAGEMENT



SELF
MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Late Log Tally Sheet (p. 57)
- Printable Weekly Late Log Graphing Worksheet (p. 58)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Late Log Tally Sheet and the Weekly Late Log Graphing Worksheet.
2. Write the dates on the Late Log Tally Sheet for the week.
3. Place the Late Log Tally Sheet in a location where you'll remember to log each missed deadline or each time you're late during the day. It can be helpful to complete this at the end of the day or at a specific time with a trusted friend.
4. Each day in the first column of the Late Log Tally Sheet, mark a tally with the number of times you miss a deadline you set for yourself or set by someone else during the day. In the second column, mark a tally with the number of times you're late to an activity.
5. Repeat the Late Log Tally Sheet for each day of the week.
6. At the end of the week, add up the total number of tallies in each column. Using the Weekly Late Log Graphing Worksheet, graph the first week of missed deadlines and instances of running late.
7. Repeat Steps 2-6 for five additional weeks, noticing any patterns or challenges that you encounter meeting the goal.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise include using the timelines to successfully accomplish at least two different projects at one time. Once you've mastered two projects, create timelines for three or four projects at once.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Graphing executive functioning behaviors can be an important tool to monitor your success. If this activity is helpful, consider graphing other behaviors like on-task behavior (see Exercise #14), completing an organization routine (see Exercise #33), or sleep habits (see Exercise #63).

LATE LOG TALLY SHEET

WEEK OF:


Mo

DATE	NUMBER OF LATE DEADLINES	NUMBER OF LATE DEADLINES	DAILY TOTAL


Tu

--	--	--	--


We

--	--	--	--


Th

--	--	--	--


Fr

--	--	--	--


Sa

--	--	--	--


Su

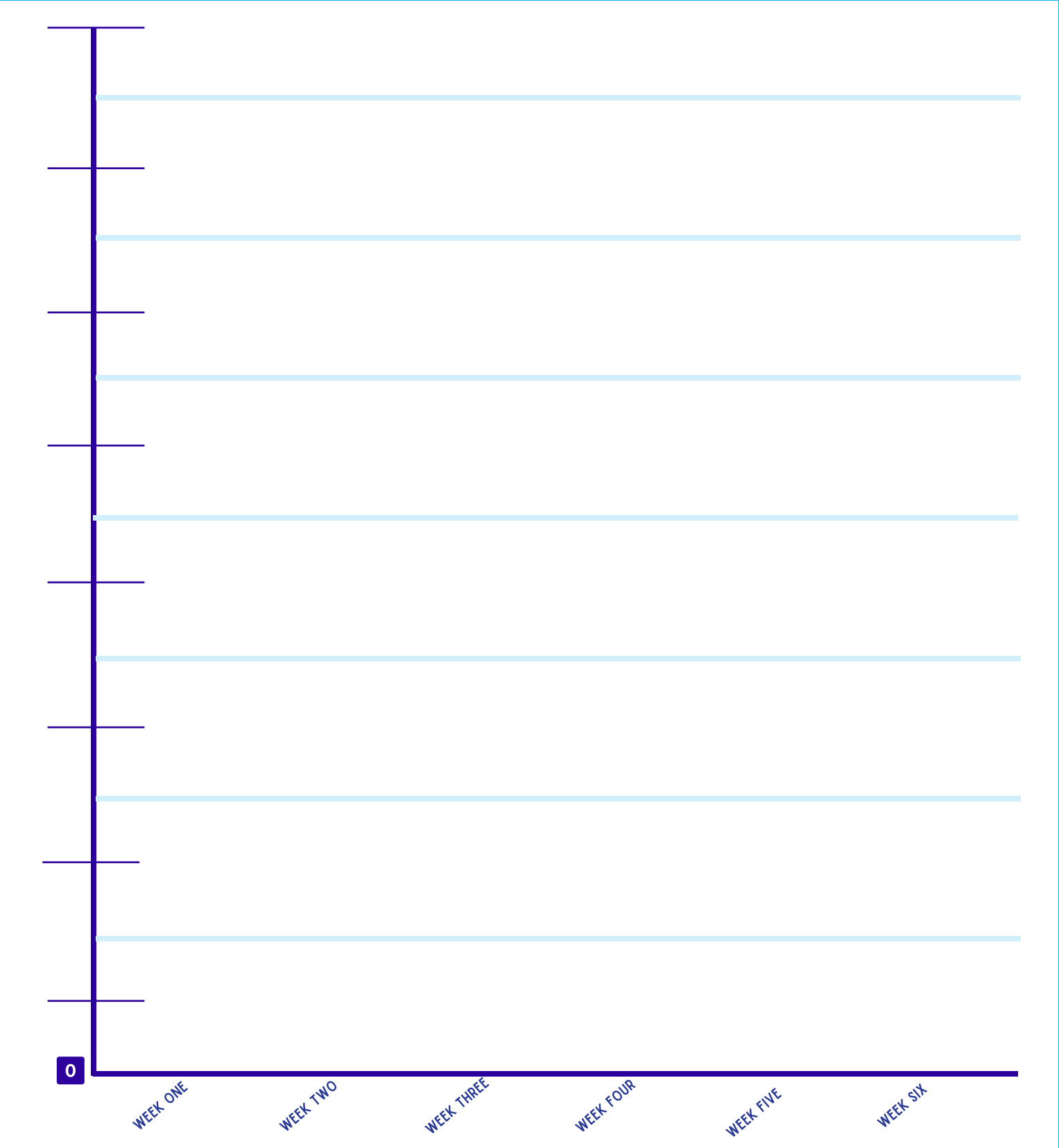
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WEEKLY TOTALS:

--	--	--

GRAPHING SHEET

BEHAVIOR 1:
BEHAVIOR 2:



EXERCISE #19

FUN PLANNER

BACKGROUND:

What's the best part of better time management skills? There's more time left over to have FUN! When you've done all the hard work to achieve your goals and better use your time, you'll be surprised at how much extra time you have for activities you enjoy like hobbies, spending time with friends, and relaxing. One way to motivate yourself to work hard at better time management is to know what you'll do with the extra free time. By planning out the end result of your achievements you know what's waiting at the finish line.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Open the notebook or your Sandbox to a clean, fresh sheet of paper.
2. Set the timer for 3 minutes. Before the timer goes off, write down as many different ideas for how you like to have fun, relax, and spend your free time.
3. Set the timer for 1 more minute to brainstorm additional ideas. During each minute, choose a length of time to capture on your fun planner. Brainstorm 1 minute for ideas that take less than five minutes like watching a video clip online. Then brainstorm 1 minute for fun activities that take 10-30 minutes like going for a walk or playing with a pet. Finally, brainstorm ideas for how you like to enjoy an afternoon, a free day like going for a long bike ride.
4. When the final timer goes off, review your list. Put it in a safe place (or mark a note in your Sandbox) to reference later. When you need the motivation to complete an activity or when you're completing your Weekly Planning Meeting (see Exercise #3), use the fun planning list you created to add in special ways to spend the time you save being more productive.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise involve establishing a list of fun activities and ways to spend the free time you enjoy. Some learners may need support brainstorming new and fun ideas to add to this list. It's a great activity to complete with a friend or family member.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Fun planning can be done with any of the exercises in this workbook. Look over your list of fun or create a new list each time you're working on a new executive functioning skill to keep your motivation level high.

SKILL AREAS:



TIME MANAGEMENT



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Notebook or Sandbox (see Exercise #6)
- Timer





CHAPTER THREE: TASK INITIATION

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TASK INITIATION

In our ever-changing digital world, we hear the same pleas from hundreds of parents and teachers, *“I feel like I’m giving hundreds of reminders every day. Why on earth is it so hard to **Just. Get. Started?**”*

We demand more from teens and young adults than ever before. When we demand it in an environment with more distractions than we can count, challenges with task initiation become even more apparent. In truth, all parents navigate some amount of stalling, delay tactics, and the occasional need for prompting. And although we want our kids to rush off to complete their chores, homework, and work responsibilities without reminders, we know that sometimes parenting requires those gentle reminders to help our children succeed. But raising teens and young adults that struggle with task initiation can be one of the most challenging and frustrating aspects of parenting.

For decades researchers have studied how individuals with unique learning needs show differences in executive functioning skills like task initiation (Dawson & Guare, 2018; Kenworthy, et al., 2008). These differences in the ability to get started with tasks can translate into challenges with various daily living skills and social relationships. Therefore, parents need to understand how task initiation skills relate to a child's learning and independence.



WHAT ARE TASK INITIATION SKILLS?

Task initiation involves a child’s ability to initiate and independently start a task. It can include various skills, including independently generating ideas, solving problems, and responding to instructions without needing others’ support. Along with time management and planning, task

initiation is considered one of the core executive functioning skills and can be problematic for many children with ASD and attention-related diagnoses. Teens and young adults with task initiation issues might:

- Need many reminders from adults to start a task.
- Delay chores and homework until they need to rush to finish on time.
- Frequently ask for help, even with simple tasks.
- Engage in problem behavior to escape or avoid tasks.

HOW TASK INITIATION SKILLS INFLUENCE PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

One of the reasons task initiation related-behaviors can be challenging is that they come in a wide range of profiles. Parents and teachers may have to manage a wide range of behaviors resulting from task avoidance.

We've worked with teens and young adults who use problem behaviors anywhere from excessively chatting about a preferred topic to aggression or self-injury to escape or avoid tasks. Over time, many of these individuals become accustomed to constant adult support to get started. It takes more and more prompting and support to start and finish tasks resulting in an individual increasingly more dependent on adults around them.

WHAT HAPPENS WHEN WE TEACH TASK INITIATION?

By addressing task initiation deficits, individuals get a two-fold benefit. First, they're apt to encounter fewer aversives in the form of 'nagging' parents, redirections, and physical or verbal prompting. And because they complete tasks independently, individuals also likely encounter higher rates of positive reinforcements like praise, success with goals, and tangible reinforcers. The more quickly a child learns to complete tasks, the faster they can move on to preferred activities, ultimately reducing the time everyone spends dealing with problem behavior.



EXAMPLES OF TASK INITIATION SKILLS

- Begins a task within 3 seconds of the instruction.
- Completes familiar daily routines without needing instruction.
- Identifies and gathers the materials necessary to complete a task.
- Completes the final step of one job and moves on to the next job within 30 seconds.
- Responds to a countdown timer to begin a task.
- Independently identifies the starting point for an unfamiliar task.
- Refrains from problem behavior when asked to start a task.
- Leaves a preferred activity to begin a non-preferred activity.
- Understands when to ask for help and when to keep trying to solve a problem independently.

IDENTIFYING TASK INITIATION GOALS

Arguably, task initiation should be one of the first executive functioning skills to focus on because it closely aligns with other skills like planning, time management, and emotional control. If you can't independently get started with tasks, many other related executive functioning behaviors are challenging to teach.

One approach to teaching task initiation is to focus on the skill in the form of task analysis. Task analysis is the process of breaking a larger skill down into component 'sub-tasks and teaching each simpler step as a building block to a larger goal. As the learner accomplishes each smaller milestone, they eventually become more independent at completing the final goal.

Task analysis methods are widely accepted as evidence-based practice (EBP) and used among special education, behavior analysts, and other therapy professionals. Task analyses work well for simple skills like putting on a jacket but more complex behavior goals like task initiation and completion. As an example, review the goals below related to a step-by-step teaching of task initiation. Then, consider how you might adapt this same task initiation skill progression for you or your own learner.

HOW TO TEACH TASK INITIATION

1

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL ONE:

When instructed to begin a preferred task (e.g., turn on screen time, eating a preferred meal, go to a preferred location in the school, etc.), the student will begin the task within 15 seconds.

It may seem counterintuitive to start teaching task analysis with preferred activities. After all, shouldn't teens and young adults *already* follow instructions when it leads to something fun?

Unfortunately, that's not always the case, especially for learners who have a long history of failing to respond to adult instructions. We've worked with clients with a long behavioral history of escape-maintained problem behaviors. Even when instructed to do something they prefer, they may still refuse simply because an adult asked them. For these learners, beginning to teach task initiation may need to start with accepting an instruction to have fun.

2

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL TWO:

When given an instruction to begin a familiar task and provided with visual supports and adult prompting, the student will begin the task within 15 seconds.

The key to the next goal in the task initiation task analysis is ‘familiar.’ Choose a task that the learner finds neutral, neither preferred nor aversive. Notice that this goal also includes assistance built into the plan. Some learners may find task initiation tasks easier with adult support or the use of visuals. Creating a sub-task into the task analysis that includes these prompts keeps the learner on track and thriving.

3

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL THREE:

With the use of visual supports or adult prompting, when given a non-preferred task, the student will begin the task within 30 seconds without engaging in problem behavior or refusal.

A next step in the task analysis for task initiation skills might move now to non-preferred tasks: homework, household chores, daily living routines, meal preparation. Identify the tasks that most consistently create struggles or problem behavior for your learner and target those in order of least to most difficult. Notice that in this sample goal, the allowed time for task initiation was modified slightly. Some learners may need additional time as the tasks get increasingly more challenging.

4

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL FOUR:

Without adult prompting, when given a non-preferred task, the student will begin the task within 30 seconds without engaging in problem behavior or refusal.

Now we’ve reached the point in the task analysis where the learner has made progress towards independent task initiation. In this stage, the learner can complete a wide range of instructions—fun and not-so-fun—whenever adults ask. At this point parents and teachers start to see meaningful changes in problem behavior as well. The learner also should experience some significant changes, including more free time and more choices throughout the day since tasks that use to take longer are less challenging now.

5

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL FIVE:

When engaged in a preferred activity, the student will leave the desired activity to complete a non-preferred or daily routine task.

This is the ultimate step for many teens and young adults who struggle with executive functioning skills. Set aside the video game to do homework. Leave your friend's house to complete household chores. We all have points in life where the fun comes to an end. To recognize and independently leave these enjoyable activities is difficult. For some learners, multiple sub-tasks might need to be built into this step, including using a visual reminder to leave a preferred activity, or starting with adult prompting and fading support until independent.

6

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL SIX:

When given a new or unfamiliar task, the student will identify the initial step to get started and will begin the task within 1 minute.

For some learners, task initiation is not problematic when the tasks are known. However, if a new task or change in routine occurs, they now struggle to know where to begin. Even though our learner is doing well with various tasks at this point, he or she may need practice with 'learning to learn something new.'

7

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL SEVEN:

When given up to five different tasks, the student will identify the best order to complete tasks and begin each task within 1 minute of concluding the previous one.

What if your learner encounters choices between tasks? Do they understand how to order assignments properly if the sequence matters? Are they able to make a choice and set priorities? These higher-level goals in the task analysis start to add in elements of other executive functioning behaviors like planning, time management, and organization. Many of the exercises in this chapter and throughout the workbook can be useful in teaching this skill.

8

TASK INITIATION TASK ANALYSIS

GOAL EIGHT:

When the student has difficulty initiating a task, the student identifies the problem and seeks out the right resource to obtain help without getting frustrated or engaging in problem behavior.

Not all situations will work out correctly for your learner. Knowing how to move past those frustrations and still successfully get started on a task closely aligns with other executive functioning skills like problem-solving, flexibility, and emotional control. Take a look at the exercises in these chapters for more information about how you can combine these skills while teaching task initiation.

INDIVIDUALIZE. CUSTOMIZE. PRIORITIZE.

The goals provided above are just one example of how you might gradually begin to teach task initiation. Hundreds of possibilities exist within these goals to customize and individualize for your learner. Some learners might only need support with a few of these goals. Others might need each plan broken apart into further sub-goals.

Finally, it's important for learners who struggle with task initiation and other executive functioning skills to prioritize critical behaviors first. Focus on building your task analysis around instructions that cause you and the learner the most stress and challenges. Prioritize the areas of your teen or young adult's life that can help them be more communicative, more social, or experience greater independence.

GETTING STARTED WITH TASK INITIATION SKILLS

To get started with these skills and goals, take the pre-assessment on the next page which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child.

Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and plan your first task initiation goal.

TASK INITIATION SKILLS

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify areas of concern and brainstorm goals to build your task initiation skills.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

Procrastination is usually not a problem for me.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I know how to get started with most tasks.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I like to start chores and homework right away.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can set aside a fun activity when I have something more important to complete first.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I easily finish tasks, even ones I don't want to do.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can complete daily tasks without reminders from parents or teachers.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I know how to choose the most important task.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For learning strategies to get started faster.

20 22 27

For understanding why task initiation is important

23 25

For help getting "unstuck" or working through barriers to getting started

21 24 26

EXERCISE #20

TOPIC SELECTOR

BACKGROUND:

When it comes to writing papers and completing large research-based projects, one of the biggest barriers to getting started is choosing a topic. Once we have an idea, it's easy to plan out steps and organize, but narrowing it down to the key ideas can be tricky. Use a step-by-step formula in this exercise to narrow all your brainstorming ideas into a distinct and easy-to-manage topic.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Topic Selector worksheet. Find a quiet, distraction-free environment to complete this exercise, and do your best to avoid electronics. It's easy to waste time in a search engine rabbit hole while narrowing a topic.
2. At the top of the worksheet, write in your assignment or broad project idea. This box now holds all possible topics related to the main idea.
3. In the next box, narrow that topic into three ideas or possible options for sub-topics. Concentrate on what you find most interesting or unique about the main project idea.
4. Copy each idea into a pyramid. Begin working your way down the pyramid boxes for the three main ideas, narrowing them into even smaller topics. Identify questions you have about the sub-topics that interest you or questions that others have not yet answered about that topic.
5. When you've narrowed up each topic as much as possible, review your original main idea or research question. Select the topic that best answers the question and write your research question(s).

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Successfully narrowing down a topic takes practice. Some learners may need multiple examples or assistance in completing the Topic Selector worksheet initially. Continue using the worksheet until formulating narrow, easy-to-organize ideas can be done without support from others.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Once you have your narrow topic, combine this worksheet with other exercises in this workbook to get your paper or project done on time. Review the outline in a Weekly Planning Meeting (See Exercise #3), gather materials to complete the research (See Exercise #49) and use attention strategies to stay focused while working (see Chapter 10).

SKILL AREAS:



TASK INITIATION



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Easy

MATERIALS:

- Printable Topic Selector Worksheet (p.69)

TOPIC SELECTOR

ASSIGNMENT/MAIN IDEA:

What is the main topic, assignment or question to answer?

3 IDEAS:

Generate three narrower ideas you have about this topic:

1

2

3

NARROW IT DOWN:

1

2

3

MY TOPIC:

MY NEXT STEP:

TOPIC SELECTOR (SAMPLE WORKSHEET)

ASSIGNMENT/MAIN IDEA:

What is the main topic, assignment or question to answer?

Assignment: Write a three-page research paper on a strategy to mitigate climate change.

3 IDEAS:

Generate three narrower ideas you have about this topic:

- 1 Eating less meat
- 2 Alternative Energy
- 3 Greener Transportation Options

NARROW IT DOWN:

1 Eating less meat

Plant-Based Diets

What are alternative proteins?

Traits of successful plant-based meat substitutes

2 Alternative Energy

Wind Power

Off-shore wind turbines

Countries with the best off-shore wind programs

3 Greener Transportation

Green public transportation in cities

High Speed Rail Between Cities

Developing a High Speed Rail Line from Minneapolis to Chicago

MY TOPIC:

The advantages and disadvantages of developing a high-speed rail route from Minneapolis to Chicago.

MY NEXT STEP:

Draft an outline.

EXERCISE #21

PEP TALK

BACKGROUND:

When you've had a difficult day or just don't have the motivation to get started on a project, sometimes all you need is a little pep talk to get yourself moving. The best person to give yourself a boost or a reminder of why you're working hard to achieve your goals is yourself. Record a reminder to yourself and save it for whenever you need that extra push to get started.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Pen and Paper
- Smartphone/Tablet with a video camera feature.
- Friend (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Find a quiet, distraction-free environment to brainstorm ideas for your video. What do you want to say to yourself when you need to get started on a project? What words might be helpful to you if you're stuck? If you're feeling sad or frustrated with a project? What reminders can you give yourself about your goals and why they are important?
2. Write down three to four ideas you'll tell yourself in the pep talk video.
3. Position yourself in front of the camera (or have a friend hold the camera to record) and record a short 1-2 minute video giving yourself a pep talk. Focus on saying what will help you get started. Videos can be funny, serious, or a little of both.
4. Save your video to a smartphone or tablet to watch whenever you need a boost or a reminder why it's so important to get started.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

The mastery criteria for this exercise comes down to getting started. Use your pep talk video any time you need a boost (and then make sure you get started on your task!)

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If reminders like this pep talk help you stay on track, record other videos to help you meet your executive functioning goals.

Building in recordings into your SMART goals (See Exercise #1) can be a fun way to keep the motivation up.

EXERCISE #22

COUNTDOWN

BACKGROUND:

One of the classic tools that parents use to help children transition between activities is a warning. The "in five more minutes..." warning is so popular among parents and teachers in part because it's so effective. So why then do we stop using it when learners get older? In fact, if we establish a habit of implementing a 'countdown' timer to prep for work periods, we can make transitions a breeze, even to task we might not enjoy.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Determine the task you need to start next from your task analysis (see Exercise #4) or checklist.
2. Set the timer for two minutes and remind yourself either silently or out loud with a statement like "In two minutes I'm going to find everything I need to start ____."
3. Start the timer. When the two minutes end, set the timer again. Remind yourself either silently or out loud with a statement like, "In two minutes, I'll have everything I need to start ____."
4. Start the timer again. This time, begin searching for all of the materials necessary to complete the task. If the task doesn't require materials, begin making your way to the area where the task needs to be completed.
5. When the timer goes off the second time, begin the task.
6. Practice the two different timers for a set of five different activities. Then practice the two timers for all important activities in a day. Then, practice the countdown across a week to establish the habit of getting started on the cue.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

The key to this exercise is establishing the habit of getting started on the cue of the timer. If you've practiced getting started immediately after the timer chimes, it should become more like a habit with enough time and with enough activities. Continue practicing with the countdown timers with easy activities and build up to using it on days when it's challenging to get started with nearly all activities.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Many app-based tools can make this countdown exercise run more smoothly and with automation. For example, try out different timers, build in visuals, or use in tandem with the Pep Talk (see Exercise #21).

SKILL AREAS:

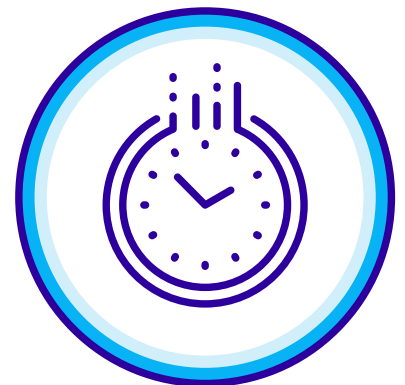


TASK INITIATION

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Timer



EXERCISE #23

FIRST/THEN

BACKGROUND:

For some learners, task initiation becomes more difficult because of prioritizing which task should come first. Some tasks are deadline-sensitive and should take priority. Other times, we can pick and choose which tasks to complete without any real consequences. Use the first/then flashcard activity below to help your learner identify and prioritize which task to initiate first.

SKILL AREAS:



TASK INITIATION

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to Moderate

MATERIALS:

- First/Then Printable Flashcards (p. 72)
- A partner, friend or small group

INSTRUCTIONS (ACTIVITY ONE):

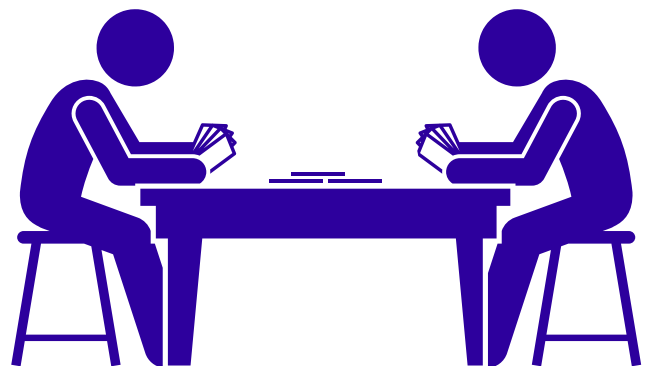
1. Print and cut out a set of the First/Then Flashcards (p. 72).
2. Place the flashcards face down in a stack in the middle of the table.
3. One person selects two cards from the deck and presents these to the other with a choice for which task to initiate first.
4. Ask the partner to explain why one task is more important to begin than the other.

INSTRUCTIONS (ACTIVITY TWO):

1. Lay all the flashcards from the First/Then Printable Flashcard set out face down on the table.
2. Take turns having each player flip over two, three, or four different task cards.
3. On each turn, have the player explain why one task is more important to begin than the others.
4. If others disagree, talk about the benefits or consequences of initiating the tasks in that particular order.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this objective may depend on your experience with completing some of the tasks in the deck. For learners who still need adult support, start with tasks that have an obvious first choice (e.g., complete a school project due tomorrow vs. watch a movie with friends). Then move to two tasks where it's less obvious (e.g., wash the dishes vs. take out the trash). Finally, use the blank flashcards to create your own tasks related to your daily routine.



EXPANSION IDEAS:

If player-based exercises and activities like First/Then Flashcards work well to learn new skills, expand by creating a deck of flashcards for organization activities (see Chapter 4), for social stories and developing emotional control (see Chapter 8), and for tasks related to self-monitoring (see Chapter 11).

TASK INITIATION

FIRST/THEN FLASHCARDS

ACTIVITY ONE:

1. Print and cut out a set of the first/then flashcards.
2. Select two cards from the deck and present your learner with a choice for which task to initiate first.
3. Ask your learner to explain why one task is more important to begin than the other.
4. Start with tasks that have an obvious first choice (e.g. complete a school project due tomorrow vs. watch a movie with friends). Then move to two tasks where it's less obvious (e.g. wash the dishes vs. take out the trash). Finally, expand to having the learner prioritize three, four, and five different tasks.

ACTIVITY TWO:

1. Print and cut out a set of the first/then flashcards.
2. Lay all the flashcards out face down on the table.
3. Take turns having each learner flip over two, three, or four different task cards.
4. On each turn, have the participant explain why one task is more important to begin than the others.
5. If others in the group disagree, talk about the benefits or consequences of initiating the tasks in that particular order.



**PIZZA WITH
FRIENDS**



**FINISH A HOMEWORK
ASSIGNMENT DUE IN
ONE MONTH**



**FINISH A HOMEWORK
ASSIGNMENT DUE
TOMORROW**



FEED YOUR PET



GO TO WORK



WASH DISHES



PLAY A VIDEO GAME



**GO TO A FRIEND'S
PARTY**



GO GROCERY SHOPPING



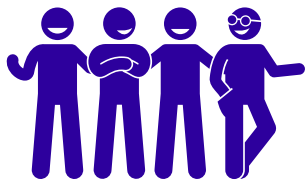
COOK A MEAL



DO LAUNDRY



TAKE A SHOWER



**HANG OUT
WITH FRIENDS**



EXERCISE



HAVE A SNACK



LISTEN TO MUSIC



FAMILY TIME



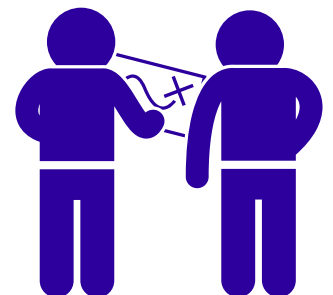
BRUSH TEETH



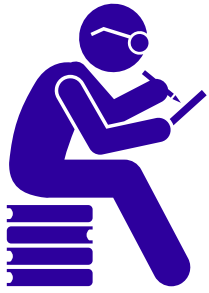
**TAKE OUT THE
TRASH**



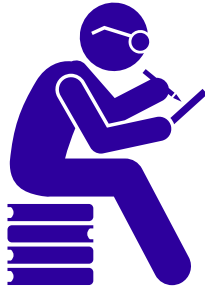
BUY A GIFT



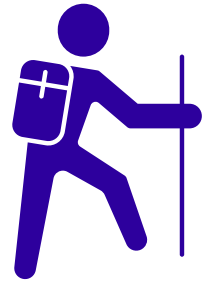
GET DIRECTIONS



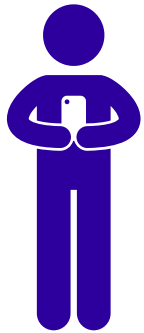
**STUDY FOR A TEST
TOMORROW**



**STUDY FOR A TEST
NEXT WEEK**



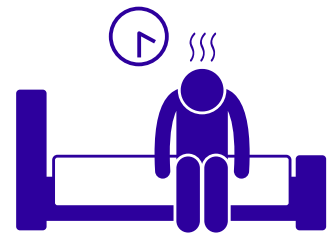
GO FOR A HIKE



TEXT A FRIEND



**GET READY FOR
SCHOOL**



GO TO BED

EXERCISE #24

PROCRASTINATION STATION

BACKGROUND:

Now more than ever, hundreds of distractions can get in the way of us getting started. Do you know what derails your concentration? What stops your projects from cruising forward down the tracks? Spending some time reflecting on how and why we get distracted can help break down the barrier of procrastination and help us get the train rolling in the right direction.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. At the end of a week, download and print the Procrastination Station Worksheet.
2. Spend several minutes reviewing any important tasks that did not get completed this week. Then, complete the reflection question to determine what barriers were in the way.
3. Review the distractions or reasons for procrastination and estimate how much time could be saved if the distractions were eliminated.
4. Write a SMART goal (see Exercise #1) for the upcoming week to reduce or eliminate the distractions.
5. During the next week, attempt to meet your goal and keep the train cars on track. Check off each day of the week when tasks moved forward toward your goal.
6. At the end of the week, download and print a new Procrastination Station Worksheet. Repeat Steps 2-5 for the upcoming week.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Continue completing steps 2-6 each week until the common barriers and distractors that get in the way of starting and finishing tasks can be easily avoided. Work with family members and friends to identify and prioritize the distractions that create the largest barriers first.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

After meeting the outlined mastery criteria, Procrastination Station is a helpful exercise to complete three or four times per year as 'check-ins' with yourself. New barriers and reasons to procrastinate will continue to emerge as our responsibilities change and evolve. Continue to monitor your attention and progress on procrastination over time using the Late Log (see Exercise #18).

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Procrastination Station Worksheet (p.77).
- Printable SMART Goal Worksheet (p. 14)



PROCRASTINATION STATION



IDENTIFY THE TASKS:

What were the biggest tasks or deadlines that I didn't accomplish this week?

IDENTIFY THE DISTRACTIONS:

What were the main reasons these tasks didn't get finished?
What are my biggest reasons for procrastination?

Estimate how much time would be saved or added each week without these distractions or reasons for procrastination.

1	_____	+	_____	minutes
2	_____	+	_____	minutes
3	_____	+	_____	minutes
4	_____	+	_____	minutes
5	_____	+	_____	minutes

MY SMART GOAL



KEEPING THE TRAIN ON TRACK

Check off each day when you keep the train rolling towards the SMART goal and avoid procrastination.

	DAY 1	DAY 2	DAY 3	DAY 4	DAY 5	DAY 6	DAY 7
	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

NOTES:

EXERCISE #25

THE DAWDLER

BACKGROUND:

No one likes The Dawdler. That person who never seems to care about how long anything takes or if there's a room full of people waiting patiently for them. Dawdling, missing deadlines, or rushing around doesn't just make us late; it can also negatively impact others. Practicing what it's like on both sides of procrastination--the consequences for us and others--can help us stay more accountable for our own behavior and avoid being The Dawdler.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of The Dawdler role play ideas. Then, cut each scenario apart and place them in a draw pile.
2. Pull a role-play card from the deck. Determine who will play the role of "The Dawdler" and the other character in the story.
3. Practice the role play. The Dawdler should choose several common reasons for procrastination (e.g., social media, not having items prepared, talking too much, moving too slow, etc.) as the reason for Dawdling in the scenario.
4. After the role-play, review the reflection questions. Then, try the role play again, this time with "The Dawdler," using good task initiation skills. Finally, reflect on what's different about the two scenarios.
5. Pull another role play card from the deck and switch roles, allowing the first Dawdler to experience what it's like to be on the other side. Complete the reflection questions again, this time with roles reversed.
6. Continue rehearsing scenarios from the deck, or write and practice your own ideas.

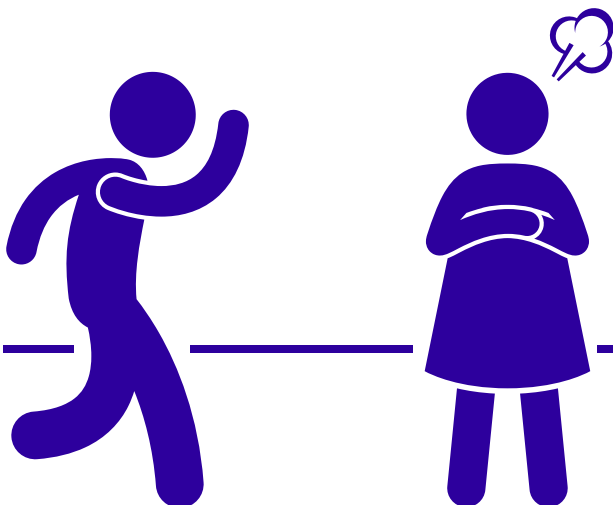
SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Easy

MATERIALS:

- Printable .pdf download of The Dawdler role play ideas (p. 79)
- A partner/friend to role play with



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Continue completing role-play scenarios until it's easy to answer the reflection questions on The Dawdler sheet.

Mastery includes avoiding dawdling that negatively impacts others throughout the week. Asking a friend or family member to provide feedback can be helpful.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If role-play and rehearsal with a friend helps with learning executive functioning skills, try creating a deck of role-play cards for other skills. Nearly all of the exercises in this workbook can be first modeled or practiced within a role play.

THE DAWDLER

ROLE PLAY IDEA CARDS

ACTIVITY

1. Cut each scenario apart and place them in a draw pile.
2. Pull a role-play card from the deck. Determine who will play the role of "The Dawdler" and the other character in the story.
3. Practice the role play. The Dawdler should choose several common reasons for procrastination (e.g., social media, not having items prepared, talking too much, moving too slow, etc.) as the reason for Dawdling in the scenario.
4. After the role-play, review the reflection questions. Try the role play again, this time with "The Dawdler," using good task initiation skills. Reflect on what's different about the two scenarios.
5. Pull another role play card from the deck and switch roles, allowing the first Dawdler to experience what it's like to be on the other side. Then, complete the reflection questions again, this time with roles reversed.
6. Continue rehearsing scenarios from the deck, or write and practice your own ideas.

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- What was the distraction or reason The Dawdler was behind in this scenario?
- If you were The Dawdler, how does it feel? How did you think your partner felt? How could you tell they felt that way?
- If you were the person waiting, how did it feel? What did you wish The Dawdler would do differently?
- What might happen if this scenario were to continue for another 5 minutes?
- What might happen if this scenario happened every day? What might the consequences be for The Dawdler and others?
- What would you do differently?
- Now practice what you might do differently and answer the questions again.



MEETING FRIENDS FOR PIZZA	GETTING READY FOR WORK	CATCHING A BUS
TURNING IN A PROJECT	COOKING DINNER	GETTING READY FOR BED
PACKING FOR A TRIP	GOING FOR A WALK	EATING BREAKFAST
GETTING OUT OF BED IN THE MORNING	LEAVING THE HOUSE FOR SCHOOL	CREATE YOUR OWN: _____

EXERCISE #26

STUCK IN THE MUD

BACKGROUND:

Once you have tested several of the strategies in this task initiation chapter or other exercises in *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*, you may find some helpful at times when you get "stuck in the mud" or don't know how to move forward with a project. At those times, it can be helpful to organize your strategies in one place, so it's easy to find the right tool at the right time. Each time you find yourself stuck, open up your vision board and choose one of the tools.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Begin by making a list of the four or five primary areas of your life where you find yourself frequently "stuck in the mud." These areas might include home, school, friends and family, work, or finances.
2. Open the file folder and lay it out flat.
3. Segment out the folder into the primary areas you identified on your list by drawing lines or cutting and gluing different colored papers. Label each area.
4. Under each area, identify strategies that you've found most effective in those areas to get unstuck or move forward. Write keywords, draw pictures, or cut out images to serve as reminders in each area.
5. In the file folder, place additional copies of key worksheets and printables that you use regularly.
6. Each time you're "stuck in the mud," take out your vision board and select a strategy that you've already identified as helpful.
7. In the future, when you identify a new useful tool, add it to the list and folder.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Vision boards can be completed once or can be working archives added to or subtracted from as needed. Work to develop an initial 'stuck in the mud' vision board, and then continue to use it until you can easily select a strategy to move forward.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner finds the planning strategies vision board helpful, consider creating a file folder vision board for other executive functioning skills like planning (see Exercise #2), organization (see Exercise #31), and emotional control (see Exercise #51).

SKILL AREAS:



TASK INITIATION



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate

MATERIALS:

- File folder
- Basic art materials (markers, scissors, glue, tape, etc.)
- Printable worksheets from *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*



EXERCISE #27

WORKING BACKWARDS

BACKGROUND:

Sometimes we struggle to get started with tasks because we're not sure about the next steps. We might know the end goal, but it's unclear what needs to happen in between. Backward design is a popular strategy in education settings to help start with an end objective and work backward to determine the steps of the process.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Backwards Planning worksheet.
2. Start by writing in the end objective, project, or task that you need to complete.
3. Navigate through the reflection questions step-by-step, beginning with determining how you will know the goal is met and the deadline.
4. Beginning with the step that must happen immediately before the task is finished, work backward through each project step. For example, if the project is a research paper, the immediate step before submitting it might be "proofread the paper." The next step before that might be "complete the references page."
5. Work step by step backward until you reach the step you are currently at in the project or until writing "Start the step-by-step plan." Steps can be as large or small as you like; however, it's helpful to have as many of the details written in the plan as possible.
6. Next, set a tentative deadline for each step in the plan to help you stay on track with completing the project on time.
7. It may be helpful to review the steps in the plan with a friend or family member. By asking about missing steps or unclear areas in your plan, you're ensuring the most success before you get started.
8. When you've completed the plan, use the reflection box at the bottom to determine how you might complete the planning or project differently next time.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Generating a step-by-step plan can take practice, even for experienced planners. Start with simpler tasks (5 or fewer steps) first until you are comfortable and fluent with the procedure. Then move on to more complex projects with more steps. Consider this exercise mastered when you can work backward on a plan for new projects.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If step-by-step planning is helpful in task initiation, it can also be done by starting with the first step in the sequence using a Task Analysis Generator (see Exercise #5).

SKILL AREAS:



TASK INITIATION



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Backwards Planning Worksheet (p. 82)
- Friend/family member (optional)

BACKWARDS PLANNING

Project Title:

WHAT IS MY END GOAL?

WHEN IS IT DUE?

HOW WILL I KNOW I'VE SUCCEEDED?

BACKWARDS PLAN

10 FINISHED!

9

8

7

6

5

4

3

2

1 START:

WHAT WOULD I DO DIFFERENTLY NEXT TIME?



CHAPTER FOUR: ORGANIZATION

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ORGANIZATION

When it comes to learning the basics about organization skills, the numbers say it all.

According to the National Association of Productivity and Organizing Professionals (NAPO, 2020)

- Americans spend more than \$4.36 billion annually on home storage and organization products.
- On average, we lose up to nine items per day. That means we spend time looking for 198,743 items over our lifetime.
- 36% of young adults say they feel judged about how organized they appear.
- 38% feel they would advance in their career if they could become more organized.

Now consider that teens and young adults with unique learning needs often struggle with executive functioning skills like organization more than traditional learners. The challenges quickly add up. It is why organizational skills are among the essential tools you can teach your teen or young adult today to set the stage for future success.

WHAT ARE ORGANIZATION SKILLS?

Organization involves how we gather stimuli in our environment to complete tasks quickly and more effectively. It's how we arrange our environment to provide order and structure to the items and activities around us. Organization skills are often closely tied to our ability to plan and manage our time.

We certainly may know from experiencing a messy bedroom or a backpack in disarray what *disorganized* looks like, but defining organization can mean different things to different individuals.



HOW WE DEVELOP ORGANIZATION SKILLS

We begin to develop organization skills early in life and progress towards more complex organizing behaviors as our responsibilities increase. Depending on the skills and strengths of your individual learner, teaching organization skills might involve teaching skills like:

- Sorting and categorizing – identifying, describing, and grouping objects by size, shape, pattern, function, and form.
- Putting things in designated places – when finished with materials, placing items back where they belong.
- Gather materials to complete a task - learning where items belong, finding what's needed for a project, and creating a plan to succeed.
- Use reminders and organization systems – learning to use a planner, visual schedule, digital and paper reminders, checklists, and other tools.
- How to reorganize if needed – recognizing when our environment is disorganized, when we need to pause for a reset, and how to get back on track with better organization.

WHY ARE ORGANIZATION SKILLS SO IMPORTANT?

Without a basic level of organization, it wouldn't take long for the world as we know it to deteriorate. We rely on an organized way of life in our schools, our homes, and our workplaces. Research shows that individuals who have good organization skills and implement them effectively have better outcomes across many different well-being areas. When things are disorganized, we report higher rates of distraction and stress (NAPO, 2020). Students who lack organization skills have more academic challenges, experience lower grades, and negative interactions with teachers (Anderson, et al., 2008).

For many teens and young adults with unique learning needs, organizational skills must be taught explicitly through targeted interventions. Yet even modest improvements in organizational skills can decrease symptoms of inattention and increase academic performance (Bikic, et al., 2017). Learners with developmental learning differences get faster at basic tasks and have fewer errors when using systems to stay organized (Dormany, et al., 2009).



EXAMPLES OF ORGANIZATION SKILLS

- Orders items or pictures into sequential order.
- Tells an organized story with a beginning, middle, and end.
- Returns items back to where they belong with a visual cue or drawing.
- Cleans up at the end of an activity or the end of the day.
- Maintains toys, personal items, and workspace in a neat and orderly manner.
- Arrives at school or work with the required materials.
- Keeps homework and essential documents in good condition.
- Develops an outline or list to organize tasks and topics systematically.

ORGANIZATION SKILLS AND PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

If we know that organizational skills show many benefits to our teens and young adults, what happens when those skills are underdeveloped or lagging?

- Do you find your child's belongings disordered and then have to 'fight' to get them to clean up?
- Does your child use problem behavior to get help searching for assignments, work materials, or belongings?
- Does your child look for ways to get out of organizing, cleaning, or planning tasks?
- Do they sometimes go to extremes like meltdowns or aggression because they can't find what they need?

While organization means different things for different individuals, keeping belongings and tasks tidy can ultimately reduce problem behaviors. Organizational skills result in less frustration and a reduced need to use problem behaviors to recruit adult help or escape a disordered task. Organizational skills create a sense of control, which can frequently be a positive reinforcer for teens and young adults with unique learning needs. Tasks finish more quickly and efficiently, leading to more time to engage in preferred activities.

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN NEAT AND MESSY

When we get started working on organization skills, one of the first things we ask and evaluate is if the child knows the difference between a clean, organized space and a messy one. It sounds simple, but some individuals with unique learning needs might not evaluate their the environment in the same way you do.

Start by pulling up some images online and ask your child to identify spaces that look clean and organized. Show some photos of unusually messy rooms, some cluttered but organized, and some images of areas that might need some tidying up. Then move to spaces in your household—you might even need to make some messes of your own!) Can your child identify and discriminate the differences? If not, it's not likely that you'll be able to agree on what it means to be organized until you do. Keep working to establish useful definitions of what it means to be organized that both you and your learner can relate to.

MOTIVATING YOUR CHILD TO GET ORGANIZED

It's not always easy to get a unique learner to understand why organizational skills have value. Parents and teachers need to help learners develop a strong 'why' or motivation for getting organized will be important early on when teaching these skills. Work to help your child understand both the short-term benefits and the long-term gains that come out of getting

organized. Some of these motivations might include:

- Earning extra rewards or privileges.
- Getting things done faster to have more free time.
- Completing tasks better and with better outcomes.
- A greater sense of control and predictability over their environment.
- Less parental and teacher oversight.

Finally, if you expect your child or student to be using these new habits, it's pivotal that you model the behaviors you want to see from them. If your child sees you scrambling every morning to find your keys or showing up to appointments without the right materials, it's hardly fair to hold them to a different standard. If you want to tackle their organization skills, make sure your behaviors are in good order first.

GETTING STARTED WITH ORGANIZING GOALS

To begin identifying the best tools and strategies for better organizing skills, take the pre-assessment on the next page, which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child. Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and planning how you might accomplish your organization-related goal.

ORGANIZATIONAL SKILLS

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the organization exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

I like my spaces neat and orderly.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I have systems to organize my work.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I know what I need to do, and when I need to do it.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

People who know me say that I am an organized person.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I feel better when my space is organized.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

When I have a lot to do, I can make a plan and figure out what I need to do first.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I try to have a place for everything.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For learning to keep belongings neat and tidy

29

30

For learning to use organization tools like checklists and reminders

28

32

33

For organizing other executive functioning skills

31

34

EXERCISE #28

REMINDER CARDS

BACKGROUND:

Sticky notes are one of the most iconic and useful organization tools. Using a home printer, create your own customizable reminders that you or your learner can place in key areas to remember important information and events.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Reminder Cards Templates.
2. Place a blank 3" x 3" sticky note over each box on the printed template with the glue at the top.
3. Using a .pdf editing software, insert a text box on the digital template over each box with the text for a reminder.
4. Insert the template with sticky notes attached into your printer. You may need to test which direction the sticky note page needs to be inserted to print correctly.
5. Print. Reminders will print directly onto the sticky notes.
6. Place your reminders in helpful places around your home.
7. Save the template for future use.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Sticky notes are one of the most popular organizing products on the market because they're easy to implement, affordable, and create great results. Some learners may create and print sticky notes without assistance but may initially need reminders to reference the sticky notes throughout the day. Others may need help with the printing process but can place and implement the reminder cards without additional assistance.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Use the printable sticky note template to plan and prioritize the weekly activities (see Exercise #4). Add printing customized reminder cards to the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda (see Exercise #3) or End of the Day Checklist (see Exercise #32) so reminders are prepped for upcoming tasks.

SKILL AREAS:



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

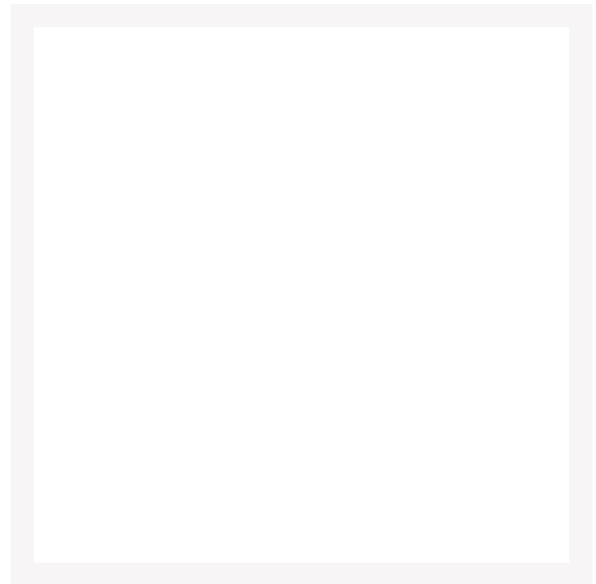
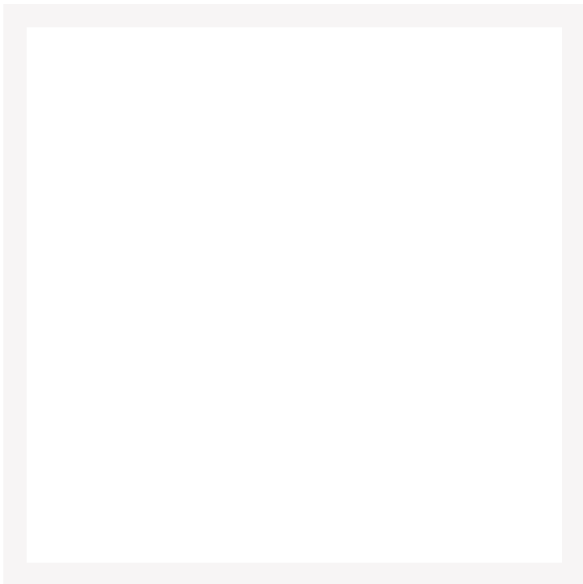
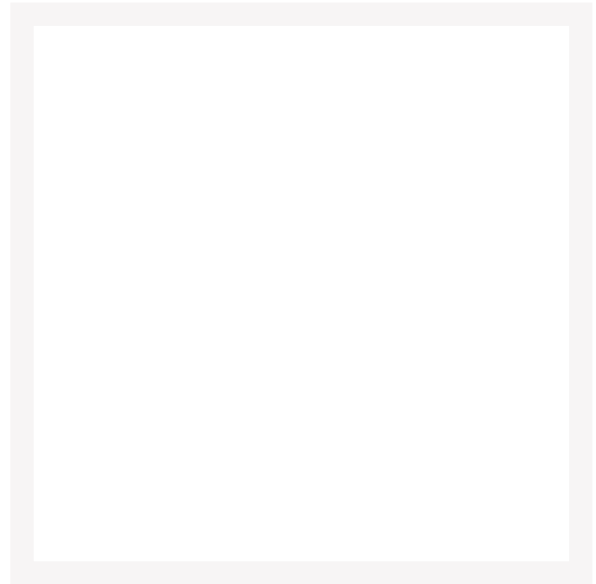
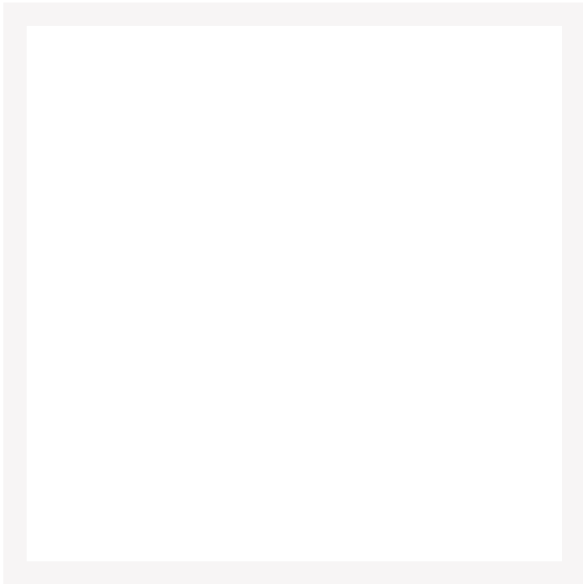
- Printable Reminder Cards Template (p. 92)
- Inkjet Printer
- 3 in. x 3 in. sticky notes



PRINTABLE STICKY NOTE TEMPLATE

Instructions:

- Print the blank template out. Then, place a blank 3" x 3" sticky note over each box on the printed template with the glue at the top.
- Using a .pdf editing software, insert a text box on the digital template over each box with the text for your reminder.
- Insert the printed template in your printer (you may need to test which direction the sticky note page needs to be inserted to print correctly).
- Print.
- Place your reminders in helpful places around your home.



PRINTABLE STICKY NOTE TEMPLATE

REMEMBER!

DON'T FORGET

IMPORTANT!

tomorrow

TO DO

TO BUY

EXERCISE #29

DESIGNATED PLACES

BACKGROUND:

Benjamin Franklin is often cited as saying it's best to have "A place for everything, and everything in its place." Work with members of your household to create a designated place for items of high importance. Practice timed trials to put things back where they belong and establish the habit of keeping clean and organized spaces.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Choose a theme from the list of areas of household organization that's in most need of organization or allow your learner to choose.
2. Set a timer for 20-30 minutes and organize one specific area of the home related to that topic. Avoid cleaning a large room or spending too much time on any one item.
3. For the most important items in that theme, work with members of the household to identify an agreed-upon 'designated place' for that item. Use baskets, plastic bins, and other organizing supplies to clearly mark the location.
4. If your learner benefits from visuals or written reminders, use a label maker to identify the designated place. Photos can also be helpful to mark the location (see Exercise #30).
5. When all items are in a designated place, have each household member observe the location. Then pull the items out and place them in a pile. Set the timer for 1-2 minutes and practice putting the items away before the timer goes off.
6. Repeat steps 1-5 with other areas from the household list.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Practice enough timed trials so that your learner can consistently put items away in the designated place without errors. After practicing several areas in the house, mix up items and have your learner 'sort' items into designated places around the house. Mastery includes using the designated places strategy to put away all items at the end of a day or during a cleaning session.

SKILL AREAS:



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Baskets, plastic bins, and other organizers
- Label maker (optional)
- Timer

HOUSEHOLD ORGANIZATION THEMES

- School supplies
- Laundry
- Morning Routine Items
- Groceries
- Winter clothing (hats, boots, etc.)
- Backpack or Work bag
- Toys and Video Games
- Sports Equipment
- Cooking Supplies/Clean Dishes
- Cleaning Supplies
- Bedtime Routine Items

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If you have a visual learner, combine Designated Places with Photo Bomb (Exercise #30) to create a visual photo book of the clean and organized spaces.

EXERCISE #30

PHOTO BOMB

BACKGROUND:

One of the challenges parents and children struggle with is agreeing on an acceptable definition of organized. After completing 'Designated Places' (see Exercise #29) and establishing what an organized space looks like, take photos to use as prompts to put items away and clean up messes in the future.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Baskets, plastic bins, and other organizers
- Smartphone Camera
- Photo Album (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Choose a theme from the list of areas of household organization (p. 94) and complete the Designated Places exercise.
2. When all members of the household agree on the designated places for each key item, take a photo of the items in their designated spaces. Look for an image that's clear enough that someone who does not live in your home could put items back in the designated place without difficulty.
3. Gather items in a smartphone album marked "Cleaning." or print the photos out and put them in a small photo album.
4. Pull out several items and practice using the visual photo album to identify where an item goes and return the item back to its designated place.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Practice using the photo prompts enough that your learner can consistently put items away in the designated place without errors. Practice outside of times when cleaning is required or when the learner has an emotional response to a challenging situation. After practicing several areas in the house, mix up items and have your learner 'sort' items into designated places around the house using the visuals.

Mastery includes using the photo album prompts to put away all items at the end of a day or during a cleaning session.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Using the photo album to clean and organize can be added to any executive functioning checklist in this workbook to remind your learner to use tools and strategies to stay organized. For example, add it to the Weekly Planning Agenda (See Exercise #3), End of the Day Checklist (see Exercise #32) or use it paired with the Weekly Organization Checklist (see Exercise #33).

EXERCISE #31

WEEKLY BINDER

BACKGROUND:

Once you've gained some new skills and met a few SMART goals with *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*, you'll want to keep the worksheets and exercises you use most often close by. Create a weekly binder to keep your executive functioning tools organized.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. As you find the exercises, worksheets, and checklists from the workbook to be effective, it can be helpful to store them in one specific place. Gather all of the materials, including the instructions and extra copies of the printable sheets you often use.
2. Open the three-ring binder and insert the tab divider pages.
3. Label each tabbed divider by a helpful category. Ideas for categories include sorting exercises by how often you use them (e.g., Daily, Weekly, Monthly, Quarterly) or by the days of the week or months of the year if you use an exercise that happens at a particular time. You can also create tab dividers that correspond with each chapter of the text or the skill areas listed in the top corner of each exercise.
4. Insert each exercise instruction sheet and extra copies in the binder with the correct tab. Then, each week, use the binder to keep the tools and checklists you use neat and organized.
5. As you use worksheets and extra copies, make sure to designate a time to restock the binder, so tools are available when you need them.

SKILL AREAS:



ORGANIZATION



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Three ring-binder
- Three hole punch
- Tab dividers
- Printable copies of exercises from *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*

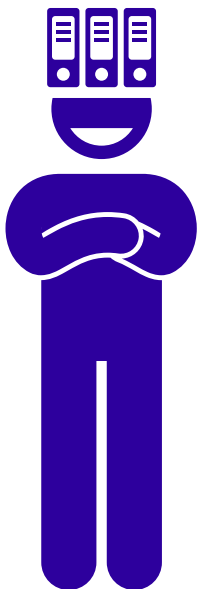
MASTERY CRITERIA:

The weekly binder can be completed once or can be a working archive that learners add to or subtract from as needed. Some learners might create the binder themselves but need teaching to remember to look for the tools inside. Other learners may need help creating and organizing the binder initially, but can easily select the best exercise to use in the moment. Work to help your learner reference the right tools at the right time.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Weekly Binder can serve as a hub for all of the exercises in this workbook.

Reference the weekly binder when you feel stuck (see Exercise #26), during the weekly planning agenda (see Exercise #3) or when completing an end of the month review (see Exercise #81). Use it to hold vision boards and folders (see Exercises #2, #6, and #39).



EXERCISE #32

END OF THE DAY CHECKLIST

BACKGROUND:

Checklists and daily agendas to keep us organized and on track—especially as we wrap up the day. While we may want our learners to ‘just know’ how to organize the next day’s activities independently, a more realistic strategy might be to use an end-of-the-day reminder list. Teach your learner to prep all the tools and materials they’ll need for the next day the night before.

SKILL AREAS:



ORGANIZATION



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Printable End of the Day Checklist (p. 98)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the End of the Day Checklist (p.98).
2. Record the date and circle any of the activities you have scheduled for the next day.
3. Beginning with the first activity on the list, list any deadlines, appointments, or important things to do the following day in the "Tomorrow I Need To" box.
4. For each activity on the list, record any necessary items you'll need to remember to gather for those activities below. For example, if on the list you wrote "school 8-2" and cross country practice "2:30-4:00", below list that you need a packed backpack and your running clothes.
5. When all of the activities and items are listed, gather the materials on the list. Then, check off each item when it's prepared for the next day.
6. Next, set any reminders and prepare your planner or daily agenda for the next day. Then, check those items off the list when you've prepared the plan for the next day.
7. Finally, when the checklist is finished, record your planned wake-up time for the next morning. Set an alarm to ensure that you wake up with enough time to complete the tasks on the list.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

This is one sample of an end-of-the-day checklist that can be customized for any learner and their daily responsibilities. It may take several days of practice to organize the next activities for the day. Other learners may need the checklist filled out for them but can gather all the materials for the next day. Support your learner until they can prepare for the next day without consistently forgetting to organize items.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The End of the Day Checklist can be combined with other exercises in the workbook. Use the Daily Planning Worksheet (see Exercise #15), Weekly Organization Checklist (see Exercise #33), and Reminder Cards (see Exercise #28) to prioritize the activities on the checklist. Using Designated Places (see Exercise #29) and Photo Bomb (see Exercise #30) organization tools can help to ensure that items are easier to gather and prepare at the end of the day.

END OF THE DAY CHECKLIST

TOMORROW IS:



TOMORROW I HAVE:



SCHOOL



WORK



SHOPPING



EXERCISE



LIBRARY/
STUDY



FAMILY
TIME



OTHER:

TOMORROW I NEED TO:



I HAVE WHAT I NEED FOR TOMORROW:

☐

CLOTHES

☐

GEAR

☐

MEALS

☐

MEDICATION

☐

TRANSPORTATION

☐

REMINDERS SET?

☐

DAILY AGENDA?



WAKE UP:

EXERCISE #33

WEEKLY ORGANIZATION CHECKLIST

BACKGROUND:

Some of the top experts in organization and planning remind followers that it's best to organize in small "tidy up" sessions rather than all at once in what quickly becomes a monumental chore.

Learning to do a few different organizational tasks each day helps avoid overwhelm and frustration when cleaning tasks get out of control.

SKILL AREAS:



ORGANIZATION



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Weekly Organization Checklist (p.100)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Weekly Organization Checklist (p.100).
2. Work with your learner to write down all the organizational tasks you need to complete each week. For ideas about areas for home organization, see the box on page 94.
3. Some tasks may need to be completed daily, like checklists and setting reminders. Place a * next to each task that needs to be completed daily.
4. Divide up the tasks equally among the days of the week, assign each task to a specific day, and, if possible, a specific time of day you plan to complete the task. For daily tasks, write the same task in each daily box.
5. Some days you may have other commitments which will prevent you from completing extra organization tasks. Anticipate which days you will have the most time and prioritize longer tasks for those days.
6. Place your weekly checklist in an area that's easy to locate. Then, reference the checklist each day to complete the assigned organization tasks.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for the weekly organization checklist come down to task completion. First, work with your learner to establish the necessary tasks (providing them a choice when to complete the tasks whenever possible). Then work to increase the number of tasks that get completed on the correct day. Start with 50-60% and build until more than 90% of the organizing tasks are completed each week.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The organization tasks can be easily combined with many other planning, time management, and organization exercises. Review the organization checklist during the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda (see Exercise #3) and store it in the Weekly Binder (see Exercise #31) or Sandbox (see Exercise #6) for easy reference.





WEEKLY ORGANIZATION CHECKLIST

MY WEEKLY ORGANIZATION TASKS

MONDAY

☐
☐
☐
☐

TUESDAY

☐
☐
☐
☐

WEDNESDAY

☐
☐
☐
☐

THURSDAY

☐
☐
☐
☐

FRIDAY

☐
☐
☐
☐

SATURDAY/SUNDAY

☐
☐
☐
☐
☐
☐
☐

EXERCISE #34

BULLETIN BOARD

BACKGROUND:

The first patent for the corkboard bulletin board was filed in 1925. Since then, bulletin boards have become a mainstay in homes, offices, and classrooms worldwide. Using the "designated places" philosophy, hang a bulletin board in a prominent place in your home as a place to reference important information, checklists, and task reminders.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Select a high-traffic area of your home with large open wall space. It's helpful to select a place where other office supplies, school/study supplies, or weekly planning meetings (see Exercise #3) may also take place.
2. Hang the bulletin board according to the manufacturer's instructions.
3. Using the guide on page 102 for reference, post different sheets of brightly colored paper on the bulletin board to divide up the space into key areas.
4. Print out and attach the worksheets, reminders, and checklists necessary for the week to the bulletin board.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for using the bulletin board should be examined in two ways. First, evaluate if your learner references the bulletin board daily and weekly to stay organized, better manage time, and monitor behavior. Secondly, evaluate if the bulletin board effectively reduces the problem behaviors related to when organization, planning, and time management skills fail.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

During the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda (see Exercise #3) or the Weekly Organization Checklist (see Exercise #33), review the contents of each area of the bulletin board, revise, and remove any unnecessary papers. Designate an area to post rewards and fun activities (see Exercises #12 & #19).

SKILL AREAS:

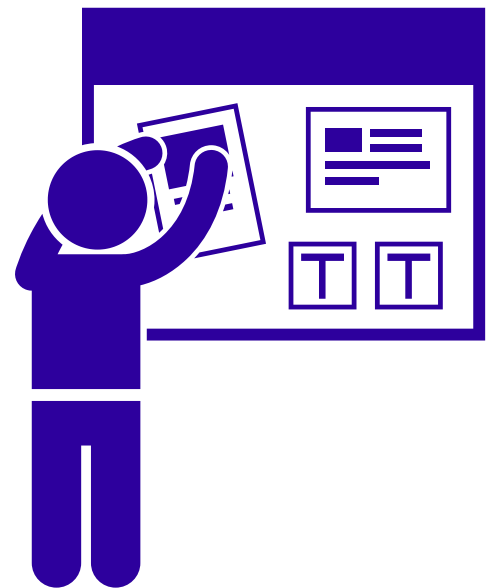


ORGANIZATION

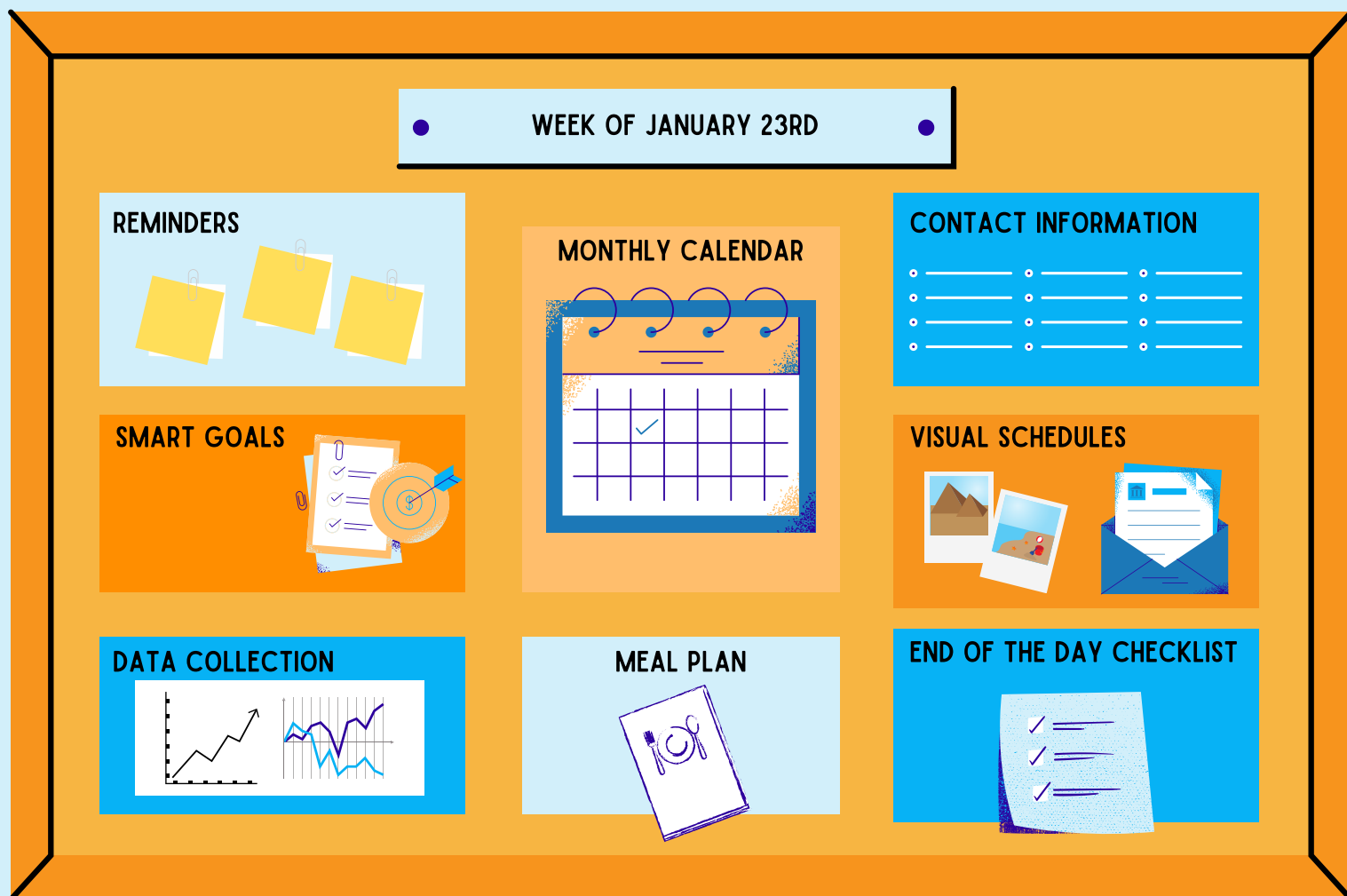
SKILL LEVEL: Easy to Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Bulletin Board - cork board or magnetic
- Fasteners for the board
- 3-4 sheets of brightly colored papers
- Worksheets, reminders, and printables from *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*



SAMPLE BULLETIN BOARD ORGANIZATION



OTHER RESOURCES TO INCLUDE ON AN EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING BULLETIN BOARD:

- Motivational Quotes and Photo Reminders
- Lists for Groceries and Shopping
- To-Do Lists and Future Tasks
- Time Log (see Exercise #14)
- Fun Planner (see Exercise #19)
- Vision Boards (see Exercise #2, #26, #39, #51)
- Phone-A-Friend Resources (see Exercise #36)
- Progress Monitoring Graph (see Exercise #18, #75)
- Savings Plan (see Exercise #38)
- Important websites
- Frequently used addresses or directions
- Stamps, labels, sticky notes
- Hooks for keys, timers, or other time management tools
- Pocket for important documents, instruction manuals, or photos



CHAPTER FIVE: PROBLEM SOLVING

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PROBLEM SOLVING

When parents reach out to us about working with a child, invariably, we end up asking about problem-solving skills. Questions like:

- *Does your child identify problems?*
- *When you see a problem in the making, can your child see it too?*
- *If your child comes to you with a problem, how much effort does it take them to generate a reasonable solution?*
- *Can your child evaluate the pros and cons of different strategies to solve a problem?*
- *When your child eventually finds a solution to a problem, can they see implement it and stay the course to see the problem through?*



For many of the parents and teachers we work with, it becomes clear by asking these questions that the struggles and challenging behaviors they encounter with their child aren't related to "undisciplined" or "lazy" kids. They're not related to bad parenting either. Instead, we find many challenges our unique learners face relate to poorly developed problem-solving skills.

WHAT ARE PROBLEM SOLVING SKILLS?

Problem-solving involves our capacity to identify and describe a problem and generate solutions to fix it.

According to Newell & Simon (1972), "a person is confronted with a problem when he wants something and does not know immediately what series of actions he can perform to get it" (p.72). We engage in problem-solving behaviors when we evaluate possible steps forward and then take action to obtain the outcome we're looking for. Problem-solving involves many other executive functioning behaviors, including attentional control, planning, and task initiation. We need to pay attention to our

environment to notice a problem, outline different strategies, and then attempt one of those solutions. Depending on the problem, we might also need to use time management, emotional control, or organization skills. Over time, if we can observe our own behavior and understanding of the environment through working memory and self-monitoring behaviors, it can also influence our problem-solving skills.

DEVELOPING PROBLEM SOLVING SKILLS

Problem-solving skills develop early through play behaviors as infants and toddlers. At these early stages of development, much of a child's play consists of cause and effect play or 'figuring out how things work.' As children move into early learning years, problem-solving includes learning decision making and turn-taking. In addition, children learn to brainstorm solutions to simple problems and notice problems when others point them out.

As children reach adolescence, they begin to independently identify problems in many settings, including home, school, work, and time with friends. They sort out conflicts and decide what steps to take but may seek adult feedback and support to evaluate the potential advantages and disadvantages of solutions. As teens and young adults, developing good problem-solving skills involves generating unique solutions to complex problems and persisting through multiple solutions until a problem resolves.

PROBLEM SOLVING AND PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

Not all teens and young adults develop adequate problem-solving behaviors like those listed here. Learners with a history of behavioral and learning challenges may not always use good problem-solving skills to manage stressful situations (Kern, et al., 2016). We all know students who use challenging behaviors like talking back, arguing, property destruction, and aggression when presented with difficult tasks. We also know students who shut down, check out, or struggle to follow directions when they encounter new or unknown situations. Without a step-by-step model for problem-solving, including how to identify a problem and choose a replacement behavior to solve it, many of our children and students use challenging behaviors instead. Over time, learners labeled as 'defiant,' 'lazy,' or 'helpless' may actually just need better problem-solving tools.



EXAMPLES OF PROBLEM SOLVING SKILLS

- Complete puzzles and games to accomplish a goal.
- Use language and body movements to achieve an outcome.
- Identify and define a problem, including where the problem originated and why.
- Break apart a problem into smaller parts.
- Identify problems in different social contexts, including work, school, home, and with friends.
- Sort out conflicts and what to do in complicated social situations.
- Seek guidance from others about what to do in problem situations.
- Persist in developing new strategies when previous attempts fail.

THE IDEAL PROBLEM SOLVING METHOD

In 1984, Bransford and Stein published one of the most popular and well-regarded problem-solving methods (Bransford & Stein, 1993). For more than 30 years, the IDEAL Problem-Solving technique has been used in industry and education to establish a problem, generate solutions, and move forward quickly and efficiently. It's a systematic approach, which can be helpful for diverse learners who respond to step-by-step strategies.

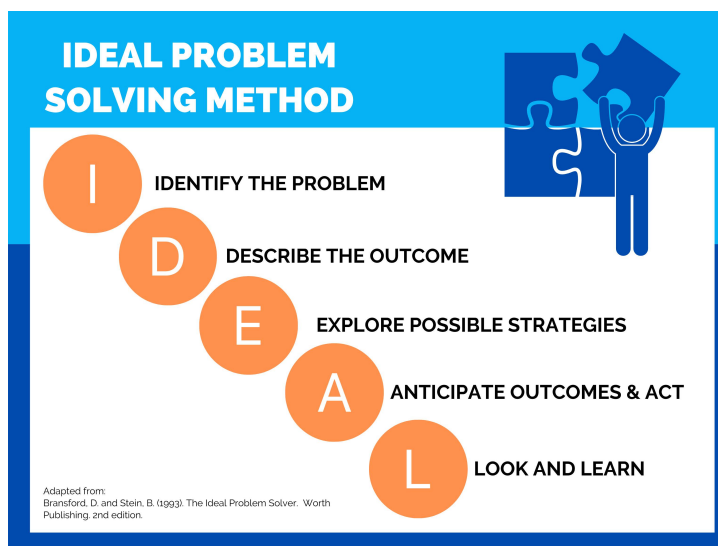
The IDEAL in the IDEAL Problem-Solving Method stands for: **I**dentify the problem. **D**efine and describe the outcome or goal if the problem is solved. **E**xplore possible strategies and solutions. **A**nticipate the outcomes and then act. **L**ook at the outcomes and learn from them.

I - IDENTIFY THE PROBLEM

There's no real way to create a solution to a problem unless you first know the scope of the problem. We have to start somewhere. Begin by identifying the issue in your own words. Then, outline the facts and the unknowns.

Examples of identifying problems:

- "I have a math quiz next week and don't know how to do the problems."
- "I can't access my distance learning course website."
- "The trash needs to be taken out, and I can't find any trash bags."



D - DEFINE AND DESCRIBE AN OUTCOME

The second step in the IDEAL problem-solving process is to define an outcome or goal for what will happen when the problem is solved. Multiple people can agree that a problem exists but have very different ideas on goals or outcomes. By deciding on an outlined objective first, it can speed up the process of identifying solutions.

Defining outcomes and goals may be a difficult step for some diverse learners. The results don't need to be complicated--after all, you don't yet know which action you'll take--but the description should be clear for everyone involved.

Examples of defining outcomes:

- "I want to do well on my math quiz."
- "I get access to the course website."
- "The trash gets taken out before the trash pickup day tomorrow."

E - EXPLORE POSSIBLE STRATEGIES

Once you have an outcome, it's time to brainstorm solutions. All possible strategies to solve the problem should be on the table during this stage, even outlandish ones. At this stage, it can be helpful to make lists, use sticky notes or voice memos to record any ideas. Many of the exercises in *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook* were designed to assist in developing solutions during the exploration stage, especially for individuals who might struggle with creative idea generation. If needed, consult with a trusted friend, family member, or someone familiar with the problem who might also offer solutions to the problem.

Examples of possible strategies to solve a problem:

- "To prep for the quiz, I could review the textbook, ask for math help from a friend, look up the problems online, or email my teacher."
- "To gain access to the course website, I could email my teacher for the course access, ask for help from a classmate, or try to reset my password."
- "Trash needs to go out so I could use something else for a trash bag, place an online order for bags, take the trash out without a bag, ask a neighbor for a bag, or go shopping after work today for trash bags."

A - ANTICIPATE OUTCOMES AND ACT

Once we generate a list of strategies, the next step in the IDEAL problem-solving model recommends that you review the potential steps and decide which one is the best option to use first. Learning to evaluate the pros and cons of action steps can take practice. Ask questions like, "What might happen if I take this step?" or "Does that step make me feel good about moving forward or uncertain?"

After evaluating the outcomes, the next step is to take action. Using some of what we know about task initiation (see Chapter 3), move forward even if you may not know the full result of taking action. Embody the idea that it's better to be doing something than nothing. Even if you may need to change course or something unexpected happens, it's better to take action.

L - LOOK AND LEARN

The final step in the IDEAL problem-solving model is to look at the results and learn from our attempts to solve a problem. We can sometimes forget this critical step, especially when working with individuals with unique learning needs. However, it's equally important to stop and reflect when problem-solving goes well ("Hey, I did a good job back there") and to acknowledge when things did not go well. If things didn't go as planned, learning from that experience can make problem-solving more efficient and effective in the future.

Ask questions like "How did that go?" and "What went well? What could I do differently next time?"

Examples of Look and Learn statements:

- “I didn’t learn the problems from looking at the textbook, but it did help to call a friend. So I’ll start there next time.”
- “When I didn’t have access to the course website, resetting my password worked. I’ll remember that the next time I can’t get into a website.”
- “I ran out of trash bags because I forgot to put them on the shopping list. So I’ll buy an extra box of trash bags to have them on hand, so I don’t run out next time.”

GETTING STARTED

To get started with problem-solving exercises and skills, take the pre-assessment on the next page to help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child. Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and planning how you might accomplish problem-solving-related goals.

PROBLEM-SOLVING SKILLS

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the problem-solving exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

I can easily identify problems and when they start.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can identify facts and gather relevant information.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can get to the bottom of why problems start.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Finding multiple ways to complete a project is easy for me.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Others think my solutions to problems are creative.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Most times I evaluate the pros and cons before I take the next step.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

When I decide on a solution to a problem, I know how to implement it.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For practice with solving common problems

3538

For learning new problem-solving strategies or skills to implement when faced with a problem

363739

EXERCISE #35

PROBLEM SOLVER PRACTICE

BACKGROUND:

Top businesses and corporations spend thousands of dollars on training teams to implement problem-solving strategies. Employees practice and role-play common problems in the workplace while coaches give supportive feedback until everyone feels confident in each of the steps. We can use the same process to practice and gain confidence in common problem-solving situations.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Printable Problem-Solving Practice Cards (p. 111)
2. Review the flashcards and choose the most common problems relevant to the learner. If necessary, use the blank cards to create flashcards with custom problem-solving scenarios.
3. Select a card from the deck.
4. Ask your learner to define the problem, choose an outcome, and then evaluate different actions.
5. Discuss the pro's and con's of each potential outcome
6. Consider all possibilities for taking each action until you and your partner agree upon an action to take.
7. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about solving various problems in the flashcard deck.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this objective may depend on your experience with some of the problem-solving scenarios found in the deck. For learners who still need some adult support, start with problems that have more obvious solutions (e.g., complete a school project due tomorrow vs. watch a movie with friends). Then move to problems where it's less obvious or scenarios where your learner consistently struggles.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If player-based exercises and activities like the Problem-Solving Practice Flashcards work well to learn new skills, expand by using the First/Then Flashcards to practice task initiation (see Exercise #23) or create a deck of flashcards for other executive functioning skills.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Problem-Solving Practice Cards (p. 111)
- Friend, Partner or Coach to provide feedback

PROBLEM-SOLVING PRACTICE CARDS

Top businesses and corporations spend thousands of dollars to train teams to implement problem-solving strategies. Employees practice and role-play common problems in the workplace.

Coaches give supportive feedback until everyone feels confident in each of the steps. The same process can be used to help diverse learners use problem-solving methods.



ACTIVITY:

1. Print and cut out a set of problem-solving flashcards.
2. Select a card from the deck.
3. Ask your learner to define the problem, choose an outcome, and evaluate different actions.
4. Discuss outcomes and possibilities for taking each action until an action is agreed upon.
5. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about solving the problem.



**YOU'RE FEELING
OVERWHELMED OR
FRUSTRATED**



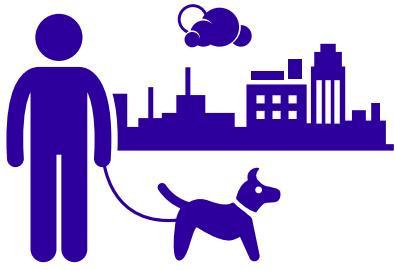
**YOU DON'T KNOW
WHAT TO EAT**



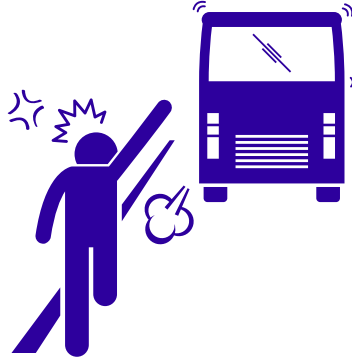
**YOU HAVE A LARGE
HOMEWORK
ASSIGNMENT DUE IN
ONE MONTH**



**YOU HAVE A LARGE
HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT
DUE TOMORROW**



**YOU LOST
YOUR PET**



YOU MISSED THE BUS



**YOU NEED
DIRECTIONS TO A
FRIEND'S HOUSE**



**YOU CAN'T LOG INTO
CLASS WEBSITE**



**YOU FELL ASLEEP
DURING CLASS**



**YOU'RE OUT OF
GROCERIES**



**YOUR CAR
BROKE DOWN**



**YOUR ROOM IS A
MESS**



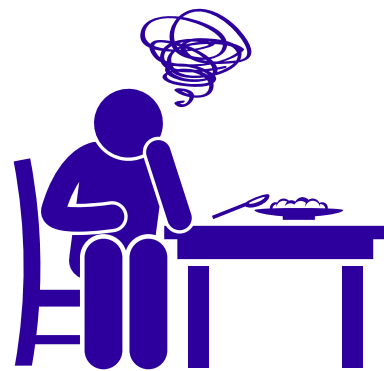
FRIEND IS ANGRY AT YOU



**YOU'RE ANGRY
AT A FRIEND**



YOU LOST A GAME



**YOU DON'T LIKE A
MEAL**



**YOU'RE NERVOUS
ABOUT A
PRESENTATION**



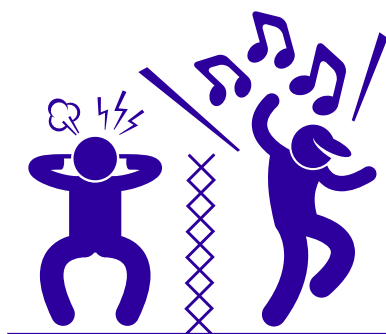
**YOU DON'T KNOW
HOW TO DO
HOMEWORK**



YOU HAVE A TOOTH ACHE



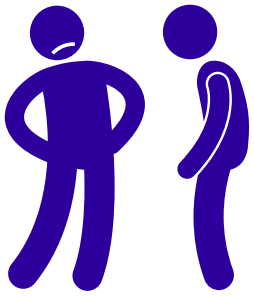
**YOU LOST
YOUR PHONE**



**A FRIEND IS TOO
LOUD**



**YOU DON'T HAVE ENOUGH
MONEY TO BUY
SOMETHING YOU WANT**



**YOUR FRIEND IS
FEELING
LONELY**



**YOUR COMPUTER
WON'T TURN ON**



**YOU'RE GOING TO
RUN OUT OF TIME
DURING A TEST**



**YOU GOT OFF AT THE
WRONG BUS STOP**



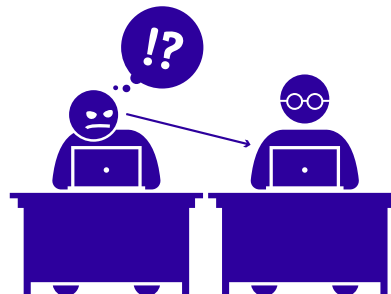
YOU LOST YOUR KEYS



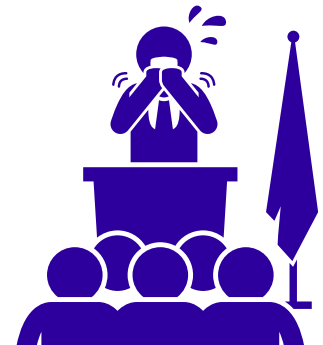
**YOU LOST YOUR
CREDIT CARD**



**THE TOILET IS
CLOGGED**



**A FRIEND IS TRYING
TO CHEAT OFF YOUR
HOMEWORK**



**YOU'RE NERVOUS
ABOUT GIVING A
PRESENTATION**



**YOU FEEL
BORED**



**YOU DON'T WANT TO
GO TO WORK OR
SCHOOL**



**A FRIEND ASKS YOU
TO KEEP A SECRET**



A FRIEND LIED TO YOU



**YOU'RE BEING
BULLIED**



YOU FAILED A TEST

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

EXERCISE #36

PHONE-A-FRIEND

BACKGROUND:

Sometimes we need a trusted friend to help us through difficult problems. Knowing whom you can rely on to brainstorm ideas or evaluate the solutions to a problem can help ease the burden off the problem-solver and lead to a better outcome. Spend time outside of difficult problem situations to identify and evaluate who might be helpful to call when you need a problem-solving partner.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Phone-A-Friend Contact List (p. 117).
2. In the top box, begin by making a list of emergencies and scenarios where the best problem-solving strategy is to call 911. Then, review with your learner to ensure they understand when and how to seek emergency help.
3. Next, write down the names and contact information for the three individuals you most commonly call when you have a problem, are in a stressful situation, or need advice.
4. Consider what types of problems you have consulted with them before and how they have successfully--or perhaps, unsuccessfully--helped you navigate in the past.
5. Write down 1-2 items that you might call each individual for in the future. Some examples include "For help with homework," "For car trouble," "For relationships," "For tech support," "When I feel angry, afraid, etc."
6. Continue to brainstorm different categories of problems you frequently encounter and write them in the remaining boxes. Finally, review your contacts list and add the names and phone numbers for each box.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

While it's important to have the Phone-A-Friend list handy when your learner needs support, it's also important to use it. Mastery criteria for this activity include developing a list *and* using the contacts on the list when needed. Continue to prompt your learner to refer back to the list until they independently consult a "Phone-A-Friend" in difficult situations.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

To generate additional ideas for problem-solving categories, use the scenarios in Exercise #35. Regularly update the Phone-A-Friend list and store it in an easy-to-access location like the Weekly Binder (see Exercise #31) or Bulletin Board (see Exercise #34).

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Phone-A-Friend Printable Download (p. 117)
- Address book or contacts list





MY PHONE-A-FRIEND LIST

WHEN TO CALL 9-1-1

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

NAME:



CALL WHEN I NEED:

EXERCISE #37

PLAN B

BACKGROUND:

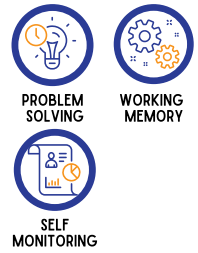
The final step in the IDEAL problem-solving method is to "look and learn" or spend time evaluating the outcomes of our problem-solving. By reflecting on what went well (and what didn't go so well) in a problem-solving situation, we can formulate a backup plan to use in the future.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Plan B for Problem Solving Worksheet.
2. Begin by summarizing the current problem in your own words, including details about how the problem began.
3. Summarize any strategies that have already been tried in the first box. Next, indicate what has been done to attempt to solve the problem and any individuals who may have already tried to help.
4. In the box marked "What was the result?" Outline any changes that resulted from the first plan. If the first problem-solving plan was not effective, list out any reasons that those strategies failed.
5. Next, generate 1-3 possible alternative strategies to solve the problem. If needed, consult with a trusted friend.
6. During brainstorming, it may be possible to generate ideas about why the problem occurred in the first place and if there were things that could have prevented it. List those out to avoid the problem happening again in the future.
7. Finally, generate the best course of action forward in the "My Plan B" box. Indicate what action items you need to accomplish first to solve the problem.



SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Plan B for Problem Solving Worksheet (p. 119)

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for Plan B Problem Solving include several steps. Learners may need help initially to reflect on the problem and prior strategies. Others may need more assistance with generating alternative solutions. Finally, continue to practice the exercise until the learner can generate an alternative solution to 3 different problems or avoid the same problem in the future.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Creating a backup plan requires flexible thinking (see Chapter 6) and self-monitoring (see Chapter 11). Use this exercise with others that help when things don't go according to our original plan (see Exercise #41).



PLAN B FOR PROBLEM SOLVING

THE PROBLEM:

Summarize the problem, including who, what, where, and when the problem occurred.



MY FIRST STRATEGY:

What have you tried so far?



WHAT WAS THE RESULT?

What worked? What didn't work?



SOME BETTER WAYS TO SOLVE THE PROBLEM:

1

2

3



HOW COULD I HAVE PREVENTED THE PROBLEM?



MY PLAN B:

My next strategy...
In the future I will...

EXERCISE #38

SAVINGS PLAN

BACKGROUND:

Whether for a new video game or college tuition, saving money can be a dilemma for many unique learners. It takes careful planning and problem-solving to create a savings plan, and then it requires impulse control to stay on track until the goal is met. Use the exercise below to outline a savings plan for an upcoming purchase and problem-solve various strategies to accomplish the goal.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Printable Savings Plan Worksheets. Set aside 30-45 minutes in a distraction-free area to work on the worksheets and goal setting.
2. Begin by researching the item you plan to save for. Identify how much the item cost and how much you have remaining to save for the item.
3. Review and complete the reflection questions, creating a plan for where you'll earn extra money and identifying how much time you have to save for the item.
4. Next, select a saving plan option. Enter the amount you have to save. Then determine a short, medium, and long duration of time to save for the item. Divide by the number of weeks to determine how much time you have to save for the item.
5. Evaluate the strengths and barriers of each option until you determine the best savings plan to meet the goal.
6. Write a SMART goal (See Exercise #1) about the savings goal. Then, sign and date the goal, committing to yourself to stay on track with the savings plan.
7. On the final worksheet, log your progress towards meeting the savings plan goal. Each week that you meet the target savings goal record an entry on the log. Divide the thermometer into equal parts based on the number of weeks you plan to save. Start at the bottom and shade in the thermometer with each savings entry you record on the log.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Different learners will require support with different elements of the savings plan. Begin with smaller goals and work up to larger items. Continue to provide support until your learner can use the plan to set a financial goal and save for 3 different items.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Savings Plan breaks apart a larger goal into smaller steps. If your learner benefits from this type of planning and goal setting, try Task Analysis (see Exercise #5) and Progress Monitoring (see Exercise #75).

SKILL AREAS:



PROBLEM
SOLVING



IMPULSE
CONTROL

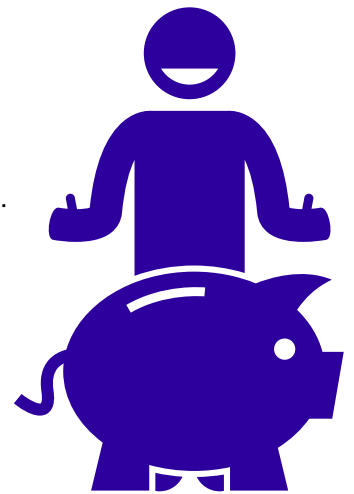


PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Savings Plan Worksheets (p. 121)
- Calculator or spreadsheet application



MY SAVINGS PLAN



GOAL:

I'm saving for:

How much does this item cost? How much do I need to save?

EARN

Where will I earn the money?

SPEND

What else do I need to spend or save for right now?



Why do you want to save for this item? What will you gain once you have it?



Are there alternatives that cost less or are easier to save for?
(Examples: Renting, buying used, buying a less expensive item)



How much time do you have to save? What is your goal date to have the money saved?

1

2

3

MY SAVINGS PLAN



SAVINGS OPTIONS:

1

Total Amount to Save



Total Weeks to Save



Per Week

2

Total Amount to Save



Total Weeks to Save



Per Week

3

Total Amount to Save



Total Weeks to Save



Per Week

Which plan is most likely to succeed? Why?

STRENGTHS

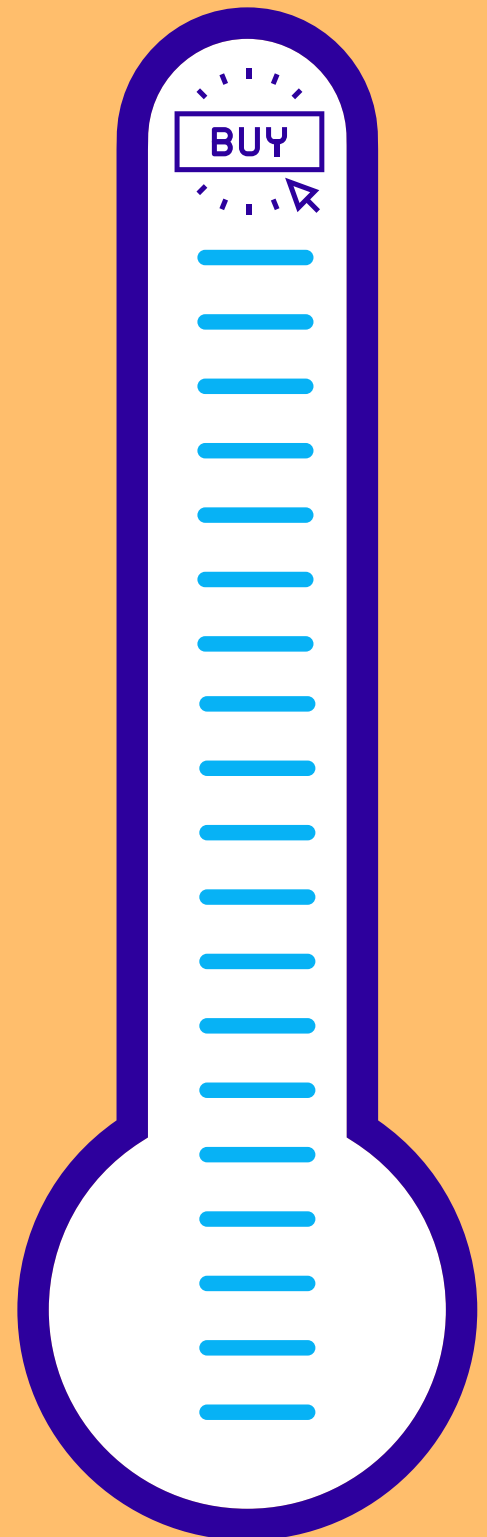
What might get in the way? How can I prevent challenges?

BARRIERS

MY SMART SAVINGS GOAL:



Signature: _____ Date: _____

[illegible]

EXERCISE #39

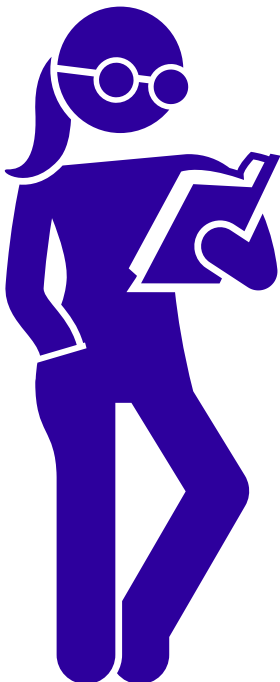
PROBLEM-SOLVING PLAYBOOK

BACKGROUND:

As you gain experience with problem-solving strategies and find different exercises and tools within *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*, you'll want to come back to them again and again. Create a small binder of problem-solving strategies and tools handy in this mini playbook.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Review the problem-solving strategies in the introduction section of the problem-solving chapter and exercises in the workbook designed to help with problem-solving situations.
2. Create one page in the binder for each strategy or exercise. Write out the name of the strategy at the top, followed by a list of the situations where the strategy might be helpful. For example, list "When I can't figure out what to eat." or "When I'm having trouble with friends."
3. Keep the instruction sheet and extra copies in the mini-binder. Then, each time a problem arises where you need extra help or clarity on the issue, use the problem-solving playbook to identify a strategy.
4. As you use exercises, make notes about what went well and what didn't go well to continue improving the playbook over time.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

The problem-solving playbook can be completed once you work on problem-solving skills or can be used as a working archive that learners add to or subtract from as needed. For example, some learners might create the binder themselves but need teaching to remember to look for the tools inside. Other learners may need help creating and organizing the binder initially but can easily select the best problem-solving strategy to use at the moment. Work to help your learner reference the right tools at the right time.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner benefits from having all their executive functioning tools in one place, consider the other vision board and binder exercises in the workbook to help them find the right strategy at the right time (see Exercises #2, #6, and #31).

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- 5-1/2" x 8" mini three-ring binder
- Paper for binder or three-hole punch.



CHAPTER SIX: FLEXIBILITY

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FLEXIBILITY

Much of this workbook was developed and written during the 2020 COVID-19 global pandemic. If anything that lives in a pandemic showed us, it was how important it (and how difficult it can be) to adapt to unexpected change. As every aspect of life turned upside down for parents and teachers, it quickly became apparent that some things were easy to pivot, and others were tough to change. In times of great uncertainty and change, our skills to demonstrate flexibility made the biggest difference in how we coped and adapted to new ways of working, learning, and parenting.

WHAT IS FLEXIBILITY?

While there's no set definition of flexibility in executive functioning, we generally consider flexibility to be the behavior of switching between tasks and demands in response to changes in the environment. In essence, it's our ability to change our behavior to different contexts or stimuli in the environment. Researchers might use other terms to study and describe flexibility, including cognitive flexibility, shift, task switching, and mental flexibility. All of these terms relate to our ability to adapt quickly and respond to change.

Individuals who struggle with flexibility may have difficulty discriminating differences in the environment or shifting focus between different tasks or relevant information. When we're inflexible, we may get 'stuck' or keep trying the same response over and over even though it's not working.



DEVELOPING FLEXIBILITY

We begin to learn flexibility and develop flexible thinking early in childhood. Toddlers and young children complete simple puzzles, games, and play that require shifting between behaviors. As young children learn to shift from activity to activity, they manage transitions and unexpected changes without upsetting behaviors. Then, as adolescents grow and their social networks continue to expand, they encounter more and more situations where problems and



EXAMPLES OF FLEXIBILITY

- Complete puzzles, games, and role play with others.
- Shifting between basic play and daily living activities.
- Managing unexpected changes without upset or frustration.
- Participating in social events like sports, clubs, and gatherings where unpredictable events occur.
- Incorporating new information when attempting to solve a problem.
- Trying an alternative strategy when an initial strategy was ineffective.
- Modifying schedules and routines to dynamically meet changing environments.
- Adapt to unpredictability with occasional stress, but able to cope with changes easily.

unpredictable events occur. In these situations, adults are close by to support and provide scaffolding as young teens adjust dynamically.

As our children grow from teenagers into young adults, we expect them to now manage unpredictable routines and meet the changing demands of school, work, and family. We also expect teens and young adults to begin to take difficult situations in stride. Young adults may need additional support at occasional points, but with well-developed executive functioning skills, they're able to pivot and recover quickly when the unexpected happens.

WHY IS FLEXIBILITY IMPORTANT?

Research shows us there are some real-world benefits to developing flexibility (Dajan & Uddin, 2015). Coping with unexpected changes and adapting to new information are associated with a wide range of positive outcomes in children and adults, including:

- Better reading abilities
- Improved responding to negative life events
- Higher ability to respond to stress in adulthood
- Improved creativity

In addition, improvements in flexibility can also help avoid common pitfalls at home, school and work our children don't adapt well to change. These include:

- Getting frustrated when little things happen
- Repeating the same mistake
- Difficulty adapting to changes in schedules
- Switching between activities or leaving activities

- Arguing the same point over and over
- Tantrums or meltdowns when rules or circumstances change.

UNDERSTANDING FLEXIBILITY AND PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

Along with the problem behaviors above, do you find yourself creating complex systems to avoid sudden changes? When something unpredictable happens, do you find yourself "on edge" and you're not sure how your child might respond? Does your child stall out, stop working, or have emotional or aggressive outbursts when changes happen? Do they struggle to make in-the-moment decisions when new information comes to light?

If your child engages in problem behaviors to escape or avoid unpredictability and change, or problem behaviors when change is hard, improving flexibility and shift can dramatically reduce problem behavior. In addition, increasing tolerance helps your child move forward more quickly with tasks rather than stalling out. That, in turn, helps learners more quickly accomplish goals and encounter fewer negative consequences for problem behavior.

FLEXIBILITY AND OTHER EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING SKILLS

When we work on strategies to improve flexibility with unique learners, we may see improvements in other core executive functioning skills. Many individuals that struggle with flexible thinking also struggle with executive functioning skills like planning, problem-solving, working memory, impulse control, emotional control, and self-monitoring. Parents and teachers that invest in flexibility may also need to evaluate other skill areas that could use a boost. That's why many of the exercises in this chapter link directly to other skills in other chapters of this workbook.

GETTING STARTED

To get started with flexibility exercises and skills, take the pre-assessment on the next page to help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child.

Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and planning how you might accomplish flexibility-related goals.

FLEXIBILITY

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the flexibility exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

I recognize problems and make changes to fix them.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I'm okay if things change unexpectedly.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Switching between tasks is easy for me.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I accept other's ideas even if they're different from my own.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can easily adjust to different rules and different expectations.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I don't mind if things go wrong or if I have to try a different way to solve a problem.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I'm okay if I can't control things or when others make choices for me.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For learning about common situations that require flexibility

40 42 47

For learning new flexibility skills when faced with a change

41 44 45

For learning tolerance to change and unpredictability

43 46

EXERCISE #40

BIG DEAL OR NO BIG DEAL

BACKGROUND:

One of the first steps to help your learner understand tolerance and flexibility is to understand that sometimes change is good.

Not all instances where we have to be flexible are a bad thing. In this exercise, learn about situations where being flexible is a 'big deal' and when it's 'no big deal' to be flexible.

SKILL AREAS:



FLEXIBILITY



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to
Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Printable Big Deal/No Big Deal Cards (p. 131)
- Friend, Partner or Coach to provide feedback

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the printable Big Deal/No Big Deal cards (p. 131).
2. Review the flashcards and choose the most common situations relevant to the learner. Focus on scenarios where your learner might have struggled with adapting to change in the past. If necessary, use the blank cards to create flashcards with custom flexibility scenarios.
3. Select a card from the deck.
4. Ask your learner to define the problem and decide if being flexible is a "big deal" or "no big deal."
5. Ask the learner what they might do instead and then evaluate different actions in situations where it's a big deal.
6. For situations where it's not a big deal to be flexible, ask the learner about benefits or rewards that might happen if they show flexibility in similar situations.
7. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about identifying various 'big deals' and 'no big deals.'

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this objective may depend on your learner's experience with some of the flexibility scenarios found in the deck. For learners who still need some adult support, start with situations that have more obvious solutions. Then move to scenarios where it's less obvious or scenarios where your learner consistently struggles to be flexible.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If card-based exercises and activities like the 'Big Deal/No Big Deal' Flashcards work well to learn new skills, expand by using the First/Then Flashcards to practice task initiation (see Exercise #23) or create a deck of flashcards for other executive functioning skills.

FLEXIBLE THINKING

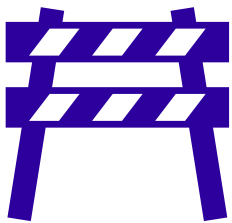
"BIG DEAL" OR "NO BIG DEAL"



One of the first steps to help your learner understand tolerance and flexibility is to understand that sometimes change is good. Not all instances where we have to be flexible are a bad thing. In this exercise, learn about situations where being flexible is a 'big deal' and when it's 'no big deal' to be flexible.

ACTIVITY:

1. Download and print the printable Big Deal/No Big Deal cards (p. 131).
2. Review the flashcards and choose the most common situations relevant to the learner. Focus on scenarios where your learner might have struggled with adapting to change in the past. If necessary, use the blank cards to create flashcards with custom flexibility scenarios.
3. Select a card from the deck.
4. Ask your learner to define the problem and decide if being flexible is a "big deal" or "no big deal."
5. Ask the learner what they might do instead and then evaluate different actions in situations where it's a big deal.
6. For situations where it's not a big deal to be flexible, ask the learner about benefits or rewards that might happen if they show flexibility in similar situations.
7. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about identifying various 'big deals' and 'no big deals.'



**ROAD
CONSTRUCTION
CLOSES YOUR ROUTE**



**MISSED THE BUS AT
THE BUS STOP**



RAINING OUTSIDE



**SOMEONE CUTS
AHEAD OF YOU IN
LINE**



**SOMEONE STEALS
YOUR CELL PHONE**



YOU LOSE A GAME



**YOU GET A BAD
GRADE ON A TEST**



**YOU DON'T LIKE
WHAT'S ON THE MENU**



**YOU'RE ALLERGIC
TO WHAT'S ON THE MENU**



**YOUR EMAIL
PASSWORD GETS
HACKED**



**SOMEONE SAYS
SOMETHING MEAN ON
SOCIAL MEDIA**



**SOMEONE THREATENS
YOU ON SOCIAL
MEDIA**



**YOU SPILL YOUR
DRINK**



**A FRIEND SENDS YOU
AN EMAIL WITH AN
INAPPROPRIATE
PICTURE**



**YOU SEE SOMEONE
SHOPLIFTING**



**A PROJECT YOU'VE
BEEN WORKING ON
GETS RUINED**



**THERE'S NO ROOM AT
YOUR LUNCH TABLE**



**YOU SEE A BUG IN THE
HOUSE**



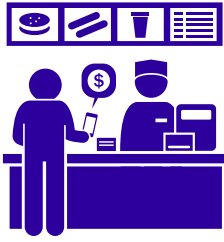
**YOU NEED TO USE
THE BATHROOM
DURING A TEST**



**IT'S NOISY WHEN
YOU'RE TRYING TO
STUDY**



**YOU CAN'T FALL
ASLEEP**



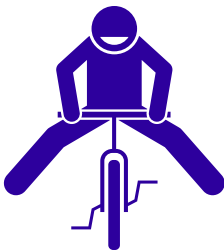
**YOU DON'T HAVE
ENOUGH MONEY
TO PAY**



**YOUR PET NEEDS TO
GO TO THE VET**



**YOU HAVE TO EAT
ALONE**



YOUR BIKE IS STOLEN



**YOU HAVE TO GET
A VACCINATION**



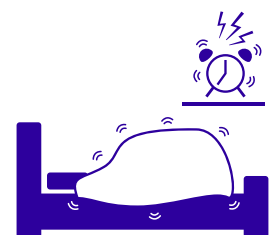
**YOU HAVE NO CELL PHONE
SERVICE**



**YOUR PACKAGE IS
STOLEN**



**A FRIEND WANTS TO
DO HOMEWORK
TOGETHER**



**YOU SLEPT THROUGH
THE ALARM**



YOU HAVE TO SIT NEXT
TO SOMEONE YOU
DON'T LIKE ON THE BUS



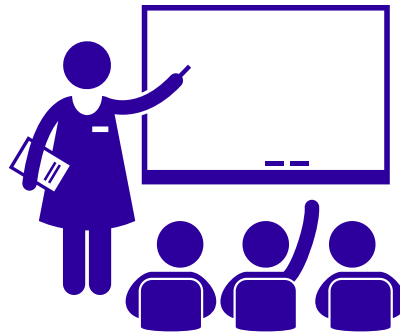
A FAMILY MEMBER
WANTS TO GIVE YOU
A HUG



SOMEONE GIVES YOU
A GIFT BUT YOU
DON'T LIKE IT



YOU HAVE A POP QUIZ



YOU CAN'T HEAR THE
TEACHER



SOMEONE TELLS YOU TO
BE DONE BEFORE YOU'RE
READY

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

EXERCISE #41

FLEXIBILITY FLOW CHART

BACKGROUND:

In situations that require flexibility, it can be helpful to have a list of strategies available to help us evaluate the situation or problem and make adjustments. Develop a flowchart or set of steps to follow each time you encounter a situation that requires greater flexibility.

SKILL AREAS:



FLEXIBILITY



PROBLEM SOLVING

SKILL LEVEL: Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Flexibility Flowchart Worksheet (p. 137)
- Pen/Pencil

INSTRUCTIONS:

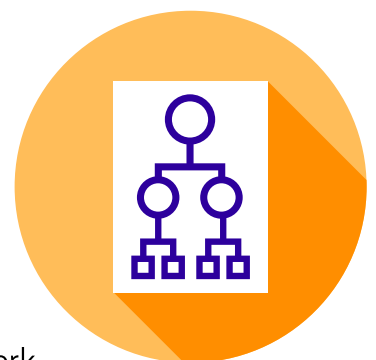
1. Download and print the Flexibility Flowchart Worksheet (p. 137)
2. Set aside 10-15 minutes to develop the lower part of the flowchart with ideas and suggestions to help with each type of problem.
3. For emergencies, record names and contact information for resources to use in emergencies. For example, include your local first-responders, 9-1-1, and anyone your learner should contact. In addition, include information about where to find other community resources (e.g., contact list stored in the Weekly Binder).
4. For big problems, select three strategies from the *Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook* chapters that have been helpful in difficult situations. The chapters on problem-solving, planning, and organization may be good places to start.
5. Finally, in the minor problems area, record strategies your learner can use when encountering scenarios that may be annoying or frustrating but require flexible thinking. Strategies can include exercises from the workbook or something simple like "Take 10 deep breaths." or "Call a parent."
6. When the flowchart is developed, practice plugging several problems into the START box of the flowchart and working through the problem with the learner.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for the flowchart should include the learner successfully using the flexibility flow chart to determine which situations require action and which situations require flexible thinking on at least 3 occasions.

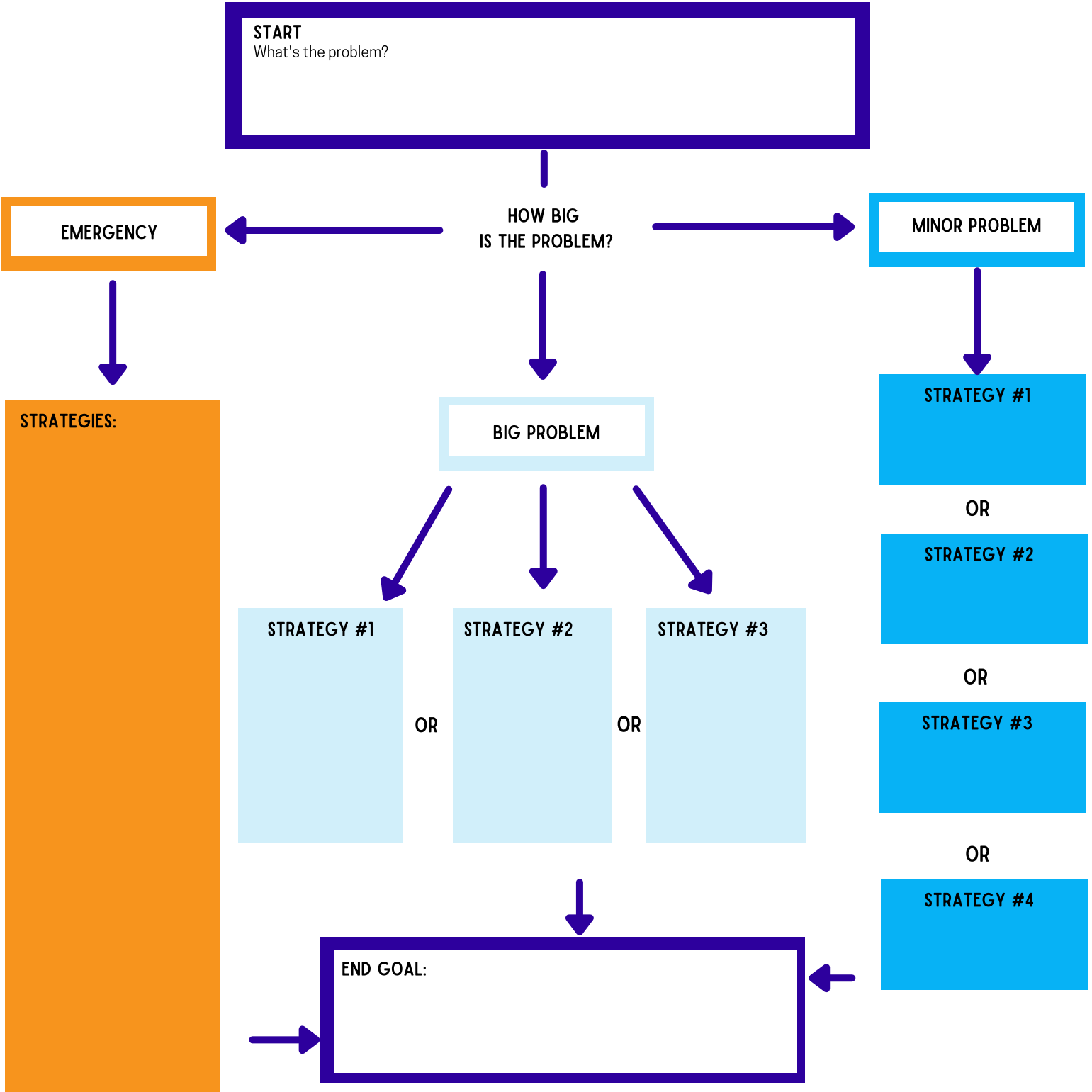
EXPANSION IDEAS:

There are several exercises in this workbook that fit well in the flowchart. Work with your learner to choose items that are most helpful for problem-solving (see Chapter 5) and maintaining emotional control (See Chapter 8).



FLEXIBILITY FLOW CHART

Using the diagram below, complete the flow chart outlining the steps you can take to be more flexible when needed. Use the exercises in other parts of the book to guide you in deciding what steps to take.



EXERCISE #42

CHANGE IS A GOOD THING

BACKGROUND:

We know that for some learners, cognitive flexibility is just plain frustrating. It tests our problem-solving and our patience. But sometimes change is a good thing. Many of the best inventions and human innovations have come from using flexible thinking. Use this exercise to evaluate ways that change and disruption might generate positive outcomes.

SKILL AREAS:



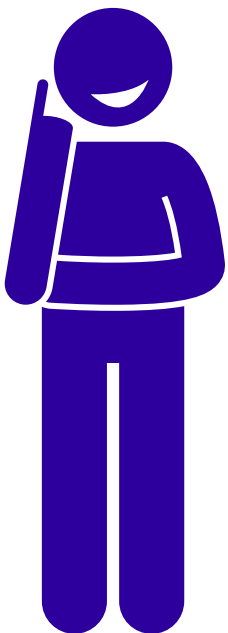
SKILL LEVEL: Easy to Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Pen
- Sheet of paper or Sandbox (see Exercise #6)
- Friend, Partner or Coach to brainstorm with

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Identify a quiet space, free from distractions for 15-20 minutes.
2. Start by dividing the sheet of paper into three sections. Under one section, write the title WHY CHANGE IS HARD. Under the middle section, write the title WHEN CHANGE WASN'T SO BAD. Finally, under the third section, write the title WHY CHANGE IS GOOD.
3. First, spend 3-5 minutes generating ideas and writing statements about why change and flexible thinking are hard. Brainstorm with your partner words and phrases that describe how change and having to be flexible makes you feel.
4. Next, think of a recent situation that required flexible thinking and adapting to change. Write 1-2 ideas in the middle section, describing scenarios where change wasn't bad. Finally, write about some outcomes that happened as a result of being flexible.
5. In the third column, spend 3-5 minutes generating and writing statements about why change and flexible thinking can be a good thing. Record ideas about the benefits of being flexible and when it might better payoff to adapt to change.
6. Review the list frequently or in situations where it might not be clear why it's important to be flexible.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Place the change is a good thing list in a place where it's easy to add to. In situations where change had an obvious benefit, encourage your learner to add to it until he or she can articulate the benefits of flexible thinking without difficulty.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If the "Change is A Good Thing" exercise connects with your learner, make a chart for other executive functioning skills. Make lists of when skills like planning (Chapter 1), organization (Chapter 4), or emotional control (Chapter 8) are hard but have some clear benefits.

EXERCISE #43

TRY MY WAY

BACKGROUND:

One barrier that gets in the way of flexible thinking is seeing something from another person's point of view. It can be hard if we're stuck in one thinking pattern to try another's idea or strategy. Practice the skill of taking another person's suggestions in easier "Try My Way" scenarios, so it's easier to be flexible in more challenging situations.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Select a 10-15 minute time without distractions to practice a familiar routine with a learner. Choose a neutral task (e.g., making a sandwich, folding a shirt, brushing teeth) that is easy for both you and the learner to demonstrate.
2. Before beginning, let the learner know that when you give the cue "Try It My Way," the learner should stop, listen to instructions, observe how to do the task differently, and then continue trying it with the new method.
3. Start with silly and unrelated changes at first (see Exercise #44 for ideas) and then gradually move to more subtle changes and focused on improving the learner's performance.
4. Provide positive feedback when the learner accepts the idea and switches to the new instructions.
5. At the end of the activity, ask the learner comprehension questions about what makes trying someone else's idea easier or more difficult.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Continue practicing the "Try My Way" scenarios until the learner can easily accept and adapt to changes during practiced routines. Then switch the more complex instructions or scenarios where the learner may have more trouble with accepting change. Mastery criteria include accepting a "Try My Way" in at least two different unplanned situations.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Use the cards from the other flexibility exercises in this chapter (see Exercise #40 & #44) for ideas on how to introduce changes to the routine. Some learners may benefit from using a problem-solving guide (see Exercise #39) or Frustration Folder (see Exercise #51) for handling more difficult situations.

SKILL AREAS:



FLEXIBILITY

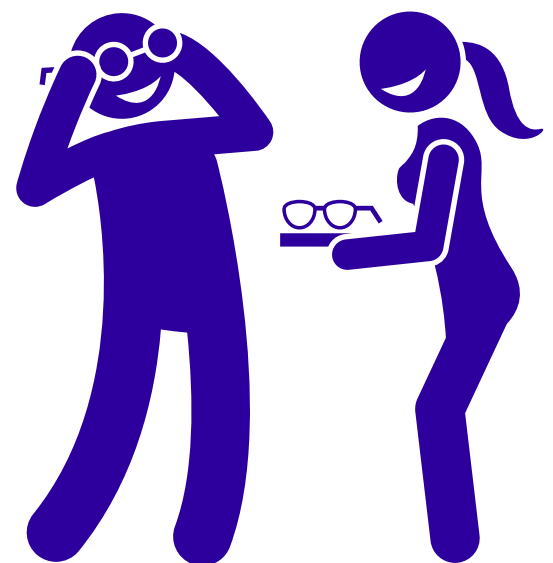


EMOTIONAL CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- A familiar household routine
- Friend, partner, caregiver, or coach to provide feedback



EXERCISE #44

MESSED UP MORNING

BACKGROUND:

We know that flexibility, like any other skill, improves the more we practice and rehearse. By taking time to practice unpredictability with our child or student's daily routines, setting aside times to role play, and giving your feedback in a contrived or non-threatening scenario, can all be ways to handle better the "disruptions" that happen in life.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Printable "Disruptions" Practice Cards (p. 141).
2. Review the flashcards and choose the most common problems relevant to the learner. Then, if necessary, use the blank cards to create flashcards with custom problem-solving scenarios.
3. Select a card from the deck.
4. Ask your learner to define the problem, choose an outcome, and then evaluate different actions.
5. Discuss the pro's and con's of each potential outcome
6. Consider all possibilities for taking each action until you and your partner agree upon an action to take.
7. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about solving various problems in the flashcard deck.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this objective may depend on your experience with some of the problem-solving scenarios found in the deck. For learners who still need some adult support, start with problems that have more obvious solutions (e.g. complete a school project due tomorrow vs. watch a movie with friends). Then move to problems where it's less obvious or scenarios where your learner consistently struggles.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If player-based exercises and activities like the Problem-Solving Practice Flashcards work well to learn new skills, expand by using the First/Then Flashcards to practice task initiation (see Exercise #23) or create a deck of flashcards for other executive functioning skills.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Disruptions Cards (p. 141)
- Friend, Partner or Coach to provide feedback

FLEXIBLE THINKING

"DISRUPTIONS DECK"



We know that flexibility, like any other skill, improves the more we practice and rehearse. By taking time to practice unpredictability with our child or student's daily routines, setting aside times to role play, and giving your feedback in a contrived or non-threatening scenario, can all be ways to handle better the "disruptions" that happen in life.

ACTIVITY:

1. Print and cut out a set of the disruptions deck flashcards.
2. Decide with your learner a day to practice the morning routine (or another set of routine tasks the learner feels comfortable with)
3. During each step of the morning routine, choose a card from the disruptions deck.
4. Ask your learner to try to complete the step of the routine according to the disruption outlined on the card.
5. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about managing any disruption that comes along the way.
6. At the end of the routine, discuss strategies that made it easier to handle disruptions and times when flexible thinking was most helpful.



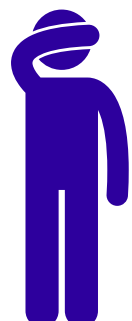
WALK BACKWARD



USE YOUR NON-DOMINANT HAND



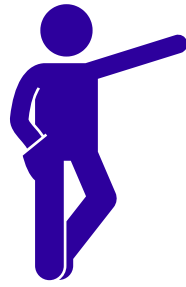
WITHOUT TALKING



COVER YOUR EYES



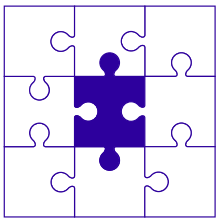
**SET A TIMER FOR
30 SECONDS**



**PUT ONE HAND IN
YOUR POCKET**



WITH A LOUD NOISE



**ONE PART YOU NEED
IS MISSING**



**WHILE SOMEONE
TALKS TO YOU**



**YOUR FAVORITE SONG
COMES ON**



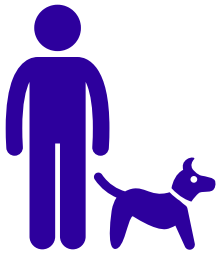
**WHILE STANDING
ON ONE FOOT**



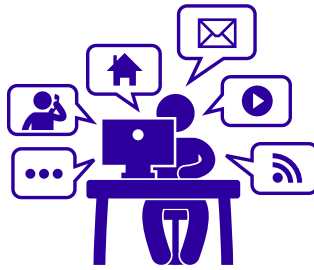
**WHILE CHECKING
SOCIAL MEDIA**



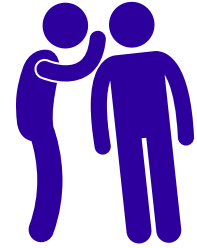
WHILE LAYING DOWN



**WITH A PET
AROUND**



**WHILE CHECKING
EMAIL**



**WHEN SOMEONE
TELLS YOU A SECRET**



**WHILE PLAYING A
VIDEO GAME**



**WHILE WATCHING A
VIDEO**



**AFTER SPINNING
3 TIMES**

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

EXERCISE #45

TRANSITION TRAINER

BACKGROUND:

Another skill included in flexibility involves shift or the skill of quickly and efficiently transitioning from one activity to another.

Some learners get hung up in changing gears rapidly, but practicing and rehearsing transitions can help over time make these unexpected changes easier to handle.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Dedicate 15-20 minutes to practice transition trainer in a quiet place without distractions.
2. Set out the five activities in a space so that it's possible to transition to each activity without shifting rooms or locations. For example, if using a video game, choose other indoor activities like reading a book, looking at a magazine, or folding laundry that can be completed close by.
3. Set the timer for 2 minutes. Alert the learner that when the timer goes off, they'll need to switch to whatever activity they're told to. They'll need to wrap up the activity and transition within 15 seconds of the timer going off.
4. Start the timer. When the timer goes off, call out the next activity.
5. Count how many seconds it takes the learner to transition.
6. Reset the timer for another 2 minutes.
7. Continue with Steps 4-6 until the learner has transitioned between all 5 activities.
8. Afterward, regroup to debrief. Ask the learner: what was easy or difficult about transitioning activities? Were some activities more difficult than others? How did it feel to have to shift so many times? What can they use about this activity to be more flexible during real-life transitions?

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Continue practicing the 5 activity transition trainer exercise with different activities until the learner can easily shift focus. Start with easy skills and gradually move to more challenging transitions.

Mastery of this exercise includes observing the learner transitioning from a preferred activity to a non-preferred activity when interrupted, without disruption on at least 2 different occasions.

SKILL AREAS:



FLEXIBILITY



TASK INITIATION

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Timer
- 5 activities (e.g. books, music, puzzle, tablet, video games, toys, etc.)
- Friend, Partner or Coach to give instructions

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Some activities may be easier to transition from than others for your learner.

Reviewing which activities are a "Big Deal or No Big Deal" (see Exercise #40) to transition between may be helpful to rehearse. If your learner has an emotional response during some transitions, use the activities in Chapter 8 to learn alternative responses to difficult transitions.

EXERCISE #46

STRETCH BREAK

BACKGROUND:

Cognitive flexibility has also been positively linked to mindfulness and meditation. Studies show that even brief mindfulness moments can help learners examine inflexible thoughts, or where they might be harboring tension in their physical body posture may be helpful to enhance flexible thinking.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Review the "Stretch Break" script on page 146. You may choose to download the script and print it out if necessary.
2. Find a quiet place, free from distractions. You'll need about 5-10 minutes to complete the script.
3. Read each step in the script. Remember that the purpose of meditation and mindfulness practice is to be present in the moment without placing any judgment. If you find a meditation to be challenging, try not to dwell on it. Instead, recognize thoughts that arise and then return to the body scan.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mindfulness training does not have a specific 'mastery criteria' since it's individualized to each person and each moment. Sometimes, the stretch break exercise will flow easily for a learner. Other days, it may be more challenging to move successfully through the script without getting distracted or frustrated.

Continue encouraging your learner to practice the stretch break at least once per day for a week or so. Re-evaluate at that time if your learner finds it easier to relax, let go of tension, and practice flexible thinking.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

There are hundreds of different scripts, YouTube videos, and app-based mindfulness and meditation resources available online. If your learner succeeds with this script, consider downloading some of the other online resources and customize. If your learner responds better with visualization, try video-based mindfulness activities on YouTube and streaming services.

SKILL AREAS:



FLEXIBILITY



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Stretch Break script (p. 146)
- Smartphone to record script or partner to read script aloud (optional)



FLEXIBLE THINKING

STRETCH BREAK SCRIPT



Cognitive flexibility has also been positively linked to mindfulness and meditation. Studies show that even brief mindfulness moments can help learners examine inflexible thoughts, or where they might be harboring tension in their physical body posture may be helpful to enhance flexible thinking.

Try this simple mindfulness exercise as a "Stretch Break" when you need help with greater flexibility. Read it slowly, pausing at each step. You may also want to record it on a smartphone or have a partner read each step aloud to you.

STRETCH BREAK SCRIPT

- Begin by finding a comfortable seat with your feet touching the floor or standing with your feet firmly on the ground.
- If you feel comfortable, close your eyes. Or find a spot ahead to rest your eyes gently.
- Take a deep breath in through the nose and then let it out through the mouth.
- Again, take another slow, deep breath in and out. Don't rush this step. It's the foundation for the rest of this mindfulness practice.
- On the next out-breath, begin to notice where your feet contact the floor. Notice any tension or sensations in your feet. How are they feeling right now? Are you feeling flexible or tight? Do you feel tension or like your feet are gripping tightly to something? If so, try to let go.
- Take a few more breaths.
- Next, follow the breath upwards. Begin to explore your belly and chest. What sensations do you feel right now? Do you feel tingling, tightness, or discomfort? Are you holding onto something? If so, take another deep breath and let go. Take a few more breaths. Imagine your in-breath and out-breath traveling deep into your belly and your chest. With each breath, you feel lighter and more flexible to face what's ahead.
- Now, take one more breath and travel up to your head. What are you feeling in your neck? Your face? The very tip-top of your head? Imagine your breath coming out of your nose. What does it feel like? Are you holding tension or tightness? Take another slow deep breath and relax.
- Feel free to stay here, examining any other parts of your body as you need. Then, when you're ready, gently open your eyes and check around the room. Rejoin your activities more relaxed and ready for flexible thinking.

EXERCISE #47

THAT'S UNFAIR

BACKGROUND:

We know that we all have limits to our flexibility. Sometimes our learners are asked to tolerate changes or adapt to the unexpected in ways that might make them feel uncomfortable or disrespected. As you work on improving flexibility, every learner needs to have a voice and a way to advocate for themselves if a tolerance situation goes too far. In "That's Unfair," the learner submits a notice (like a yellow card in soccer) flagging that a situation made them uncomfortable. The notice then opens the dialogue up for changes in the future.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print several copies of the printable "Fairness Warning" worksheet. Place the copies in a location where everyone in the home or classroom can easily access them.
2. Designate a public location (bulletin board, refrigerator, basket, etc.) to post warnings for everyone to review.
3. Review the worksheet with the learner. Inform them that each time they believe they were asked to tolerate or adapt to changes unfairly or beyond their personal limits, they should complete the worksheet and post it in the designated location.
4. When a worksheet is posted, set aside 15-30 minutes at an agreed-upon time to review the contents of the worksheet.
5. Complete the discussion questions at the bottom of the worksheet and develop a compromised plan in the future to prevent the situation from happening again.
6. If the scenario is not possible to prevent, practice potential strategies for the learner to use if they may need to tolerate the change again.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Initially, you may need to complete the worksheets together as your learner practices the skill of self-advocacy. Then, continue to practice the warnings until you're aware of common trigger points for tolerance and have established plans for everyone involved to know a learner's boundaries.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Fairness warnings can be applied to many different executive functioning skills. For example, allowing learners to advocate for their independence in planning, time management, and task initiation can reduce problem behavior and help everyone communicate more effectively.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Printable Fairness Warning Worksheet (p. 148)
- Bulletin Board, Refrigerator or other location to post the notice.



FAIRNESS WARNING



TODAY'S DATE: _____

DATE OF THE INCIDENT: _____

DESCRIBE THE INCIDENT:

WHY IS THIS A PROBLEM?

RESOLVING THE FAIRNESS WARNING

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS:

- How do others feel about this incident?
- Do we agree or disagree about what happened?
- How might this situation have been prevented?
- Is this situation likely to happen again?
- What steps can you and others take next time?
- What skills need to be learned?
- Are there SMART goals that need to be created and achieved?

THE PLAN:

What steps will occur in the future to prevent another fairness warning?



CHAPTER SEVEN: WORKING MEMORY

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Can you boost working memory?	
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WORKING MEMORY

Recall from our introduction the story of Sam and her academic struggles.

“She continually asks me to repeat the instructions.”

“I swear, she doesn’t remember what I tell her three minutes later.”

“She gets easily frustrated and then uses problem behavior when she forgets instructions.”

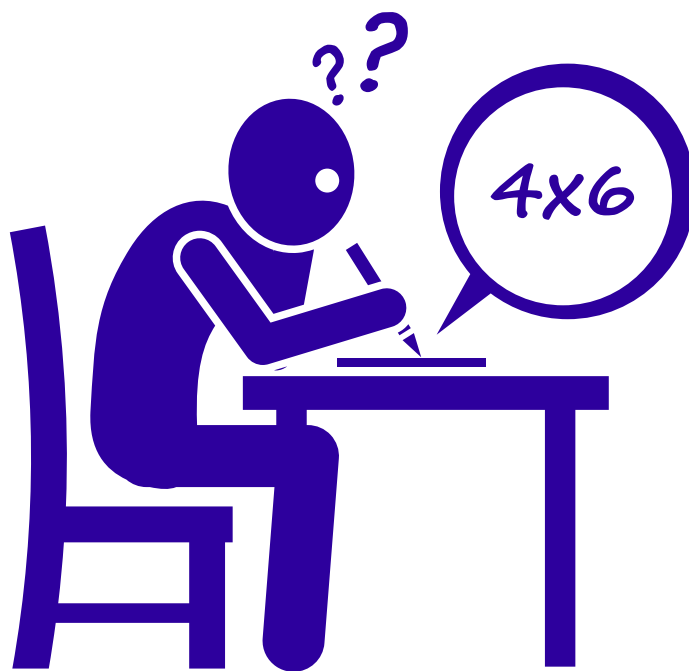
“Sam expects that I’m always around to help in the classroom if she can’t remember what to do.”

When Sam's parents and teachers sought help for her executive functioning challenges, one of the items that came up across the board was difficulties remembering information, following instructions, and frustration when Sam couldn't get the right answer. Given Sam's challenges with remembering and recalling information, her parents began to think she might have challenges with working memory.

THE BASICS OF WORKING MEMORY

Just like a computer, our brains have a limited capacity to store and retain information. Working memory describes our ability to remember information and recall it later when we need it later.

Working memory is commonly associated with academics like reading and math. In part because both of those skills require us to recall information like letter sounds, sight words, and simple math facts like



addition and subtraction. Working memory can also involve our ability to follow multiple-step instructions since we need to remember all parts of the task while completing the steps in order.

WORKING MEMORY AND OTHER EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING SKILLS

Not only is working memory closely associated with academic success, but it's also connected to other executive functioning skills. While we may think of it as short term recall of information, working memory also requires us to apply it to the right situations when needed. So it's not just information retention; it's about the application as well.

That's why boosting working memory can impact other executive functioning skills as well. Studies show:

- Good working memory helps us with concept formation or connecting existing ideas with new information (Cowan, 2014)
- Improvements in working memory can promote increases in attentional control. For example, we know that individuals who test well in working memory can more easily stay on task.
- Working memory can promote better impulse control and flexibility. When we have the right information at hand, we're less likely to make knee-jerk responses. We're also more likely to demonstrate flexible thinking, shifting our attention and applying different rules in different settings (Center on the Developing Child at Harvard University, 2011)



EXAMPLES OF WORKING MEMORY TASKS

- Recalling numbers, letters, and words, beginning with two digits and increasing to longer strings.
- Delivering a message to another person (e.g., "Go tell your brother it's time for dinner.")
- Completing simple errands (e.g., "Go to the refrigerator and get the milk.")
- Playing simple memory and matching games.
- Completing math facts and sight word worksheets.
- Completing two, three, and four-step tasks without needing additional instructions.
- Gathering information from one source and applying it to another setting.
- Keeping track of personal belongings, remembering and recalling where things are placed around the home and classroom.
- Using visual schedules, written reminders, and picture instructions to help recall information and complete tasks.
- Attempting to problem-solve first if they cannot recall the instruction before asking for help.
- Demonstrating self-control of problem behaviors if they require more help to remember an instruction.

NATURE OR NURTURE: CAN YOU BOOST WORKING MEMORY?

Like so many other psychology and child development areas, there's a debate among researchers about nature vs. nurture and working memory. Some believe we are born with a fixed working memory capacity. We inherit working memory through 'nature' or our genetics. Others believe that working memory can be 'nurtured' or increased through training and practice.

In part, this debate stems from the problems inherent in studying working memory. Individuals improve when given tools to boost working memory-related tasks like math, reading, and recalling factual information in both laboratory and applied settings. Some researchers question whether improvements we see are simply 'practice effects' or enhancements because of repeatedly doing the same tasks. Other researchers describe these improvements as an actual expansion in working memory.

But for all practical purposes, what's important is that **there's an improvement**. So even if we can't yet settle the nature vs. nurture debate, we can still help teens boost these skills.

STRATEGY TRAINING AND CORE TRAINING

There are two main ways to boost working memory skills: strategy training and core training. Both have shown promise in clinical and applied settings at helping learners improve how they remember information and use it in new environments.

Strategy Training

Strategy training involves teaching more effective ways to store, maintain and retrieve information from working memory. Strategy training aims to provide "tips and tricks" that apply to recalling information in various settings. One strategy is trained at a time and then generalized to many different working memory tasks. Things like using mnemonic devices and visualization exercises are two forms of strategy training that can be used for all types of recall tasks.

Core Training

Unlike strategy training with a specific tool or exercise to improve recall, core training attempts to reduce errors when working memory fails. Core training involves high intensity, the rapid repetition of working memory tasks, often under in the face of interference and challenge. Increasing how a teen recalls information under pressure improves the ability to "tune out the noise" or incorrect information.

Core training often includes a broad approach, with many different tasks and stimuli included in the training program. Practicing a diversity of skills at a high frequency potentially increases the likelihood of working memory gains.

OTHER STRATEGIES FOR WORKING MEMORY

In addition to strategy and core training, there are other options for students with unique learning needs.

1.Break it down.

Individuals with working memory challenges struggle with retaining complex instructions or lots of information at once. If you know your learner has difficulty managing lots of information at once, adjust your expectations and break steps down. Provide instructions step-by-step, or have your learner complete smaller components of a task and recruit feedback more frequently. Breaking tasks down may seem like taking a step backward, but ultimately, if you give your teen or young adult too much information and the process breaks down, you'll have to provide help anyway. Sometimes, less is more.

2.Reduce distractions.

Some working memory training exercises focus solely on helping individuals tune out irrelevant information and distractions. If you know your learner is heading into a complex task that demands full attention, an effective strategy to support success is to reduce as many distractions as possible. Turn off devices and screens. Play white noise or background ambient sounds to drown out conversations. By giving your teen or young adult fewer things to tune out, you increase the probability they'll stay focused on the task at hand.

3.Offer breaks.

Just as we look to break down tasks into simpler components to promote success, we can also help learners that struggle with working memory with more frequent breaks. Getting up to stretch, get a drink of water, or use the restroom can make a big difference for some learners who have difficulty with an intense focus on complex tasks. For some learners who have good working memory skills but struggle with the motivation to apply them in academic or vocational settings, more frequent breaks can improve performance on tedious or less-preferred tasks.

GETTING STARTED WITH WORKING MEMORY GOALS

To begin identifying the best tools and strategies for learning better working memory skills, take the pre-assessment on the next page which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child. You may also find it helpful to begin with the Learning Styles Inventory Exercise (p. 155) to determine which mode of instruction will work best for helping your child boost working memory.

Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and planning how you might accomplish working memory-related goals.

WORKING MEMORY PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the working memory exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

I pay close attention to details to avoid mistakes.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I have strong reading and math skills.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can remember multiple instructions for tasks.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Others say I have a good attention span.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can see chores, homework, and tasks through to the end.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I don't often forget what I'm doing or get lost in the middle of a task.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can keep track of lots of facts and information and recall them when I need it.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For information about different learning styles

48

To help learners prepare better to follow complex instruction

4950

EXERCISE #48

LEARNING STYLES

BACKGROUND:

When identifying the best strategies to help boost working memory, it may help first identify your learning style. This learning styles inventory evaluates the preferred and most effective learning model for students. Determining if you might be a visual (learn by "seeing" information), haptic or kinesthetic (learn by "doing and moving"), or auditory (learn by "hearing" information) learner can help guide the best ways to boost executive functioning skills like working memory.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Learning Styles Inventory (p. 156).
2. Spend 5-10 minutes reading the inventory, marking which responses make the most sense for your learner. Try to think about the most common examples and avoid dwelling on 'exceptions' when answering each item.
3. Use the attached score sheet (p. 157) to calculate your learner's score.
4. Read about the different learning styles and evaluate how to incorporate the information into upcoming SMART goals.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this exercise requires completing the Learning Styles Inventory for you or your learner. However, the greatest value of the inventory comes from customizing other executive functioning exercises in this book based on the outcome. Look to develop and incorporate the strongest learning style into teaching activities for your learner.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The information in the Learning Styles Inventory can be incorporated into any of the exercises in this workbook. Look to expand your learner's use of their strongest learning mode as you're teaching the rest of the exercises in this text.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Printable Learning Styles Inventory (p. 156) and Score Sheet (p. 157)



LEARNING STYLES INVENTORY

To complete the quiz below, read each statement. Place a checkmark in the box that corresponds to the response that matches most closely for you or your learner.

1. I remember things better if I write them down.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
2. I remember things that I hear better than things that I see.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
3. I remember things best when I'm shown how to do them.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
4. I'd rather someone just tell me what to do than figure it out on my own	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
5. I'd rather just start doing and figure it out on my own.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
6. I'd rather visualize the steps I need to do first and then get started.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
7. I like to make lists, flash cards, and take pictures to help me remember things.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
8. I like to learn from podcasts, lectures, or conversations with others.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
9. I like to use my hands and 'trial-and-error' to get the right answer.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
10. When I buy something new, I open the box and just start playing around with it.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
11. When I buy something new, I read the directions before I use it.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐
12. When I buy something new, I'll watch a video or listen to someone at the store show me how to use it.	NEVER ☐	SOMETIMES ☐	ALWAYS ☐

SCORE SHEET

STEP 1: Record your score for each item in the box below:

0 points = NEVER

1 point = SOMETIMES

3 points = ALWAYS

STEP 2: Add up the total score for each column and enter the total in the TOTAL box.

STEP 3: Assign a rank for the highest to lowest scores. The highest score indicates a learning style preference.

VISUAL

1

6

7

11

TOTAL

RANK

AUDITORY

2

4

8

12

TOTAL

RANK

KINESTHETIC

3

5

9

10

TOTAL

RANK



VISUAL

- Learns by seeing or watching demonstrations.
- Vivid imagination.
- Thinks in images.
- Able to visualize in great detail.
- Often distracted by movement.
- Recognized words by sight.
- Sometimes stops an activity to "imagine" or intensely concentrate on a visual image.
- Memory improves when writing things down or taking notes.



AUDITORY

- Learns through verbal instructions.
- Enjoys dialogue and uses sub-vocalizations.
- Imagines in sounds.
- Problem-solves by talking things out, with others or with self.
- Recognizes words through phonics and auditory word attack.
- Easily distracted by sounds.
- Memory improves with auditory repetition or "catch phrases"



KINESTHETIC

- Learns through physical activities.
- Enjoys whole body movement.
- Problem-solves by manipulating tools and objects.
- Prefers trial-and-error learning.
- Recognizes words by writing them down or air-spelling with a finger
- Memory improves with mind-mapping, role playing and manipulatives.

EXERCISE #49

WHAT DO I NEED?

BACKGROUND:

While we may want our learner to ‘just know’ or ‘remember it all,’ a more realistic strategy for an individual with working memory deficits might be to use a checklist to remember essential things. Independence with an activity, even if aided with an intervention tool like a reminder list, is still a greater level of independence. Use the What Do I Need? Worksheet to help your learner gather necessary materials for an event or packing for an activity.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the What Do I Need? Worksheet (p. 159).
2. Before beginning a multiple-step or complex project, set aside 10-15 minutes to create a brief outline or schedule for the steps of the project.
3. Provide a goal or outcome for the project and as many details as possible to help the learner remember each step. For trips and events, steps may be written out in a schedule or time-based format.
4. After outlining the steps, go through them one by one and write down the materials needed for each step. Then, identify any items, needs, or materials that the learner must gather to complete that stage of the project.
5. As materials are gathered, use the worksheet as a checklist to ensure everything is packed or prepared ahead.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Generating a list of required materials can take practice, even for individuals with good working memory skills. Start with simpler tasks (5 or fewer steps) first until you are comfortable and fluent with the procedure. Then move on to more complex tasks with more steps. Consider this exercise mastered when you can generate and gather materials lists for new projects.

SKILL AREAS:



WORKING
MEMORY



PLANNING

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- What Do I Need?
Worksheet (p. 159)



EXPANSION IDEAS:

Many people find the What Do I Need? exercise to be helpful when paired with the Weekly Planning Meeting (see Exercise #3) and the Sandbox (see Exercise #6). If you have a learner who finds this helpful strategy for routine tasks, make copies and use the materials checklist every time.

WHAT DO I NEED?

WORKSHEET

Use this worksheet to gather all the required information and materials you need to complete a multi-step project.

PROJECT:

DUE:

GOAL: Describe the outcome or goal of the project.

DESCRIBE THE STEPS

Outline each step of the project. Write the steps in order and include enough detail to use as a guide when completing the project.

MATERIALS

Write the materials or resources you will need for each step of the project. When you have the item or have used it, check it off the list

☐

☐

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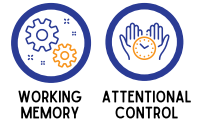
EXERCISE #50

SUMMARIZE

BACKGROUND:

If your learner struggles with retaining instructions, you might find the "say it back" strategy to be an effective way to help them retain steps. By asking for a summary, you're increasing the probability of remembering the information.

SKILL AREAS:



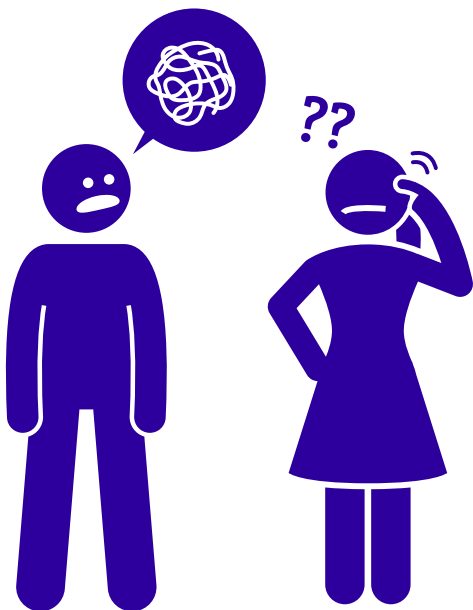
SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- A friend or partner to provide instructions.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Set aside 10-15 minutes in a 'learning session' to practice this activity.
2. Provide the learner with instructions that you are going to give them a task to do. Give simple, clear instructions for each step in the task.
3. Immediately after giving the instruction, follow up with the question, "Now, what are you supposed to do?" Next, ask the learner to summarize the instructions that were just given.
4. If the learner summarizes correctly, say "Now, go do it" and observe the learner. If they cannot summarize, prompt them to listen again carefully and re-state the instructions and ask again. Continue until the learner accurately repeats the instructions back.
5. Provide positive feedback when the learner completes the instructions correctly. If needed, prompt the learner to verbally summarize the instructions again if they get distracted or need additional help.
6. Repeat the practice for additional instructions, starting with easy instructions first and gradually increasing to more complicated tasks.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Continue practicing 10-15 minute 'summarize sessions' until your learner feels comfortable repeating the instruction back in summary (and then completing the task correctly after). As the instructions indicate, it's best to start with shorter, easier tasks first and then expand to more complex tasks. Continue until your learner independently uses the summarize technique outside of sessions without support.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The summarize exercise works well for learners who have auditory strengths. Identify if this might be your learner using the Learning Styles Inventory (see Exercise #48).



CHAPTER EIGHT: EMOTIONAL CONTROL

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EMOTIONAL CONTROL

Let's think back again to our introduction story of Sam and her outburst at school.

On a typical Tuesday evening, it's around 10 pm when Sam finally gets around to doing homework. She's tired and rushes through the project so she can go to sleep. The next day Sam turns in her assignment. Her teacher can see that Sam didn't do her best work, so Sam has to keep working while her friends get time to talk and text at the end of class.

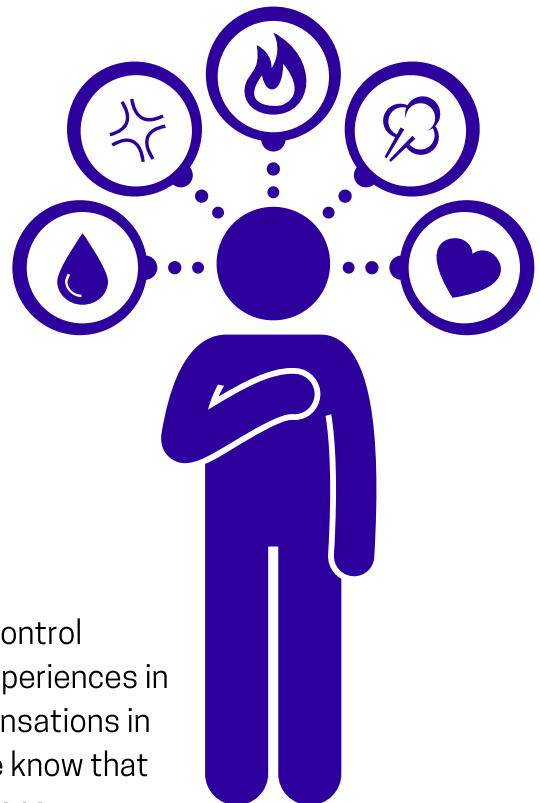
Frustrated and angry, Sam yells at her teacher. "You're just another person out to get me!" storms out of the classroom, bumping another student hard into the wall on her way out the door. As Sam storms down the hallway, she knows her teacher is already calling the principal...

The example above showcases a breakdown in emotional control. Sam's response to her teacher's feedback and not getting to relax at the end of class happens in thousands of homes and classrooms every day. As students like Sam grow into adulthood, the negative consequences for challenges in emotional control only increase.

As a parent, educator, or coach, what we know about emotional control can be a game-changer in promoting success and achievement in students like Sam.

WHAT IS EMOTIONAL CONTROL?

Sometimes known as emotional regulation, emotional control describes how we manage and respond to emotional experiences in the environment. Experiencing emotions can include sensations in the body and the thoughts that go along with them. We know that teens and young adults experience both positive emotions



(excitement, joy, happiness, pride, etc.) and negative emotions (disappointment, sadness, guilt, frustration, overwhelm, etc.) It's what we do about those emotional states that become important. Learning to respond to positive and negative emotions is the essence of emotional control.

WHY EMOTIONAL CONTROL IS IMPORTANT

Research supports that emotional control is among the most critical skills necessary for children and teens to grow into healthy and independent adults. According to the University of North Carolina at Greensboro Center for Youth, Family, and Community Partnerships (CYFP), effectively managing emotions can impact:

- Academic achievement
- School readiness
- Mental health
- Student-teacher and parent-child relationships
- Peer-to-peer relationships



EXAMPLES OF EMOTIONAL CONTROL

- Labeling basic emotions in self and in others.
- Using conversations or statements to express emotions and actions.
- Learning to control upset behavior, tantrums, and meltdowns.
- Describing the sensations of emotions in the body.
- Labeling advanced and subtle emotions in self and others including empathy, suffering, affection, disappointment, etc.
- Using perspective-taking to see another's point of view.
- Talking or writing about past events and reflecting on how to manage emotions in the future.
- Talking to a trusted friend about challenges and concerns.
- Noticing and asking when it's necessary to take a break.

When teens and young adults fail to demonstrate good emotional control and regulation, it can also cause negative impacts, including:

- Avoiding work or school activities.
- Excessive social media use.
- Procrastinating on other responsibilities.
- Physical or verbal aggression.
- Self-injury or self-harm.
- Abusing food, alcohol, or other substances.

EMOTIONAL CONTROL AND PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

While the behaviors above might happen after a stressful event, individuals with unique learning needs may also have heightened responses at the moment. Ask yourself if any of these problem behaviors related to emotional control describe your child:

Does your child have frequent outbursts?

Get in trouble at school for blurting, hyperactivity, or out-of-seat behavior when excited?

Over-reactions or violent/aggressive behavior when upset?

Does your child struggle to bounce back after a setback?

Engage in high rates of negative thoughts?

All of these may contribute to a need for increased development of emotional control. By improving emotional control skills, your child can begin to use strategies other than problem behavior to respond to emotions. While in some ways, it is developmentally appropriate for children and teens to rely on adult support for emotional control. However, developing greater emotional control allows children to recognize emotions as physical sensations in the body, rather than being controlled by them or act upon them.

EMOTIONAL CONTROL AND EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING SKILLS

Improving your teen's emotional control may ultimately mean targeting other executive functioning skills. In our introduction, for learners like Sam, emotional outbursts and problem behaviors may be related to skill deficits in planning and organization. If we address the root issues related to these other skill areas, problem behaviors decrease.

Teaching skills in time management, organization, and task initiation may be more difficult for other learners without addressing emotional control first. Learners who don't have strong skills to respond to frustration and failure may need to work on those strategies first. For these learners, focus first on keeping emotions in check and ultimately learning other executive functioning skills becomes more manageable.

Other considerations when teaching emotional control:

Emotional triggers frequently happen for children, teens & young adults.

21st-century kids have busier schedules than ever, crammed with school, work, hobbies, friends, and family. It also means their schedules are also packed full of opportunities where frustration, disappointment, and challenges emotions occur. Relationships also become more complex, and the expectations for social behaviors increase in our adolescent years. Being intentional about practicing emotional regulation skills can be an essential part of helping reduce the stress and manage the emotional triggers that often happen for our learners.

Emotional control won't just 'happen.' It comes from learned experience and skill-building.

While many parents and teachers take a "hope for the best" strategy for emotional control, research shows it's better to be intentional about helping your teen build these skills.

Especially for teens with unique learning needs, who may or may not need customized interventions to learn new skills, assuming that emotional control will just 'happen over time' puts your teen at risk for falling behind and experiencing greater stress.

We learn about emotional regulation by watching others, talking about emotions, and getting feedback on our behavior. It takes many more learning opportunities for some teens to learn emotional control than others.

When having conversations with your teen about emotional regulation, it can be helpful to talk about real-life situations and triggers you also experience. It's easy for us to keep emotions to ourselves and not necessarily allow our teens to see the hundreds of emotional regulation responses we make throughout the day.

For example, when someone cuts you off in the parking lot for the best parking space, label the emotion and the emotional response. "Look at that! How frustrating! That wasn't very nice of that driver. But it's no big deal; I'll find another spot." Show your teen that they aren't the only one that has difficult emotions. Narrate your emotional thoughts and how you're handling them appropriately.

Consequences Will Only Get More Challenging

The final reason we like to offer parents and teachers for tackling emotional control is that the consequences of emotional dysregulation only get more severe as children grow older.

Pushing another student might mean a trip to the principal's office as a teen. Pushing another adult in the grocery store could mean criminal charges as an adult. Refusing to complete a task at home might mean losing access to screen time. Refusing to complete a task as an adult could mean getting fired from a job. Learning to manage emotions, avoid conflict, and avoid impulsive behavior while the consequences are less severe is critical for preventing more severe consequences later.

GETTING STARTED WITH EMOTIONAL CONTROL GOALS

To begin identifying the best tools and strategies for learning better emotional control, take the pre-assessment on the next page, which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child. Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to identify and plan how you might accomplish emotional control goals.

EMOTIONAL CONTROL

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify emotional control exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

When bad things happen, I bounce back easily.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can control my temper.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I handle frustration in healthy ways.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Others say I have good patience.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

When I get upset, it's easy for me to calm down and get back to work.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I avoid saying things to 'get back' or hurt someone when I'm upset.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I have a high tolerance for frustration. I can work through difficult things.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

To help learn new coping strategies to use in emotional situations

51 52 53 55

To help learners practice managing challenging emotional situations

54 56

To help learners understand the consequences of using and not using emotional control

57 58

EXERCISE #51

FRUSTRATION FOLDER

BACKGROUND:

Once you have tested several of the emotional control strategies in *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*, you may find yourself coming back to the same worksheets and exercises again and again. It can be helpful to organize them in one place, so it's easy to find the right tool to cope with frustration when you need it most. Each time you need to keep your cool, open up your vision board and choose one of the tools.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Begin by making a list of the four or five primary areas of your life where you frequently need to use tools to manage an emotional situation. These areas might include things like home, school, and work.
2. Open the file folder and lay it out flat.
3. Segment out the folder into the primary areas you identified on your list by drawing lines or cutting and gluing different colored papers. Label each area.
4. Under each area, identify the emotional control strategies that you've found to be most effective in those areas. Then, write keywords, draw pictures, or cut out images to remind each area. For example, under "SCHOOL," you might write "Get a drink of water." or cut out the header for "Exercise #55" to remind yourself where to look in the workbook.
5. In the file folder, place additional copies of key worksheets and printables that you use regularly.
6. Each time you need to use a strategy to help boost your emotional control, take out your frustration folder and select a strategy that you've already identified as helpful.
7. As you work through the workbook or identify a new useful emotional control strategy, add to the list under each different primary area.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Vision boards can be completed once or can be working archives added to or subtracted from as needed. Work with your learner to develop an emotional control frustration folder, and then continue the process until they can independently open the folder and select a strategy. Note that each of the strategies may need to be specifically taught before putting them into the folder.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner finds the frustration folder and vision board helpful, consider creating a file folder vision board for other executive functioning skills like planning (see Exercise #2), problem-solving (see Exercise #39), and self-monitoring (see Exercise #74).

SKILL AREAS:



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to
Moderate

MATERIALS:

- File folder
- Basic art materials (markers, scissors, glue, tape, etc.)
- Printable worksheets *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook* exercises and worksheets

EXERCISE #52

STOP, THINK, ACT

BACKGROUND:

One evidence-based method to teach children and teens to use better emotional control is the “STOP, THINK, ACT” method. It's been researched in various contexts and shown to disrupt the knee-jerk or impulsive, emotional reactions to difficult problems.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the STOP, THINK, ACT guide (p. 169). Next, identify a simple household task that your learner can easily complete without assistance. Finally, inform your learner that during the task, you're going to create a disruption.
2. Review each step of the STOP, THINK, ACT procedure with your learner.
3. First, demonstrate the household task for the learner and show them how to STOP, THINK, ACT to solve a problem.
4. Next, allow your learner to take a turn with the household task and the STOP, THINK, ACT method.
5. Continue practicing different problems until your learner can independently use the method to problem solve and maintain good emotional control.
6. Move on to additional tasks and more difficult disruptions and provide positive feedback to your learner on successful problem solving and emotional control.

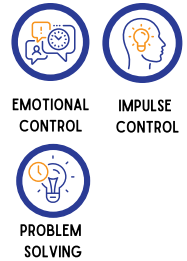
MASTERY CRITERIA:

As mentioned in Step 6, continue with additional tasks and more difficult emotional situations to practice the STOP, THINK, ACT method. Encourage your learner to review situations after using the method and how they might problem-solve or use good emotional control. Continue until the learner demonstrates the STOP, THINK, ACT method independently in challenging emotional situations.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The STOP, THINK, ACT method can be combined with other executive functioning practice to improve skills like problem-solving (see Exercise #35) and flexibility (see Exercise #44). If you need additional ideas for scenarios to practice, review Tough Stuff (see Exercise #54) or Big Deal No Big Deal (see Exercise #40).

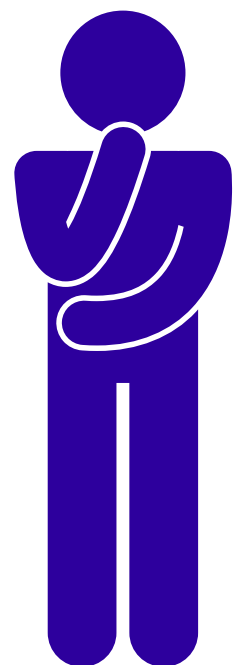
SKILL AREAS:



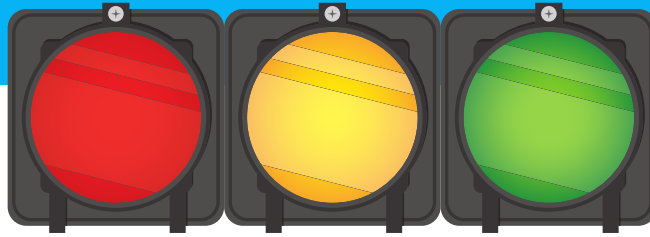
SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- STOP, THINK, ACT Printable Guide (p. 169)
- Household tasks



STOP THINK ACT METHOD



STOP

Pause. Take a breath.
Avoid acting on impulse



THINK

What is the problem?
What are the options?
What is the best path forward?



ACT

Proceed with the best option.
Act carefully and revise if
needed.

My other strategies:

When does Stop Think Act work the best for me?

EXERCISE #53

BODY SCAN

BACKGROUND:

Year over year, our understanding continues to grow on why and how mindfulness meditation supports emotion regulation. There's a strong link between teens and young adults who practice mindfulness exercises (breath control, body scans, attending to emotional responses, etc.) and control emotions under stress. One of the most valuable skills you can build with your child or student is doing simple mindfulness activities like a body scan.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download the Body Scan Script (p. 171-172). You may select to print the worksheet out and read the steps aloud or use an audio recording device (smartphone, digital voice recorder, etc.) to pre-record the script to listen to.
2. Identify a quiet, distraction-free location to work with your learner. Ask your learner to pay attention to how they feel before the body scan.
3. Instruct your learner to focus on each step of the body scan, reading slowly through the steps.
4. After completing the body scan, ask your learner to report back how they feel and any improvements.
5. Repeat often until your learner feels comfortable completing the body scan independently.

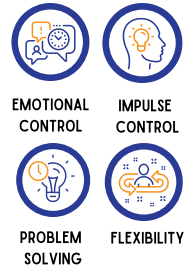
MASTERY CRITERIA:

Body scans and other mindfulness activities do not have a specific 'mastery criteria' since it's individualized to each person and each moment. Sometimes, the body scan exercise will flow easily for a learner. On other days, it may be more challenging to move successfully through the script without getting distracted or frustrated. Continue encouraging your learner to practice the body scan at least once per day for a week or so. Re-evaluate at that time if your learner finds it easier to relax, let go of tension, and practice better emotional control.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

There are hundreds of different scripts, YouTube videos, and app-based mindfulness and meditation resources available online. Try Exercise #46 (Stretch Break) to practice flexible thinking and an alternative to the body scan script listed here. If your learner succeeds with this script, consider downloading some of the other online resources and customize.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Easy to Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Body Scan Script (p. 171-172)
- Quiet, distraction free space.
- Audio recording device (optional)

EMOTIONAL CONTROL

BODY SCAN SCRIPT



Emotional control and regulation have been positively linked to mindfulness and meditation practices. Studies show that even brief mindfulness moments can help learners calm emotions. In addition, examining where they might be harboring tension in their physical body posture may be helpful to navigate stressful situations.

Try this simple mindfulness exercise when you need help with emotional control. Record it on a smartphone or read each step silently as you begin to relax.

BODY SCAN SCRIPT

- Begin by finding a comfortable seat with your feet touching the floor or laying on your back in a comfortable location, arms at your sides, and feet resting gently facing outward.
- If you feel comfortable, gently close your eyes.
- Take a deep breath in through the nose and then let it out through the mouth. Then, again, take another slow, deep breath in and out. Don't rush this step. It's the foundation for the rest of this mindfulness practice.
- On the next out-breath, begin to notice the sensations in the toes of your feet. Notice any tension or sensations in your toes. How are they feeling right now? Are you feeling flexible or tight? Do you feel tension or like your toes are gripping tightly to something? If so, try to let go.
- Take a few more breaths.
- Next, follow the breath upwards. Begin to explore the feelings in your feet and ankles. What sensations do you feel right now? Do you feel tingling, tightness, or discomfort? Are you holding onto something? If so, take another deep breath and let go. Take a few more breaths. Imagine your in-breath traveling down to your feet. With each breath, your feet become more relaxed.
- Take a few more breaths.
- Now focus your attention on the feelings in your shins and knees. Do you feel any tightness? Pressure? Heat or warmth? Visualize relaxing your body as you continue to breathe.

EMOTIONAL CONTROL

BODY SCAN SCRIPT



- In the next out-breath, gently shift your focus to your thighs, hips, and tailbone. As you slowly move up your body, imagine your breath moving deeply into these areas of your body. Releasing any tension or tightness.
- Just rest here as you take several more breaths.
- Now, gently shift your focus upward to your belly. What sensations are you feeling in your belly right now? Gently release any tension or stress from the day you might be holding in your core.
- Continue upward to your chest and heart. Many of us feel our emotions the most in the chest and our hearts. It's where we might feel anxious, upset, disappointed, or fear. Recognize any sensations you might be having in your chest. Take another slow deep breath and relax.
- Rest here for several more breaths before shifting your focus up to your neck and head. What are you feeling in your neck? Your face? The very tip-top of your head? Does your body feel tired? Relaxed? Tightness? Tingling or heat?
- Focus your attention on the breath coming out of your nose. What does it feel like? Are you holding tension or tightness? Take another slow deep breath and relax.
- Now that you have focused on each area of your body shift your focus back to your entire body and take several deep breaths. Feel free to stay here, examining any other parts of your body as you need.
- When you're ready, gently open your eyes and check around the room. Then, rejoin your activities more relaxed and ready to respond to whatever lies ahead.

EXERCISE #54

TOUGH STUFF

BACKGROUND:

Emotional control doesn't just happen—it takes practice. The scenarios in the Tough Stuff Flashcard Deck are all situations where you might struggle to control emotions. Use the flashcards to rehearse and practice with a coach on choosing a safe and smart resolution to the problem.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download, print, and cut out a set of the emotional control "tough stuff" flashcard deck (p. 173). There are several blank cards to create your own cards if needed.
2. Select a card from the deck.
3. Ask your learner to define the problem, choose an outcome, and then evaluate different actions.
4. Discuss potential emotional responses and why they might not be the best option to resolve the issue.
5. Discuss alternative outcomes and possibilities for other actions until a course of action is agreed upon.
6. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about handling the issue without an emotional response.

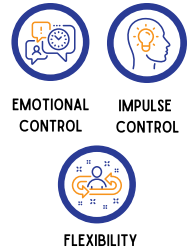
MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this objective may depend on your learner's experience with some of the emotional control scenarios found in the deck. For learners who still need some support from a coach to make the best choice, start with situations that have more obvious solutions. Then move to scenarios where it's less obvious or scenarios where your learner consistently struggles with emotional control.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If card-based exercises and activities like the 'Tough Stuff' Flashcards work well to learn new skills, expand by using the First/Then Flashcards to practice task initiation (see Exercise #23) or "Big Deal/No Big Deal" cards to practice flexibility (see Exercise #40). If your learner needs some more practice with identifying solutions, try the Stop, Think, Act Method (see Exercise #53) or Problem-Solving Playbook (see Exercise #39)

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Tough Stuff Deck (p. 173)
- Friend or coach to provide feedback



"TOUGH STUFF"

EMOTIONAL CONTROL DECK

Emotional control doesn't just happen—it takes practice. The Tough Stuff Flashcard Deck scenarios are all situations where your teen might struggle to control emotions. Use the flashcards to rehearse and practice choosing a safe and smart resolution to the problem.

ACTIVITY:

1. Print and cut out a set of the emotional control "tough stuff" flashcards.
2. Select a card from the deck.
3. Ask your learner to define the problem, choose an outcome, and then evaluate different actions.
4. Discuss outcomes and possibilities for taking each action until a course of action is agreed upon.
5. Rehearse and provide feedback to your learner until they feel confident about handling the issue without an emotional response



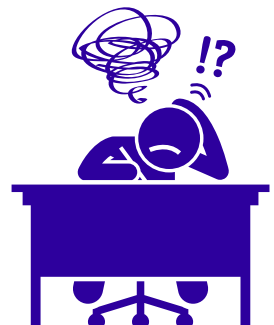
A FRIEND IS YELLING AT YOU



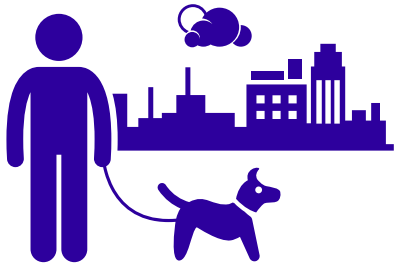
**YOU DON'T LIKE
WHAT'S ON THE
MENU**



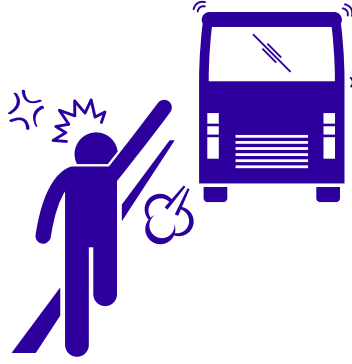
**YOU CAN'T LOG INTO
A CLASS WEBSITE**



**YOU HAVE A LARGE
HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT
DUE TOMORROW**



**YOU LOST
YOUR PET**



YOU MISSED THE BUS



**YOU'RE NERVOUS
ABOUT A
PRESENTATION**



YOU LOST THE GAME



**YOUR LIVE STREAM
QUITS**



**YOUR TEACHER DOESN'T
UNDERSTAND YOU**



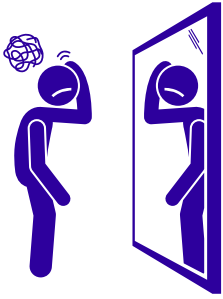
**YOUR CAR
BROKE DOWN**



**YOUR ROOM IS A
MESS**



**YOU'RE ANGRY AT A
FRIEND**



**YOU DON'T LIKE HOW
YOU LOOK TODAY**



LAST IN LINE



**YOU DON'T FEEL
WELL TODAY**



**YOU DON'T HAVE ENOUGH
MONEY TO BUY
SOMETHING**



**YOU DON'T KNOW
HOW TO DO
HOMEWORK**



**A FRIEND IS TOO
LOUD**



**YOU LOST
YOUR PHONE**



**YOU CAN'T STOP
THINKING ABOUT
SOMETHING**



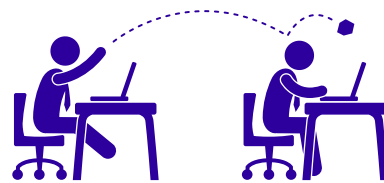
**SOMEONE LEAVES A
MEAN COMMENT**



**YOU'RE TOO TIRED TO
DO HOMEWORK**



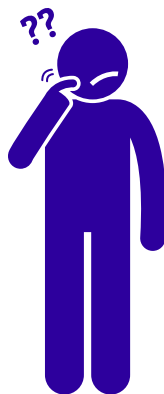
**A FRIEND IS GETTING
BULLIED AT SCHOOL**



**YOU'RE GETTING
BULLIED AT SCHOOL**



**A FRIEND IS
SPREADING GOSSIP
ABOUT YOU**



**YOU FORGOT WHAT
YOUR PARENT TOLD
YOU TO DO**



WORK IS TOO HARD

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

CREATE YOUR OWN

EXERCISE #55

WHAT WOULD ____ DO?

BACKGROUND:

When having conversations about emotion regulation, it can be helpful to talk about real-life situations and triggers from others' experiences. Looking at emotionally charged situations from the lens of our favorite celebrity, athlete, or fictional character can sometimes help learners with unique needs connect with strategies to help their own emotional control.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the "What Would ____ Do?" Worksheet (pg. 179). Identify a quiet space without distractions to spend 10-15 minutes completing the reflection worksheet.
2. Ask your learner to brainstorm a person (fictional or in real-life) that they believe is a good role model for handling difficult situations. If your learner has difficulty with this step, consider celebrities, professional athletes, social media influencers, or fictional hero/heroine characters from their favorite movies and tv shows.
3. Begin answering the questions on the reflection worksheet, including helping your learner evaluate strategies they've observed this person use for emotional regulation. Finally, discuss the consequences that might happen to the individual if they did not demonstrate emotional regulation.
4. Post the reflection worksheet in a location your learner is likely to see and review it from time to time (see Exercise #34).
5. When your learner struggles with emotional regulation or control, ask them to reflect "What would ___ do?" using their role model as a guide.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Some learners may complete the reflection worksheet and then independently identify strategies to use for emotional control.

Others might need frequent reminders or to complete the worksheet with multiple role models. Mastery criteria involve independently completing the sheet and implementing an emotional regulation strategy without support.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If having a list of solutions easily accessible to your learner is helpful, try Problem-Solving Playbook (see Exercise #39) and Frustration Folder (see Exercise #51) and incorporate celebrities and role models into the strategies.

SKILL AREAS:



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- What Would They Do? Worksheet (p. 179)



WHAT WOULD _____ DO?

TODAY'S DATE: _____

MY VIP: _____



Why does this person make a good role model for emotional control?

What does this person say or do in difficult situations instead of getting upset?

What might happen if this person did not show good emotional control?

WHAT WOULD _____ DO?

**DESCRIBE THE SITUATION
OR PROBLEM:**

THE PLAN:

What might this person do to solve the problem or to manage this difficult situation?

EXERCISE #56

READING OTHERS

BACKGROUND:

When we develop emotional control, we learn about basic emotions first (mad, sad, happy, etc.) and then slowly expand into more complex concepts like empathy, grief, and loneliness.

Before individuals can develop emotional control in response to others, you first need to identify what emotion is happening and why. Use these social scenarios cards to help learners practice identifying and evaluating different emotions.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Social Scenarios Cards (p. 181)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download, print, and cut out the social scenarios cards (p. 181).
2. Choose a scenario to review with your learner. Then, if necessary, you may choose roles and act out the scenario in a role play.
3. Answer the comprehension questions for each scenario together, discussing each person's emotions involved in the story. If necessary, practice maintaining good emotional control in the role play to rehearse the "best response" in each scenario.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Some learners may observe what's happening in the social scenario and then generalize those emotion comprehension strategies to similar situations in real life. For other learners, these activities help to practice answering emotion comprehension questions (e.g., "Why do you think....?" or "How does that make you feel?") so that they might be more prepared to answer those questions at key moments.

Mastery criteria for this exercise involve answering the questions without additional support for at least 3 different emotions.



EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner does well with social scenarios, consider using this format for various executive functioning skills. For example, write stories to discuss topics like problem-solving (see Chapter 5) or time management (see Chapter 2).

SOCIAL SCENARIO CARDS



THE MISSING KEYS

Andrea's parents have agreed to allow Andrea to use the car this weekend to go shopping with some friends. Early on Monday morning, before Andrea was awake, her mother needed to use the car for work. Andrea's mother was running late, and when she went to find the keys to the car, they weren't on the hook where they belong. Andrea's mother stormed into Andrea's bedroom and woke Andrea up. "You're always so irresponsible. You're never taking the car to the mall again!"

1. Describe the problem.
2. How do you think Andrea's mother is feeling?
3. How do you think Andrea feels?
4. What could Andrea's mother do differently?
5. What could Andrea have done differently?

DOG PARK DILEMA

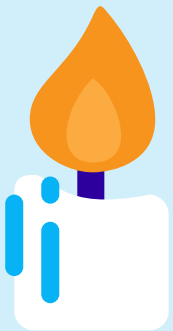
Jamal is meeting his friend Idris at the dog park at noon. When he arrives at the dog park, Idris isn't there yet. He waits in his car for a while and finally gets out to go into the park with his dog. After 20 minutes, Jamal texts Idris to find out where he is. Idris texts Jamal back right away and says, "sorry, dude. something came up."



1. Describe the problem.
2. How do you think Jamal is feeling right now?
3. What are helpful things Jamal could do right now?
4. What are not-so-helpful things he should avoid?
5. What should Idris have done differently?

FUNERAL FEELINGS

Rosie and Ann have been friends since middle school. They spend most weekends together and do homework almost every day after school. Yesterday, Ann told Rosie that her grandmother passed away and the funeral is in three days. Rosie has never been to a funeral before, but she knows Ann's grandmother's importance to her.



1. How do you think Rosie is feeling?
2. How do you think Ann feels?
3. What are helpful things Ann could do right now?
4. What are not-so-helpful things she should avoid?
5. Who could help Rosie?

SOCIAL SCENARIO CARDS



TEXT MESSAGE MONSTER

Greg is hanging out with his friend Andy in his basement. They are supposed to be playing Greg's new video game, but Andy's phone keeps beeping. Every time someone sends a text to Andy, he pauses the game, picks up his phone, and replies to the text. Finally, after the fifth time Andy stops to text back, Greg slams his controller down and storms upstairs.

1. Describe the problem.
2. How do you think Greg is feeling?
3. How do you think Andy feels?
4. What could Greg do differently?
5. What could Andy have done differently?



THE BIG SNOOZE

Lizzie and her two friends Chelsea and Jess, had a sleepover last weekend. Lizzie gets on the bus on Monday morning, and two boys start making snoring sounds at her. When she sits down on the bus, another student pulls out his phone to show her that Chelsea and Jess posted a video of Lizzie snoring in her sleep on social media.

1. Describe the problem.
2. How do you think Lizzie is feeling right now?
3. What are helpful things Lizzie could do right now?
4. What are not-so-helpful things she should avoid?
5. Who could help Lizzie?



MOVIE MIX UP

Tori invited her friend Ryan over to see a movie on Friday night. On Friday evening, Ryan texted Tori to say he wasn't feeling well and couldn't come over anymore. The next morning, Tori saw pictures of Ryan hanging out with a group of kids from school on social media.

1. Describe the problem.
2. How do you think Tori is feeling?
3. How do you think Ryan feels?
4. What are helpful things Tori could do right now?
5. What are not-so-helpful things she should avoid?

SOCIAL SCENARIO CARDS

HOMEWORK HELP



Natasha and Elliot are working on homework in the library. Natasha has been working on her math assignment for an hour and still can't figure it out. Elliot's already done with his assignment and is working on a history paper for next week instead. Natasha drops her pen on the table and says, "I'm so stupid. I'll never get this done before tomorrow. Can't I just look at yours?"

- 1. Describe the problem.
- 2. How do you think Natasha is feeling?
- 3. How do you think Elliot feels?
- 4. What could Elliot do in this situation?
- 5. What could Natasha do differently?
- 6. Who could help Elliot?

PIZZA PROPOSITION



Sam and some friends are going out for pizza after work tonight. He'd really like to invite a coworker Morgan to come with him but doesn't know what to say. In fact, Sam would really like to ask Morgan out on a date just the two of them, but sort of "freaks out" just thinking about it.

- 1. Describe the problem.
- 2. How do you think Sam is feeling?
- 3. What are helpful things Sam could do right now?
- 4. What are not-so-helpful things Sam should avoid?
- 5. Who could help Sam?

CREATE YOUR OWN:



EXERCISE #57

WHY IT MATTERS

BACKGROUND:

Not all learners understand the value behind emotional control or working on emotional regulation skills. It's not uncommon for individuals who struggle with emotional control to say things like, *"Who cares if I get upset?"*, *"It's not a big deal if I get out of control as long as no one gets hurt."*, *"But I said I'm sorry."* Using the Why It Matters worksheet, guide your learner to understand the consequences of not using good emotional control.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the "Why It Matters" worksheet (p. 185). Identify a quiet, distraction-free environment to review the worksheet with your learner. It's best to avoid working on this sheet when your learner is already upset or frustrated.
2. Review each step of the worksheet with your learner. Start by choosing an emotion that is the biggest struggle for your learner (e.g., anger, frustration, anxiety, fear)
3. Identify the common behaviors they exhibit when angry, upset, or frustrated that cause challenges for others.
4. Continue working through the reflection questions on the worksheet, helping your learner review who and what is impacted when they struggle with emotional regulation.
5. Finally, review the strategies your learner could do instead. If necessary, review the STOP, THINK, ACT method (see Exercise #52) for an alternative strategy your learner can use in the moment.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Some learners may take several different "Why it Matters" worksheets to connect and motivate them to improve emotional control. Not all learners respond the same, and some may need additional role-plays or practice with alternative, replacement behaviors. Continue completing the "Why it Matters" worksheet for different emotional triggers until your learner demonstrates comprehension of at least 3 different reasons emotional control is important.

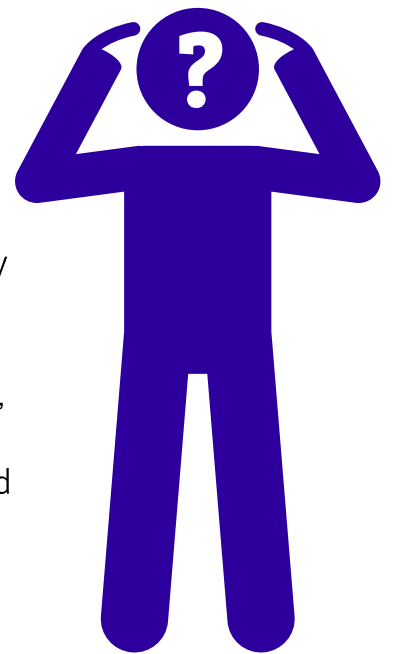
SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Why It Matters Worksheet (p. 185)



EXPANSION IDEAS:

As mentioned above, this exercise works well with the STOP, THINK, ACT method (see Exercise #52). To work on other ways to motivate your learner to use executive functioning skills, try Rewarding Success (Exercise #12), Fun Planner (Exercise #19), and Better Choices (Exercise #64).

WHY IT MATTERS

Use this worksheet to help your learner understand the impacts of their behavior to others and the environment

EMOTION:

When I'm feeling this emotion, what does my body often do?

WHO?

When I act like this, who is impacted?

WHAT?

What are three consequences that happen if I act like this?

1

2

3

What are better choices I could make?

What might happen if I made a better choice?

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

EXERCISE #58

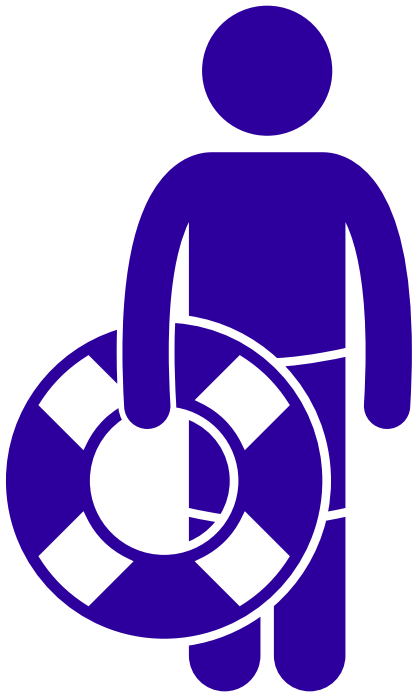
STAY COOL POOL

BACKGROUND:

There are many different strategies we can use to demonstrate good emotional control. Taking deep breaths. Going for a walk or a stretch break. Or more formal methods like Stop, Think, Act (see Exercise #52). Use this quick reference sheet to keep track of all the different strategies you can use to "stay cool" when you need it most.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the "Stay Cool Pool" worksheet. Identify a quiet, distraction-free environment to review the worksheet with your learner.
2. In each area of the pool worksheet, there are specific emotions or situations that may trigger emotional responses. For each emotion, select a strategy that works the best to maintain your cool. Then, write that strategy on the life preserver to remind what your learner can do in those situations.
3. When completed, post the worksheet in an easily accessible space as a reminder when you need it most.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Identifying replacement behaviors for emotional responses requires time and practice. Your learner may need to complete the Stay Cool Pool worksheet often as they develop new executive functioning skills. Mastery criteria involve using two different emotional control strategies with or without referencing the Stay Cool Pool worksheet.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Many of the executive functioning exercises in this workbook can act as "life preservers" for learners with diverse needs. For example, if the Stay Cool Pool worksheet works well for developing emotional control strategies, encourage your learner to create similar worksheets to document their pool of strategies for skills like planning (see Chapter 1), impulse control (see Chapter 9), and self-monitoring (see Chapter 11).

SKILL AREAS:

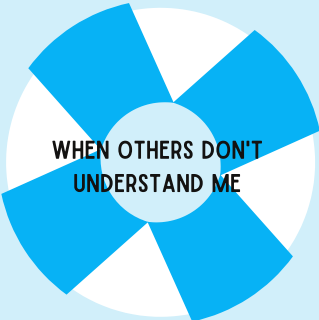
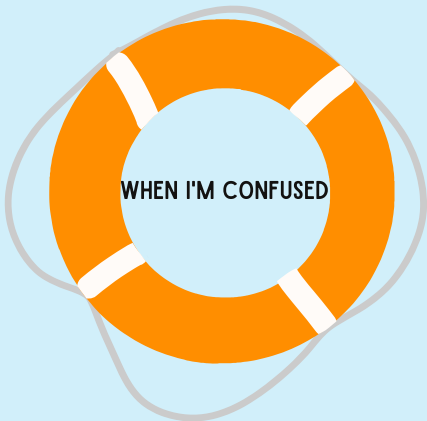
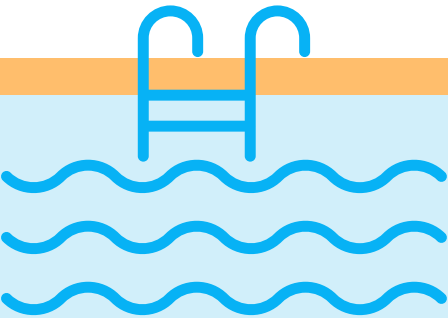


SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Stay Cool Pool Worksheet (p. 187)

STAY COOL POOL





CHAPTER NINE: IMPULSE CONTROL

CHAPTER OUTLINE	188
SKILLS OVERVIEW.....	189
What is impulse control?	
Impulse control disorders	
Impulse control and executive functioning	
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IMPULSE CONTROL

We know from research and our own personal experiences that the human brain can be easily susceptible to impulsive behavior. Acting on impulse, sometimes making split-second decisions, comes from our evolutionary instincts to survive. Take too long to act in the ancient world, and you might be another creature's lunch!

Unfortunately, even though our technology-driven world has rapidly evolved, our impulsive tendencies have not. In the 21st century, we are subject to emotional responses, decision-making challenges, and acting without thinking. As parents, teachers, and coaches, we need to know how to support our learners by combating this disconnect between our instincts to act on impulse and demonstrating appropriate self-control.

WHAT IS IMPULSE CONTROL?

Impulse control—sometimes known as self-control or our inhibition—is an executive functioning skill that allows us to engage independently in society. Impulse control helps us “think before acting” and to prioritize long-term rewards over short-term gain. When we demonstrate appropriate impulse control behaviors, we resist or avoid doing things that may be harmful to ourselves and others.

Like many other executive functioning skills in this workbook, we are born with a genetic makeup that supports self-control, but we gain impulse control through environmental learning. Impulse control develops in our toddler years as we learn primary safety responses like avoiding a hot stove or running into the street.



We expect toddlers to need constant monitoring for impulsive behaviors but begin to fade our support as we grow more independent in elementary and middle school. By pre-teen and teenage years, we continue some risky behaviors but often follow the safety rules and strive for social norms. By adulthood, we can manage impulsive behavior across all settings, avoiding most instances of rushing, reckless, or harmful behaviors.

IMPULSE CONTROL & PROBLEM BEHAVIOR

What happens if your child doesn't continue to develop good impulse control behaviors? Self-control and impulse behavior might not be the cause of problem behavior itself. But, it certainly contributes to how quickly your teen or young adult learner might default back to poor habits and behaviors. Children who struggle with impulse control might demonstrate problem behaviors like:

- Interrupting in conversations, talking over others, or refusing to allow others to share opinions.
- Difficulty sharing preferred items.
- Refusals, whining, or tantrums when asked to stop or transition away from something enjoyable.
- Arguments about setting healthy limits on food, spending money, and screen time.
- Engaging in dangerous or unhealthy behaviors when peers are around.
- Giving up easily or refusing to persist with challenging tasks.

IMPULSE CONTROL DISORDERS

Before exploring strategies to improve impulse control, it's important to pause and recognize that the impulse control behaviors above relate to under-developed executive functioning skills. They are different behaviors than those associated with impulse control disorders. Impulse control disorders (pyromania, kleptomania, intermittent explosive disorder, etc.) are serious medical conditions that are not likely to benefit from the strategies included in this text. Consult a medical professional if you feel your child's impulsive behavior puts themselves or others at risk of harm.



POTENTIAL GOALS RELATED TO IMPULSE CONTROL

- Understands and articulates the consequences of self-controlled vs. impulsive behavior.
- Understands and demonstrates self-controlled behavior vs. impulsive behavior in controlled situations or role-plays.
- Demonstrates control of personal space and voice volume when around others.
- Maintains healthy limits on food, shopping, and screen time.
- Controls instances of risky behavior when alone or with others.
- Avoids 'self-sabotage' or choices that will reduce the probability of success at home, work, or school.

IMPULSE CONTROL AND EXECUTIVE FUNCTIONING

impulse control is closely tied to how we learn to function independently. Some teens and young adults who struggle with impulse control may also be struggling with other executive functioning skills. Evaluating planning and problem-solving skills along with flexibility and emotional control can be important when we're also trying to work on impulsivity.

There is also a well-known body of research connecting improvements in impulse control with consistent sleep and maintaining a healthy diet and exercise. Supporting your learner through the exercises in this chapter may also include working to reducing stress levels, promoting a regular, consistent sleep schedule, and engaging in physical activity as a family. Even tiny changes in habits in these areas can make a meaningful difference in improving self-control.

GETTING STARTED WITH IMPULSE CONTROL GOALS

To begin identifying the best tools and strategies for improving impulse control, take the pre-assessment on the next page, which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child. Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and planning how you might accomplish your self-control goal.

IMPULSE CONTROL

PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the impulse control exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

I read and follow instructions carefully.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I think about decisions before I make them.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I like to think before I speak.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I'm okay waiting for something I really want, even if it's hard.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I avoid taking action until I have all the facts.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I avoid jumping to conclusions.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Others describe me as consistent and reliable.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For learning about impulse control triggers

59 60 63

For learning to use different tools to avoid impulsive choices.

61 62 64

EXERCISE #59

THE INTERRUPTER

BACKGROUND:

One of the common concerns we hear from parents and teachers of children with impulse control issues is how frequently they're interrupted. Use this video-based activity to help your learner practice when it's a good time to interrupt.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Begin by using the paper and pencil to make a list of the most common or most recent scenarios where your learner interrupted or disrupted a group. Examples might include: during class time, while a parent is working from home, during an important phone call, when busy engaging with a sibling, using the bathroom, or when a neighbor stops by. Using the Better Choices worksheet (see Exercise #64) to help brainstorm triggers for your learner can be helpful.
2. Once you've developed a list, set up smartphone equipment to record the scenario with your learner.
3. First, instruct your learner to interrupt at the wrong time or re-create the problematic situation in the past.
4. Once the video has been collected, pause with your learner to watch the video. Discuss strategies and alternatives to interrupting that are better choices.
5. Re-record the same video, this time instructing your learner to make a better choice for interrupting.
6. Repeat Steps 2-4 with the common scenarios that your learner struggles with.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for video-modeling activities include answering questions about self-control behaviors and demonstrating improvements when the trigger situations occur. Continue having your learner role-play, observe videos, and answer questions until they demonstrate a better choice on at least two different opportunities.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

As mentioned above, the Better Choices (see Exercise #64) activity can help generate triggers to record videos for. If your learner does well with video-modeling activities, consider expanding to other impulsive behaviors (see Exercise #60, #63) and other executive functioning skills (see Exercise #35, #43, #68).

SKILL AREAS:

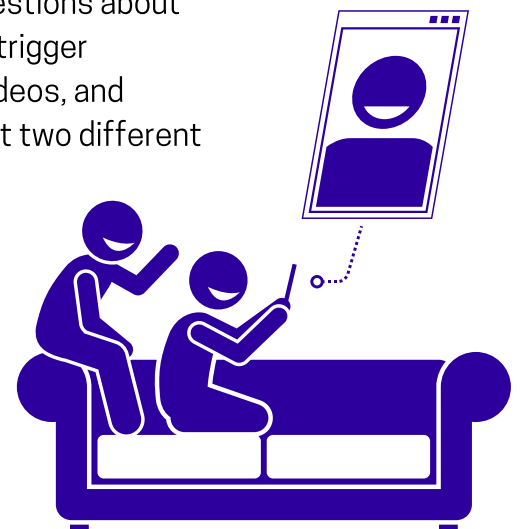


IMPULSE
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Paper & Pencil
- Smartphone or tablet with video recording capability
- Common household items
- A tripod or extra person to record videos.



EXERCISE #60

THE DEMANDER

BACKGROUND:

Just like interrupting can be a common impulse control problem, so can being overly demanding. Use this video-based activity to help your learner practice how to ask for things in ways that are likely to be well-received by others.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Begin by using the paper and pencil to make a list of the most common or most recent scenarios where your learner placed unrealistic demands or used an inappropriate tone to ask for something. Examples might include: demanding more screen time, whining or begging for extra privileges, or demanding things be done right away. It can be helpful to use the Better Choices worksheet (see Exercise #64) to help brainstorm impulse triggers for your learner.
2. Once you've developed a list, set up smartphone equipment to record the scenario with your learner.
3. First, instruct your learner to use a demanding tone or re-create the problematic situation in the past.
4. Once the video has been collected, pause with your learner to watch the video. Discuss strategies and alternatives to using the demanding tone.
5. Re-record the same video, this time instructing your learner to make a better choice for making requests.
6. Repeat Steps 2-4 with the common scenarios that your learner struggles with.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Paper & Pencil
- Smartphone or tablet with video recording capability
- Common household items
- A tripod or extra person to record videos.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for video-modeling activities include answering questions about self-control behaviors and demonstrating improvements when the trigger situations occur. Continue having your learner role-play, observe videos, and answer questions until they demonstrate a better choice on at least two different opportunities.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

As mentioned above, the Better Choices (see Exercise #64) activity can help generate triggers to record videos for. If your learner does well with video-modeling activities, consider expanding to other impulsive behaviors (see Exercise #59, #63) and other executive functioning skills.

EXERCISE #61

CAN-DO CUBES

BACKGROUND:

We know that learning to control impulsive behaviors takes practice and persistence. Use this Can-Do Cubes activity to create a list of strategies for your learner they can do instead, and then have them "roll the dice" to practice a different tool or strategy.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Can-Do Cubes Templates (p. 196-197). Use the pre-made cube template for ideas for what your learner might do instead of using impulsive behaviors, or use the blank cube template to create your own.
2. Cut out the templates and fold them to create a cube.
3. Tape or glue the template together on the folded edges.
4. Once the cubes are created, have your learner roll the cube to select a replacement strategy.
5. Identify a scenario that may be a trigger for your learner's impulsive behavior. Role-play the scenario, and instead of using impulsive behavior, practice your learner demonstrating the replacement strategy listed on the cube.
6. Repeat Steps 4-5 with the common scenarios that your learner struggles with until they've practiced the strategies listed on the cubes.

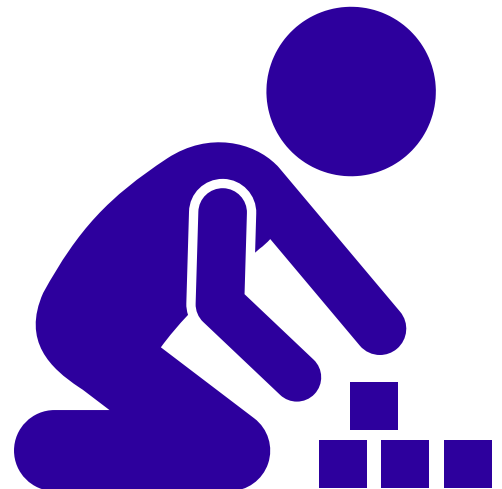
SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Easy

MATERIALS:

- Can-Do Cubes Template (p. 196)
- Pencil/Pen
- Scissors
- Glue or Tape



MASTERY CRITERIA:

To use the Can-Do Cube activity, learners should answer questions about self-control behaviors and demonstrate improvements when trigger situations occur. Continue having your learner roll the cubes, select a strategy to practice, and answer questions until they demonstrate a better choice on at least two different opportunities.

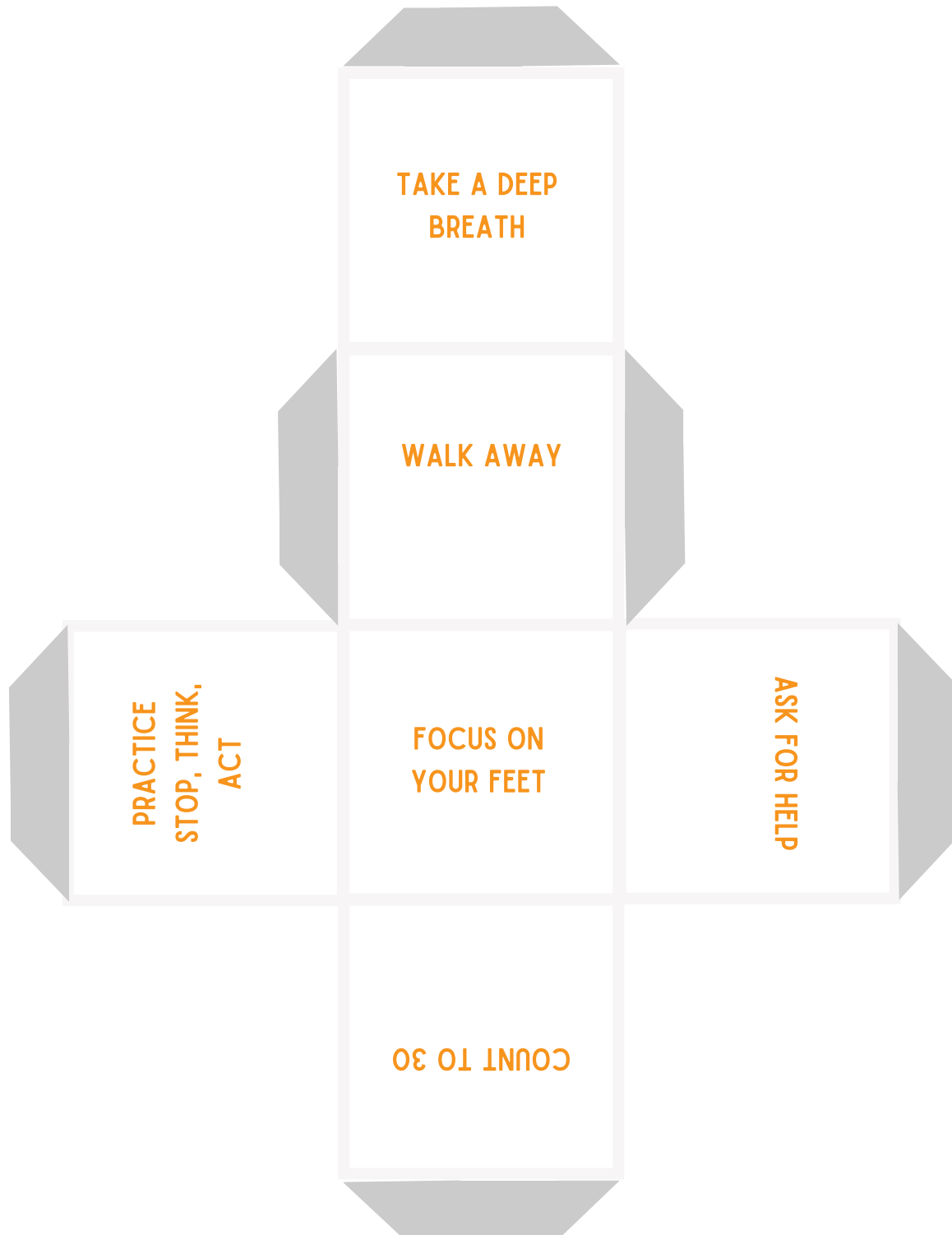
EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Better Choices (see Exercise #64) activity can help generate triggers to practice with your learner. If your learner does well with the Can Do Cubes activity, consider expanding to create cubes for other executive functioning exercises in the workbook (see Exercise #12, #19, #26, #39, #51, #73)

PRINTABLE CAN-DO CUBE TEMPLATE

Instructions:

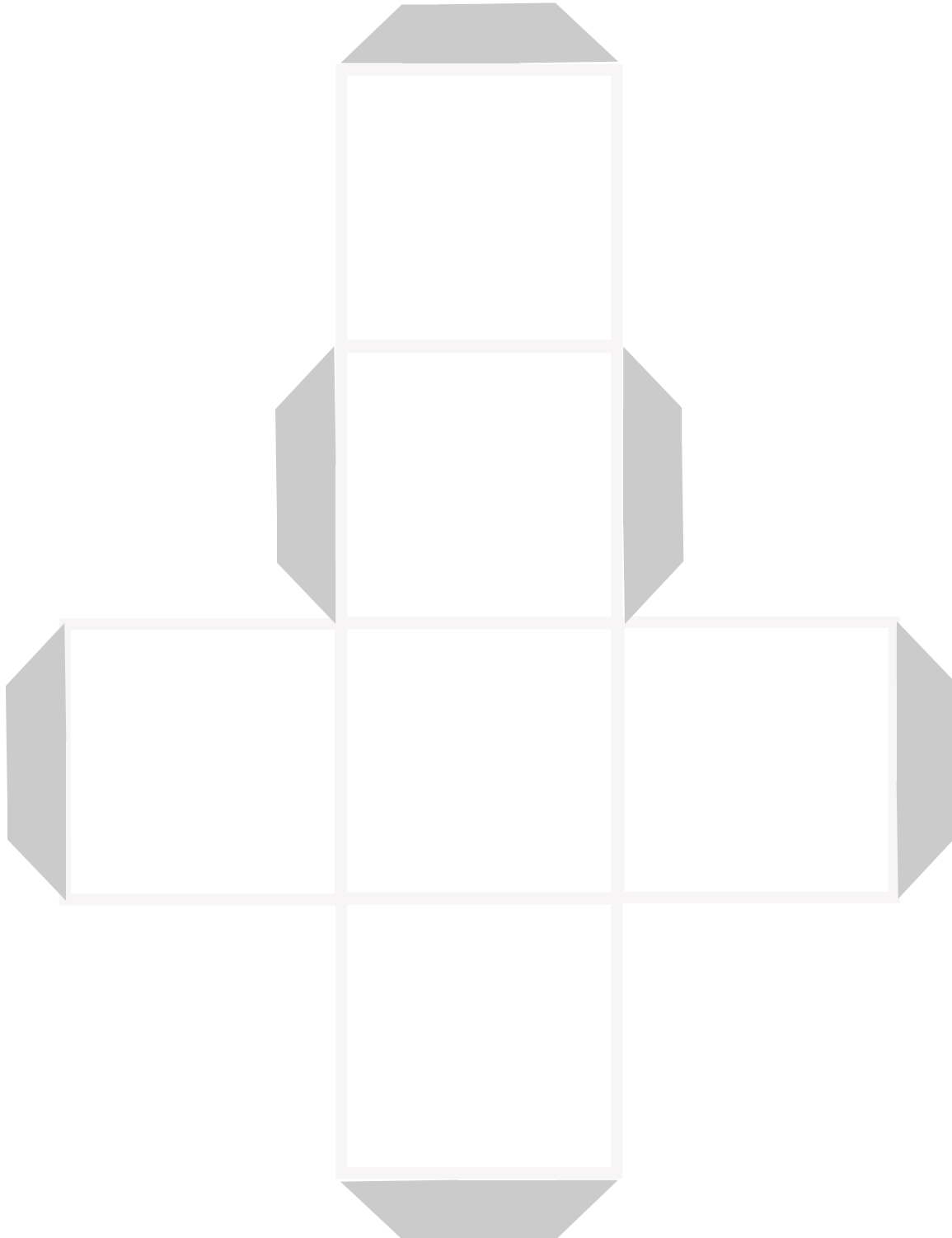
- Print the template out.
- Cut around the entire edge of the template. Do not cut off the gray tabs
- Fold along the inside edges so that the strategies are listed on the outside of the cube.
- Assemble the cube by gluing or taping the sides together along the tabs.



PRINTABLE CAN-DO CUBE TEMPLATE

Instructions:

- Print the template out.
- Cut around the entire edge of the template. Do not cut off the gray tabs.
- In each box, list one strategy or helpful tool.
- Fold along the inside edges so that the strategies are listed on the outside of the cube.
- Assemble the cube by gluing or taping the sides together along the tabs.



EXERCISE #62

THE QUITTER

BACKGROUND:

Teaching impulse control sometimes means teaching perseverance or overcoming the impulse to give up and quit for learners with unique needs. Using this exercise to develop replacement behaviors for when your learner struggles with being "The Quitter."

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the "When I Want to Quit" worksheet template (p. 199). Then, identify 10-15 minutes in a location without distractions to complete the worksheet with your learner.
2. Begin by brainstorming recent situations where your learner gave up easily or struggled to persist when something was difficult. Be sensitive that this may be a difficult topic for your learner to discuss. If the conversation begins to break down, pause and choose an alternative time to continue.
3. After reviewing a recent scenario, discuss with your learner what it feels like when they're ready to give up. Document different sensations in the body, or prompt your learner to review some of their thoughts. (See Exercise #53 - Body Scan for additional ways to discuss this with your learner)
4. Next, discuss alternatives to quitting. Create a list of options that your learner can do instead of the knee-jerk reaction of giving up.
5. Post the completed worksheet in a place that's easy to reference for your learner when they are frustrated or acting on the impulse to give up.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this activity involves answering questions about self-control behaviors and demonstrating improvements when the trigger situations occur where your learner attempts to quit.

Continue having your discussion, and if needed, role-play the alternatives until they demonstrate persistence through difficult tasks on at least two different opportunities.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

As mentioned above, it can be helpful to work on mindfulness strategies with your learner before and during this activity (See Exercise #46 and #53 for additional mindfulness practice.)

SKILL AREAS:



IMPULSE
CONTROL



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

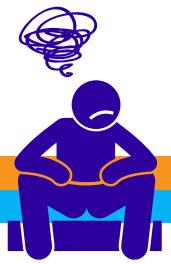
SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- When I Want to Quit Worksheet Template (p. 199)



WHEN I WANT TO QUIT



THE LAST TIME I WANTED TO QUIT...

What does it feel like in my body when I want to give up?

What happened after? How did it make me feel? How did it make others feel?

What are the consequences if I always want to quit?
What happens in the short term?
What happens in the long term?

WHAT ELSE CAN I DO BESIDES QUITTING?

☐
☐
☐
☐
☐
☐
☐

EXERCISE #63

SLEEP STUDY

BACKGROUND:

Research demonstrates that impulsive behavior and emotional regulation can be significantly impacted by the amount and quality of our sleep. If your learner struggles when they are tired or have difficulty sleeping, using the sleep log can help change habits and promote better sleep hygiene.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the "My Sleep Routine" worksheet (p. 201). Identify 10-15 minutes in a location without distractions to complete the worksheet with your learner.
2. Begin by brainstorming what helps your learner sleep well. It can be helpful to conduct an internet search of sleep hygiene strategies in this step. If your learner hasn't tried an option yet, but it may be beneficial, add it to the list of sleep routines to try.
3. At the bottom of the sheet, write out the sleep routine for your learner and a two-week period to try the routine.
4. Using the Sleep Log (p. 202) or an electronic sleep monitoring device, assist your learner in collecting data on their sleeping habits.
5. Complete the reflection questions at the bottom of the "My Sleep Routine" worksheet at the end of the sleep trial.
6. Repeat for additional two-week intervals as needed to help your learner improve sleep habits.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Improvements in sleep habits and sleep routines are the short-term mastery criteria for this exercise. However, note that learners will each respond to changes in routine differently. Some learners may benefit from adding one or two changes to the routine at once. Others may adjust the routine all at once but may need several more weeks for habit changes to occur. Go slowly and adapt to your learner's needs.

Zzz...



SKILL AREAS:



IMPULSE
CONTROL



SELF
MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: Advanced

MATERIALS:

- My Sleep Routine Worksheet (p. 201)
- Sleep Log (p. 202) or electronic sleep monitoring device

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner thrives with self-monitoring activities, consider using data collection, a Behavior Log (see Exercise #80), and Progress Monitoring (see Exercise #75) to target other executive functioning skills in this workbook.

MY SLEEP ROUTINE

ZzZ

THINGS THAT HELP ME SLEEP

MY SLEEP ROUTINE:

LOGGING MY ROUTINE:

START

END

POST-SLEEP LOG REFLECTION:

What worked well in the routine?
What didn't work well?
What changes did I see from the routine?
What should I keep working on in the future?

SLEEP LOG

Zzz

	BED TIME	WAKE UP TIME	TOTAL SLEEP TIME	NOTES ABOUT MY DAY
MONDAY				
TUESDAY				
WEDNESDAY				
THURSDAY				
FRIDAY				
SATURDAY				
SUNDAY				

EXERCISE #64

BETTER CHOICES

BACKGROUND:

Learners don't just build self-control through osmosis. It takes practice and rehearsal of the right strategies to overcome the impulse at the moment. This exercise practices scenarios with your learner that are particularly challenging for impulse control and then replaces them with techniques instead of acting impulsively.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a copy of the Better Choices Worksheet (p. 204). Identify 10-15 minutes in a quiet, distraction-free environment to complete this activity. Focus on a time when you and your learner are ready for open conversation, avoiding times where your learner might be upset or unable to complete reflections.
2. Begin by reflecting on previous situations where impulsive behaviors get in the way. Then, answer the top questions about times when your learner may be frustrated, angry, or triggers for using impulsive behaviors.
3. Using these scenarios to guide your thinking, identify three strategies or alternative behaviors your learner could select better than the impulsive behaviors listed above.
4. Identify opportunities where your learner can practice those alternative behaviors and the benefits of doing so.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for using Better Choices should be examined in two ways. First, evaluate if your learner can articulate the strategies listed as better choices. You may need to role play, rehearse or practice these scenarios (see Expansion Ideas below.) Secondly, evaluate if the Better Choices Worksheet effectively reduces the problem behaviors related to acting on impulse. Continue to practice until your learner controls impulsive behavior by selecting a better choice on at least two occasions.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Better Choices activity works well to prepare for many of the other training activities included in this chapter. For example, use it to identify strategies for The Interrupter (see Exercise #59), the Demander (see Exercise #60), and the Quitter (see Exercise #62).

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Better Choices Worksheet (p. 204)



BETTER CHOICES

When I'm frustrated, I tend to...

When I'm angry, I tend to...

When I'm nervous, I tend to...

Other times I act on impulse...

STRATEGY 1:

When to use it

Why it's a better choice

STRATEGY 2:

When to use it

Why it's a better choice

STRATEGY 3:

When to use it

Why it's a better choice



CHAPTER TEN: ATTENTIONAL CONTROL

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ATTENTIONAL CONTROL

As of this writing, if you enter the search words "How to Focus Better" into Google, you'll encounter about 6.2 billion results. In a world with so many distractions, we scramble to sustain our attention on what matters the most. Studies show we face distractions once every 7-8 minutes throughout the day, equating to about 60 distractions in an eight-hour work or school day. These distractions can cause frustration, time management issues, and challenges in obtaining goals.



If adults struggle with this skill, imagine how difficult it can be for learners with unique needs. Thankfully, there are some simple and easy ways you can start building attentional control in your child or student's regular daily routine. Building focus and concentration are all about identifying what works for a particular learning style, effectively practicing the skills, and celebrating successes as they come.

WHAT IS ATTENTIONAL CONTROL?

Attentional control involves our ability to focus on certain stimuli in the environment while not focusing or "tuning out" other things. There are two distinct behaviors involved in attentional control: paying attention to a stimulus in the environment and ignoring or non-attending to others. Attentional control works closely with other executive functioning skills, including working memory (using what we know to make decisions), emotional control (regulating our behavior), and cognitive flexibility (shifting focus between different stimuli in the environment).

MEASURING ATTENTIONAL CONTROL

How do we know if a learner with unique needs demonstrates focused attending? One of the reasons we struggle to help students with attentional control is that it can be difficult to measure through direct observation. We cannot know precisely when or if someone is "attending" or when the behavior starts and stops because it's a private or internal event. However, knowing how important it is to have a measurable, observable component to setting SMART goals, creating a clear definition of attentional control is the starting point for success.

Instead, we often measure attentional control by directly observing a secondary, alternative behavior. These bi-products of attention are behaviors we assume would be difficult to complete without demonstrating attentional control. Often these direct observations occur through a comprehension or skills check.

Some ways you might directly observe your learner's behavior include:

- **Observational learning** - Can your learner watch others' behavior and perform a similar behavior immediately after? Can your learner watch others' mistakes and avoid similar mistakes in the future?
- **Task completion** - Can your learner focus long enough to complete an activity (worksheets, puzzles, games, etc.) with multiple steps without stopping?
- **Comprehension** - Can your learner accurately answer questions about something observed, read, or spoken about?
- **Social interactions** - Can your learner stay on topic and answer questions during conversations? Does your learner get off-topic or distracted by details in social interactions?
- **Problem-solving** - Can your learner solve simple problems, including examining details in the environment and generating a solution to move forward?
- **Task initiation** - Can your learner focus on the right tasks at the right time, knowing when and where to get started? Can your learner continue working on the next task as soon as one is completed without getting off-track?



WAYS TO OBSERVE AND TEST ATTENTIONAL CONTROL

- Observational learning
- Task completion
- Question comprehension
- Appropriate social interactions
- Problem-solving
- Task initiation

ATTENTIONAL CONTROL AND PROBLEM BEHAVIORS

Many parents and teachers seek a boost in attentional control and executive functioning because of how closely issues with attentional control can closely align with problem behavior.

Learners with attentional control deficits may engage in problem behaviors to escape tasks that take too long. For example, they may act out, tantrum, or talk back if asked to return to activities once they've been distracted. In addition, frequent reminders and redirections from adults can deteriorate social relationships with parents and teachers. Fellow students and peers may also spend less time with easily distracted learners, taking the entire classroom off task.

By targeting and improving attentional control, learners can complete tasks faster and more efficiently. Faster completion allows learners to return to preferred activities faster. Staying focused also means fewer errors and mistakes in their work. All of which means less time you'll need to spend reminding or reprimanding.

STRATEGIES TO BUILD ATTENTIONAL CONTROL IN TEENS AND YOUNG ADULTS

Thankfully, working on attentional control doesn't have to be time-intensive or require lots of advanced training. Oftentimes, some simple changes to your learner's environment can make a big difference in improving focus and concentration. Along with the exercises in this workbook, building these supports into daily routines, parents and teachers can help ease some of the stress, frustration, and problem behavior related to attentional control.

1. **Take frequent breaks.** It may seem counterintuitive that taking a break from intense concentration can increase our ability to pay attention. However, for diverse learners who may have difficulty focusing for long periods, it can be helpful to build in more frequent breaks. Breaks should be short--no more than 3-5 minutes--but long enough to give attentional control a rest.
2. **Plan physical activity during breaks.** Along with taking frequent breaks, it's helpful if those 'brain breaks' include some form of physical activity. For example, we tend to shift from concentrating on a task, to focus on our smartphone news feed or emails. Yet, these tasks also require focus and concentration, so it's not restful for your learner's brain. Instead, encourage your learner to get up and moving around during breaks. Research supports that moderate to intense physical activity can increase our concentration and focus. In addition, even brief periods of physical activity can be beneficial for diverse learners.
3. **Test out times for peak attention.** Does your learner focus better right away in the morning? Does your student need to start with some easy tasks and build momentum for longer sustained attention? Is it more challenging for your child to focus when tired, hungry, or after a long day of school/work? For learners who are likely to need long-term supports to sustain attention, it's critical to examine and understand the times when attentional skills are at their peak. Choose these times for the most challenging tasks and save things requiring less concentration when focusing wains.

4. **Practice focus in a designated location.** Sometimes we can train our brains into focusing better just by practicing attention in the same location. Have your learner use a designated place for tasks that require sustained attention (e.g., quiet reading in the "reading corner," homework station, or workbench). Not only can you reduce the number of distractions in that particular environment, but your learner's brain will identify this location as an environment for focused attention over time.

5. **Use visual timers.** Sometimes helping a learner best focus in their time is just about assisting them in understanding time in general. Some evidence supports that learners who struggle with focused attention also struggle with understanding time and time management concepts. Try using a visual timer for a learner, including a countdown or time remaining marker. Learners can better conceptualize time passing by using a visual timer that indicates the total time needed to complete a task and how much time is remaining.

CELEBRATING ACCOMPLISHMENTS

Finally, be sure to celebrate progress as it happens. Good goal-setting practices involve recognizing short-term milestones with just as much excitement and enthusiasm as you might celebrate your learner's long-term goals. Building attentional control for parents and educators working with diverse learners can be more of "a marathon, not a sprint" activity. Celebrating your learner's accomplishments along the way can make the journey just as enjoyable as achieving an end goal.

GETTING STARTED WITH ATTENTIONAL CONTROL GOALS

To begin identifying additional tools and strategies for improving attentional control, take the pre-assessment on the next page, which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child. Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to identify and plan how you might accomplish your attentional control goal.

ATTENTIONAL CONTROL PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the attentional control exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

I can easily complete tasks with lots of steps.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I work carefully and avoid rushing through tasks.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can power through a task even if it's boring.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I focus on homework and chores without getting sidetracked.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Once I start on a task, I can work straight through to the end.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

If I get interrupted in the middle of a task, I can easily pick up where I left off.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can focus on my work even when others are talking around me.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

For learning about common triggers and distractions

65 68

For learning to control distractions in the environment

66 67 69

For learning to evaluate good attentional control & celebrate successful concentration

70 71

EXERCISE #65

HOW I PAY ATTENTION

BACKGROUND:

One of the most well-researched benefits of mindfulness training ties back to increasing attentional control. By nature, meditation is practicing focused attention. It's training the brain not only to hold focus (awareness) but also to hold it on one thing (attention). Try this mindfulness activity to help your learner identify what happens to their thoughts and body when they concentrate.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Review the "How I Pay Attention" script (p. 212-213) You may choose to download the script and print it out if necessary.
2. Find a quiet place, free from distractions. Your learner will need about 5-10 minutes to complete the script.
3. Read each step in the script. Remember that the purpose of meditation and mindfulness practice is to be present at the moment without placing any judgment. If you find a meditation step to be challenging, try not to dwell on it. Instead, recognize thoughts that arise and then return to the body scan.
4. While some research supports meditation benefits happen even after one sitting, repeating the practice daily or several times per week can build the greatest concentration and focus.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mindfulness training does not have a specific 'mastery criteria' since it's individualized to each person and each moment. Sometimes, the "How I Pay Attention" exercise will flow easily for a learner. On other days, it may be more challenging to move successfully through the script without getting distracted or frustrated. Continue encouraging your learner to practice the script at least once per day for a week or so. Re-evaluate at that time if your learner finds it easier to focus and concentrate.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

There are hundreds of different scripts, YouTube videos, and app-based mindfulness and meditation resources available online. If your learner succeeds with this script, consider downloading some of the other online resources and customize. If your learner responds better with visualization, try video-based mindfulness activities on YouTube and streaming services. Other exercises in this workbook for mindfulness practice include Stretch Break (see Exercise #46) and Body Scan (see Exercise #53).

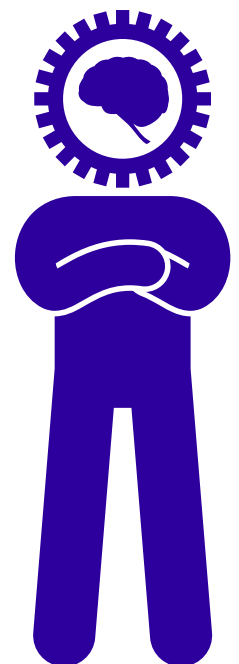
SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- How I Pay Attention script (p. 212-213)
- Smartphone to record script audio or a partner to read it aloud (optional)



HOW MY BODY PAYS ATTENTION

MEDITATION SCRIPT

Attentional control and concentration have been positively linked to mindfulness and meditation practices. Studies show that even brief mindfulness moments can help learners calm thoughts, examine where they might be distracted, and practice sustained attention.

Try this simple mindfulness exercise to help your learner build focus and concentration. Record it on a smartphone or read each step silently as you begin to relax.

HOW MY BODY PAYS ATTENTION

- Begin by finding a comfortable seat with your feet touching the floor or standing with your feet firmly on the ground.
- If you feel comfortable, close your eyes. Or find a spot ahead to rest your eyes gently.
- Take a deep breath in through the nose and then let it out through the mouth.
- Again, take another slow, deep breath in and out. Don't rush this step. It's the foundation for the rest of this mindfulness practice.
- On the next out-breath, begin to pay attention in your body to what it feels like to concentrate on your breath. Don't stress out about being focused or try to force your body to pay attention. Just continue to focus on your breath and recognize that this is what concentration feels like.
- Take a few more slow, deep breaths. In and out.
- Next, begin to direct your attention to your feet. Examine what it feels like in your feet right now. What do your feet do when you're concentrating? Are they quiet? Do they tingle? Feel warm or cold?
- Return to the breath. Inhale and exhale. If you get distracted, that's okay. Simply begin again to focus on the breath.
- Next, follow the breath upwards. When you focus your attention, what do your legs, knees, and thighs feel like? Gently explore the sensations in this area of your body. When you concentrate, what is your body doing in these areas?

HOW MY BODY PAYS ATTENTION - PAGE 2

- When you're ready, again shift your attention back to the breath. You're practicing the skill of directing and controlling your focus each time you move your thoughts from your body back to your breath. It's okay if you lose focus. Simply begin again right where you left off.
- Rest your attention here for several more breaths.
- Next, begin to explore your belly and chest. What sensations do you feel right now? Do you feel tingling, tightness, or discomfort? What does it feel like to concentrate on the breath in your chest? Take a few more breaths. Imagine your in-breath and out-breath traveling deep into your belly and your chest.
- Now, take one more breath and travel up to your head. What do concentration and focused attention feel like in your neck? Your face? The very tip-top of your head? How do you know you're concentrating right now?
- One final time, shift back to focusing just on the inhale and exhale of the breath.
- Feel free to stay here, examining any other parts of your body as you need. When you're ready, gently open your eyes and check around the room. Then, rejoin your activities with more focus and mindfulness to how your body feels when you're paying attention.

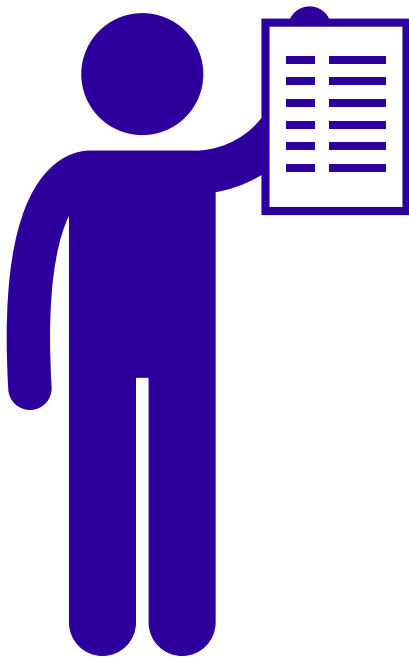


EXERCISE #66

MANAGING DISTRACTIONS

BACKGROUND:

Helping our learners manage distractions can go a long way to improve focus and concentration. Help your learner complete a list of the most common ways they get off-track when trying to focus on important homework, chores, or tasks.



INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the "My Distractions" list (p. 215).
2. Encourage your learner to print the list at the beginning of the day or at the beginning of a session where intense concentration is required.
3. Begin the task.
4. Each time your learner gets off task or distracted, have your learner record what caused the distraction or lapse in concentration. It can be helpful to have a second observer record the distractions. However, the observer should not interrupt or attempt to get the learner back on track.
5. At the end of the work session, review the list. Identify 1-2 items that are most distracting and cause the most disruption to focused attention.
6. Using the available space, work with your learner to create a plan to manage these distractions in future work sessions.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- My Distractions list (p. 215)
- Pen/Pencil
- Work task (e.g. homework, chores, project)
- Observer to watch for distractions

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Different activities may have different levels of distractions for your learner. It can be helpful to complete the Managing Distractions list over several different work sessions to get a longer list of distractions together. Then, continue practicing the observations until your learner has reduced the distractions to one or fewer per work sitting.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Some learners may not even recognize that they have gotten off-task or distracted during a work session. In these instances, it can be helpful to record the work session and then watch the video together later. Completing the worksheet at that point allows the learner to watch themselves in action and observe how they might better manage distractions in the future.

A stylized illustration of a person in a dark blue suit, appearing overwhelmed and stressed. The person is juggling multiple tasks: holding a pen in one hand, a briefcase in another, and a clock face. There are also coffee cups and a stack of papers floating around them, symbolizing the multitasking nature of their work. The background is a simple gradient of light blue and white.

OBSERVER:[illegible]

3

[illegible]

EXERCISE #67

WORK ROOM RENOVATION

BACKGROUND:

Once you've identified the core distractors that get in the way of attentional control, the next step is to reduce those distractors.

Sometimes, a quick audit of your learner's workspace can be enough to identify when and where to reduce distractions and improve focus and concentration.

SKILL AREAS:



ATTENTIONAL
CONTROL



ORGANIZATION

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Workspace Audit Worksheet (p. 216)
- Organization materials

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Workspace Audit worksheet (p. 216). Identify 10-15 minutes in your learner's most common workspace for homework, chores, or focused attention activities.
2. Complete the audit with your learner. Focus on completing the checklist without too much thought or debate with your learner.
3. Next, evaluate the audit worksheet. Identify 1-2 items on the audit worksheet to improve on in the workspace that will result in improved focus and concentration for your learner.
4. Using the organization materials, ensure that the workspace is clean and free of clutter. Then begin targeting the distraction items on the audit worksheet.
5. If a larger DIY project is needed, work with your learner to create a renovation plan that improves the space for better attentional control.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this activity involves not only completing the workspace audit worksheet, but also improving focused attention during homework, chores, and other tasks that require focus and concentration. Work with your learner to create and maintain the environment using the audit worksheet. Then monitor to observe your learner completing at least three tasks without distraction in the newly renovated space.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

It can be helpful when conducting a workspace audit to build other executive functioning tools into the workspace. Consider adding space in the renovation for items like a break box (see Exercise #71), bulletin board (see Exercise #34), and Priorities Post-Its (see Exercise #4).



WORKSPACE AUDIT



Instructions: Examine your workspace and answer each question. To the right, record any notes about improvements or changes that can be made to enhance concentration and focus in your space.

YES NO

☐ ☐

Do you have your own personal work space?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is the space free of distractions and excessive noise?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is there enough room to lay out papers, books, and materials?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is the space too silent?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is the temperature not too hot or not too cold?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is the chair comfortable? Do your feet rest comfortably on the floor? Is the back of the chair upright, but not stiff?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Do you have everything within reach so you don't need to get up for frequently used materials?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is there space to take breaks? Get up and move around? Is there room nearby to stretch?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is the space free from clutter or objects that may be distracting?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Does the space have good lighting? Can you see clearly without excessive brightness?

NOTES

RENOVATION TASKS:

1

2

3

EXERCISE #68

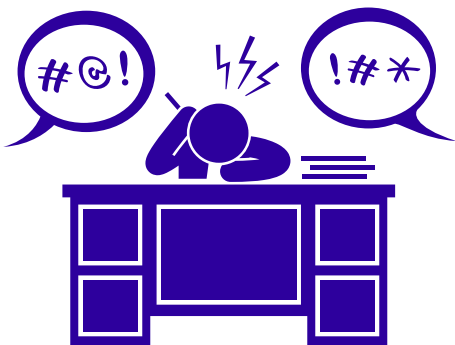
THE DISTRACTION-ATOR

BACKGROUND:

Improving focus takes practice. So does learning to work under pressure and with distractions. Use this exercise to help your learner keep their cool, even when they are intentionally being distracted.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Gather the materials and identify a quiet, distraction-free environment for 10-15 minutes to complete the activity.
2. Inform your learner that they'll be completing the worksheet first without any distractions. Set the stopwatch and record how many seconds it takes for your learner to complete the worksheet.
3. Discuss with your learner what strategies work well not to get distracted.
4. Provide your learner with another copy of the same worksheet. Instruct them to complete the worksheet again, however this time, with distractions.
5. Set the stopwatch and have the distractor try to talk to the learner, make noise in the environment, or otherwise attempt to break your learner's concentration. Record how many seconds it takes for your learner to complete the worksheet.
6. Compare and discuss with your learner what was challenging, what strategies they used to complete the worksheet with distractions, and what they might do differently next time.
7. Repeat steps 5-6 with different types of distractions. Review at the end of each session and provide feedback to the learner when they stay focused despite the distractions.



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Improvements in short-term focus and concentration are the best mastery criteria for this exercise. Your learner may demonstrate improvements in their focus with the worksheet task after several trials or may need practice as distractions increase. Continue until the learner can complete the worksheet in a similar amount of time as the zero-distraction environment.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Academic tasks may not be the only ones your learner gets distracted with. Continue to practice with various tasks until your learner can complete multiple types of activities, even when they're purposefully being pulled off-task.

SKILL AREAS:



ATTENTIONAL
CONTROL



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Timer or stopwatch
- Multiple copies of a simple math or spelling worksheet
- Observer (to play the role of the distractor)

EXERCISE #69

POMODORO

BACKGROUND:

The Pomodoro technique was developed in the late 1980s by then university student Francesco Cirillo. The technique has been used for decades in various settings to help learners improve attentional control for short periods by using frequent breaks. The Pomodoro technique is easy to use and takes just a few minutes to teach.

SKILL AREAS:



ATTENTIONAL
CONTROL



TASK INITIATION

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Timer
- Work tasks (homework, chores, etc.)

INSTRUCTIONS:

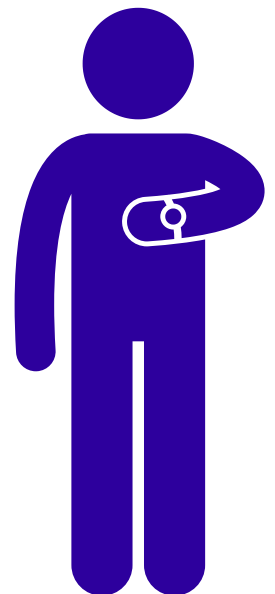
1. Identify a quiet, distraction-free environment for your learner to work in. It's helpful to have at least 4-5 work tasks available to your learner to complete during the Pomodoro session.
2. Instruct your learner to list the work tasks in the order that they wish to complete them or the tasks that are most important to complete first.
3. Set the timer for 25 minutes. Instruct your learner to complete 25 minutes of intense, focused concentration. All notifications, emails, text messages, etc., are put away and ignored during this time. The learner should only complete the tasks on the list.
4. When the 25-minute timer is up, set the timer for a 5-minute break. During break time, the learner can get up, move around, check messages, and use the restroom. However, the learner should be prepared that when the timer goes off, another 25-minute work session begins.
5. Repeat steps 3 and 4. After every 4th work session, set the timer for a longer 25-minute break.
6. Repeat the sequence of 25-minute work sessions and 5-minute breaks until the learner completes all the items on the task list.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

The Pomodoro technique is simple to implement, and many learners can complete the timer and work sessions without adult support. Observe your learner implement the technique and provide feedback to ensure they remain engaged throughout the work session.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Pomodoro technique pairs well with many of the planning and organization techniques in this workbook. If your learner needs help identifying what tasks to complete, review Weekly Organization Checklist (see Exercise #33) or Working Backwards (see Exercise #27). To help your learner plan what to do on a break, consider Break Box (see Exercise #71)



EXERCISE #70

QUALITY CONTROL

BACKGROUND:

One of the reasons we encourage learners to develop attentional control is to reduce mistakes. Using a quality control checklist, learners can audit their own performance, catch mistakes, and recognize when distractions decrease their work performance. This helps learners self-monitor and identify problems without needing adult corrections.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print two copies of the Quality Control Checklist (p. 221). Identify a short homework or household chore for your learner to complete. The task should not be difficult and should be easy to complete within 10-15 minutes.
2. Instruct your learner to complete the task however they would like. Do not instruct your learner to minimize distracting items (e.g., can keep their phone on, watch TV simultaneously, etc.)
3. Following the task, work with your learner to complete the Quality Control checklist. Observe and help your learner identify any mistakes or issues with attention to detail.
4. Identify a second task for your learner to complete. This time, encourage your learner to minimize distractions and focus on working quickly without mistakes.
5. Complete the Quality Control Checklist again. Discuss differences and any strategies that were helpful for your learner to reduce mistakes in their work.
6. Finally, have your learner discuss and answer the questions about the performance and the level of distractions while working.

SKILL AREAS:



ATTENTIONAL
CONTROL

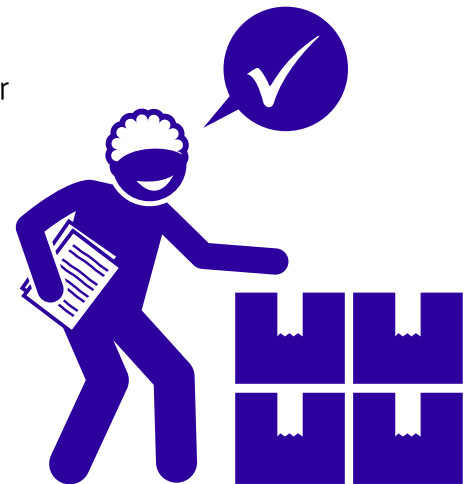


SELF
MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Quality Control checklist (p. 221)
- Work tasks (homework, chores, etc.)



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Quality Control involves many different skills. Mastery includes using self-monitoring to evaluate one's own performance and learning to reduce distractions in the future. Continue practicing the exercise until your learner can complete work without identifying any issues on the quality control checklist.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Quality Control checklist can be adapted and modified for various tasks at home and in the classroom. Focus on easy tasks until your learner can use the checklist, then gradually expand into more distracting environments and more challenging tasks.

QUALITY CONTROL



Instructions: After each work session, review the questions below to examine the quality of work and correct any mistakes you might have made.

YES NO

☐ ☐

Is my work neat and tidy?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Did I follow all the directions?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Did I answer all the questions or complete all the parts?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Did I check my work for errors?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Did I give my best effort?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Did I ask questions if I needed help?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Would others say that my work is completed?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Would I say this is my best effort?

YES NO

☐ ☐

Did I leave my work space clean and tidy?

NOTES

HOW DID I DO WHILE WORKING?

PAYING ATTENTION

NEEDS
IMPROVEMENT



MEETS
EXPECTATIONS

BEST
PERFORMANCE



REDUCING DISTRACTIONS

NEEDS
IMPROVEMENT



MEETS
EXPECTATIONS

BEST
PERFORMANCE



AVOIDING MISTAKES

NEEDS
IMPROVEMENT



MEETS
EXPECTATIONS

BEST
PERFORMANCE



GOALS FOR NEXT TIME:

EXERCISE #71

BREAK BOX

BACKGROUND:

It may seem counterintuitive that taking a break from intense concentration can actually increase our ability to pay attention. However, for diverse learners who may have difficulty focusing for long periods, it can be helpful to incorporate frequent breaks. To help your learner create a plan for breaks, use this Break Box Exercise to create a plan for the most productive and helpful breaks.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print a .pdf copy of the break box cards (p. 223-225). It can be helpful to have these printed on thicker cardstock paper or attach them to a 3x5 index card.
2. Prepare the cards by having your learner select activities that are useful in helping your learner relax, de-stress, and promote focused attention after taking a break. There are pre-made cards or an option to have your learner write their own cards. Be sure that activities take no more than 3-5 minutes and are easy to transition away from.
3. Gather the materials needed for each break card and place them in an easy-to-find location.
4. Place the cards in the "break box" storage container.
5. When your learner needs a break, randomly select a card from the break box and complete the activity listed on the box. Your learner can choose the same card multiple times or can remove the card until all options in the box have been completed.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Break Box Idea Cards (p. 223-225)
- Index card storage box
- Backpack or plastic tote to store break box materials
- Materials for break box



MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for break box includes learners selecting a card and taking a break from work that results in getting back on task later without disruption.

Continue practicing different break box cards until your learner can take a break from work and come back to tasks later successfully.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

The Break Box is meant to be combined with other time management and task initiation techniques. Therefore, it works well with Fun Planner (see Exercise #19), Pomodoro (see Exercise #69), and Check-in & Check-Out (see Exercise #76).

BREAK BOX IDEA

Go for a walk around the block.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Make a shopping list.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Drink a glass of ice water.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Watch your favorite music video.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Practice 5 yoga poses.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Check in with your pet.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Tidy up your desk space.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Give yourself a neck massage.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Come up with a weird record to break. See who can balance the longest on one foot or flick a paper football farthest.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Do 100 jumping jacks.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Look out the window at everything you can see. Identify and focus on one thing in detail.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Have a pillow fight.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Turn on some music and dance around.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Water the plants.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Put some pieces of a jigsaw puzzle together.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Switch seats to a new spot or change chairs in your current spot.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Have a quick snack.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Practice breathing exercises.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Wash your hands with a nice smelling soap or use a hand lotion.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Check in with a friend on social media.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Read a few pages of a favorite book.



BREAK BOX IDEA

Close your eyes and take a quick rest.



MY BREAK BOX IDEA



MY BREAK BOX IDEA





CHAPTER ELEVEN: SELF-MONITORING

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SELF-MONITORING

We begin our final executive functioning chapter again considering our introduction story of Sam:

Do you remember how often Sam's smartphone got in the way after school? How often she procrastinated with projects and assignments, causing extra fatigue and frustration from her parents? Most importantly, recall Sam's response to her teacher when she was given a consequence for falling behind in her work.

Now imagine a scenario where Sam's parents and teachers have provided her the tools to:

- Monitor her smartphone usage so it doesn't interfere with schoolwork
- Plan her projects and assignments, so she minimizes mistakes and the need to rush.
- Keep her bedtimes in check, so she's well-rested.
- Check her frustration level and make a better choice than yelling.

In this scenario, Sam's capitalizing on all the executive functioning tools together. She's planning, organizing, maximizing her attention span, and using better emotional control when frustrated. Yet, in all aspects, Sam's life is different.

It's also likely that other relationships in Sam's life are very different. Andy and Joan enjoy a much different parenting experience, helping Sam set and accomplish her goals. Sam's teachers can foster her learning in different ways because her work is completed. Even her sibling and friends may experience a better connection with Sam since she's less tired and more in control of her emotions.

In our second scenario, Sam has been taught



Self-monitoring is our workbook's final executive functioning skill that helps all other executive functioning skills work more efficiently and effectively.

WHAT IS SELF-MONITORING?

The executive functioning skill of self-monitoring reflects how we understand our behaviors and how we adjust to make changes for the future (American Psychological Association, 2020). Self-monitoring can include work-checking behaviors (reviewing mistakes, fixing errors, etc.) and social behaviors (responding to social norms, situational awareness, apologizing).

Self-monitoring can also refer to a behavior intervention technique used with diverse learners to help them record and monitor their behavior to change some aspects of responding. The executive functioning exercises in this book primarily focus on this second aspect of self-monitoring. However, implementing these techniques can improve all aspects of self-monitoring and other executive functioning skills.

QUANTITATIVE VS. QUALITATIVE SELF-MONITORING

Self-monitoring involves not only observing our behaviors but also how they impact others around us. There are two primary ways we engage in self-monitoring, depending on the type of observations we make:

- **Qualitative Monitoring** – observing the characteristics of our environment and behavior. Attending to how things make us feel (“I get angry when...”), sensations in the body (“My neck gets sore when I...”), or how our behavior changes the environment (“When I do this, my friends laugh at me.”). Monitoring how our behavior matches with social norms and standards.
- **Quantitative Monitoring** – In contrast, quantitative monitoring involves direct observation of instances of behavior or permanent products of our behavior. This might include frequency (“I did twelve math problems.”), duration (“I did homework for thirty-three minutes.”) and intensity or difficulty of a behavior (“I did the extra-hard math problems.”)



EXAMPLES OF SELF-MONITORING

- Counts the total number of items or tasks completed
- Discusses one's thoughts and feelings with others.
- Adjusts effort to achieve a goal after failure.
- Understands and articulates the consequences of positive and negative behaviors
- Completes data collection or self-observation worksheets
- Reflects on a problem behavior and displays a resulting decrease in problem responding.
- Reflects on skill-acquisition behavior and displays a resulting increase in positive responding.

BENEFITS OF LEARNING SELF-MONITORING

One reason parents and teachers who work with learners with unique needs value self-monitoring is the extensive research supporting its effectiveness (The Iris Center, 2008).

Individuals who engage in high rates of self-monitoring demonstrate:

- Increased on-task behavior
- Lower rates of disruptive behaviors
- Increased fluency of day-to-day tasks
- Less aggressive and destructive behaviors
- Increased pro-social social behaviors, including initiations, cooperation, and listening skills.



Parents and teachers are not the only ones who see benefits from learning self-monitoring behaviors. Teens and young adults with unique learning needs also report positive outcomes and benefits after being empowered to monitor their own behavior. Some of these additional benefits include:

- **Provides immediate feedback** – Students using self-monitoring strategies do not need an adult to intervene once the techniques are taught. Likewise, it's not necessary to have a second person involved to indicate to the student that they are on the right track. Instead, by giving them self-monitoring tools, they provide themselves with immediate feedback, often making changes faster than a teacher or parent can.
- **Engages students in their learning and personal development** – Ever feel like you're working harder than your learner to keep things moving forward? Self-monitoring puts the responsibility back on the learner to achieve and maintain success. As a result, successful programs show high engagement rates and motivation because the learner is invested in their own success.
- **Improves communication** – With self-monitoring interventions, your student observes their behavior and often creates a visual product (graphs, data collection forms, app reports) that you and your learner can examine together. The data objectively guides communication rather than pointing fingers or telling a student what they did or didn't do correctly.
- **Focuses on individual performance** – Finally, there's no need to compare your student to others in self-monitoring. Instead, they're simply looking at their performance and how it improves over time. This can be especially helpful for students who struggle with how their unique learning needs might differ from classmates and peers.

HOW WE DEVELOP SELF-MONITORING

We begin to develop self-monitoring at a young age through imitation. By identifying how our

behavior is the same or different from others, and then adapting it to match, we learn how to self-monitor. We use self-monitoring in activities like journaling, checklists, and reflection by middle school and high school. Into adulthood, we can check our work for mistakes, monitor our performance, and work harder in the future to achieve bigger goals.

While we've written elsewhere in the workbook, it's worth reiterating. Evidence supports that **all individuals** can make progress towards achieving executive functioning goals. Some individuals may need additional strategies and support to sustain success, especially when it comes to self-monitoring. Even if your learner may need long-term plans and supports to succeed, there's strong evidence to keep working towards achieving self-monitoring goals.

GETTING STARTED WITH SELF-MONITORING GOALS

To begin identifying additional tools and strategies for improving self-monitoring, take the pre-assessment on the next page, which will help identify which exercises in the chapter may be most helpful for you and your child. Then, use the SMART Goal Planning Exercise (p. 13) to begin identifying and planning how you might accomplish your self-monitoring goal.

SELF-MONITORING PRE-ASSESSMENT

Complete this pre-assessment worksheet to identify the self-monitoring exercises and goals that may be most helpful.

Instructions:

- Read each statement.
- Place an X in the box that most closely describes you or your child.

I try to get better at things over time.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can "read" situations and adjust my behavior if needed.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can see problems from others' perspectives.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I don't mind feedback and criticism because it helps me improve.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I can step back from a situation and evaluate what's not working right.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I regularly evaluate my progress and try to adjust my plans.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

I'm open to making changes in order to do a better job.

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

SCORING:

Using the scoring guide below, calculate the total score:

NEVER	RARELY	SOMETIMES	OFTEN	ALWAYS
0	1	2	3	4

TOTAL SCORE:

MY NEXT STEPS:

For items that scored 0 or 1, what are some goals or next steps to take action on?

FIND AN EXERCISE:

To collect data and information on helpful behaviors to increase

72 74 75 78

To collect data and information on unhelpful behaviors to decrease

79 80 81

For learning to evaluate good self-monitoring & celebrate achieving goals

73 76

EXERCISE #72

EXERCISE EVALUATION

BACKGROUND:

Not all of the exercises in this book work for every learner.

Exploring which of these tools is helpful for your learner and why it can make a meaningful difference in understanding how to teach executive functioning skills in the future best. Use this evaluation activity to identify what's most effective and if any modifications or changes can be made in the future.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Exercise Evaluation Worksheet (p. 233).
2. After meeting the mastery criteria of an exercise in *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*, identify a quiet place for 10-15 minutes of reflection with your learner.
3. Review each question in the reflection worksheet. Identify and rate how successful the exercise was for your learner, their preferences about continuing with the activity in the future.
4. Next, discuss with your learner what they might do differently next time. If the exercise was not successful, review the reasons and strategies that might change that in the future.
5. Finally, draft a SMART goal (see Exercise #1) on the next steps you intend to take related to this executive functioning exercise. For example, goals might include trying a different exercise, modifying the same exercise, or creating a weekly or monthly practice schedule.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Some learners may need initial support to evaluate the success of an activity effectively. Continue to monitor your learner's responses on the worksheet, offer feedback and support throughout. Mastery criteria include completing the evaluation worksheet for two different exercises and then achieving at least one of the SMART goals created on the worksheet.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

This exercise can be combined with any other activity in *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*. For additional practice with SMART goal setting, review Exercise #1, SMART Goal Planning.

SKILL AREAS:

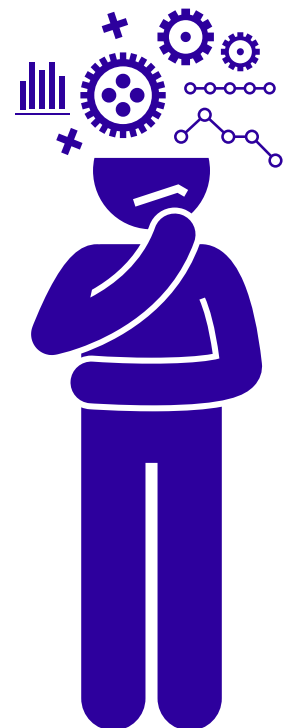


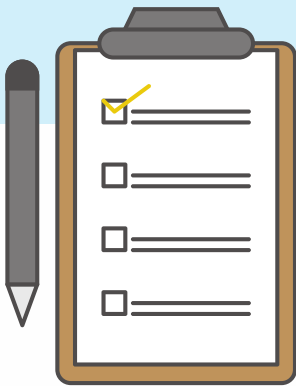
SELF-MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Exercise Evaluation Worksheet (p. 233)
- Exercises from *The Real-Life Executive Functioning Workbook*





EXERCISE EVALUATION

DATE:
ACTIVITY:
DATE MASTERED:

WHAT I LIKED ABOUT THIS EXERCISE:

WHAT I DISLIKED ABOUT THIS EXERCISE:

EXERCISE EVALUATION RATINGS

EASY TO DO

DEFINITELY NOT
TRUE



NEUTRAL



DEFINITELY TRUE

IMPROVED MY PERFORMANCE

DEFINITELY NOT
TRUE



NEUTRAL



DEFINITELY TRUE

SOMETHING I WILL USE AGAIN

DEFINITELY NOT
TRUE



NEUTRAL



DEFINITELY TRUE

WHAT WILL I CHANGE IN THE FUTURE?

SMART GOAL IDEAS:



EXERCISE #73

INVENTIVE INCENTIVES

BACKGROUND:

Keeping our learners motivated is critical to succeeding with teaching any executive functioning skill. Does your learner have a specific plan for what will happen when they achieve a SMART goal? Helping your learner examine and record incentives and what motivates them to learn more challenging tasks can be a valuable tool to reaching SMART goals.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Explain to your learner that the purpose of this activity is to identify incentives--positive outcomes, motivators, or achievements that can be earned or gained by achieving goals.
2. Open the notes function on the smartphone to record incentives. Set the timer on the smartphone or tablet for 3 minutes. Before the timer goes off, jot down or type as many different ideas for your learner's incentives for achieving a goal. These incentives can be tangible items, activities, privileges, or intrinsic/internal motivators.
3. Set the timer for 1 more minute to brainstorm additional ideas.
4. When the final timer goes off, review the list with your learner.
5. Open the smartphone/tablet function to take photographs or screenshots. Use the web browser to search for online items or, on the camera, create an album of photos capturing each of the items on the incentive list.
6. Put it in a safe place for your learner to reference later. Then, when you need the motivation to complete an activity or when your learner completes the Weekly Planning Meeting (see Exercise #3), use the incentive list you created to add in special ways to spend the time you save being more productive.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Smartphone/Tablet with photo album and screenshot capability.
- Search engine
- Timer

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise involve establishing a list of incentives and motivators for achieving goals. Some learners may need support brainstorming new and fun ideas to add to the digital list. It's a great activity to complete with a friend or family member and a fun way to help your learner monitor their own motivations.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Inventive incentives can be done with any of the exercises in this workbook. For example, look over your learner's list of fun or create a new list each time you're working on a new executive functioning skill to keep the motivation level high.



EXERCISE #74

SUCCESS STORIES

BACKGROUND:

What does success look like for you and your learner? One way to enhance our self-monitoring skills is to set our standard for success and then monitor how close we are to achieving it. Use this exercise to help your learner create a visual definition of their keys to success.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Begin by making a list of three current goals your learner is working on. These can be short, medium, or long-term goals.
2. Open the file folder and lay it out flat.
3. Segment out the folder into the primary goals you identified on your list by drawing lines or cutting and gluing different colored papers. Label each goal area.
4. Under each goal, build a definition of success. Write keywords, draw pictures, or cut out images to serve as reminders in each area for what it means to succeed at the goal. Encourage your learner to write their "success story" for each goal or use images of individuals who have succeeded at the same goal.
5. In the file folder, place tools or SMART planning worksheets (see Exercise #1) that outline the planning and path outlined to achieve success.
6. Each time your learner encounters a new goal milestone or struggles to move forward, take out the success vision board and self-monitor the progress towards the goal.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Vision boards can be completed once or can be working archives added to or subtracted from as needed. Work with your learner to develop a vision board for success for one set of goals, and then continue the process until they can independently open the folder and self-monitor their own success.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner finds the success stories vision board helpful, consider creating a file folder vision board for other executive functioning skills like planning (see Exercise #2) or emotional control (see Exercise #51).

SKILL AREAS:



SELF
MONITORING

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- File folder
- Basic art materials (markers, scissors, glue, tape, etc.)
- Magazines, newspaper, or smartphone pictures.



EXERCISE #75

PROGRESS MONITORING

BACKGROUND:

Graphing executive functioning behaviors can be an important tool for self-monitoring success. Use the attached data sheets and graphing forms as brainstorming to develop paper and pencil tools to teach your learner to self-monitor performance.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the data collection worksheet set (p. 237-240).
2. Identify and define a target behavior for graphing with your learner. The type of behavior may help determine how often or what type of data collection to conduct, so it's helpful to have a clear goal in mind.
3. Determine how long you will log data collection for and if any interventions will be added. If you plan to add interventions, it can be helpful to start with baseline data or "pre-intervention" data collection first, so your learner can observe any progress.
4. Log or graph the progress monitoring for the pre-determined time. At that time, work with your learner to evaluate any trends in the data points. Are the behaviors increasing? Decreasing? Staying about the same? Revise and discuss any additional behavior changes, and repeat steps 2-4 with another round of progress monitoring.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery for this activity includes logging the data on the progress monitoring sheets and successfully identifying trends in behavior based on the progress made. Continue working with your learner until they log 3 different behaviors and demonstrate meeting a measured goal over time.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Progress monitoring can be applied to nearly all of the exercises in this workbook. First, establish a SMART goal, define the target behavior, and then create measurement criteria. Data collection is one of the most useful tools in helping your learner build and maintain skills.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Data Collection Worksheets (p.237)
- Stop watch or calendar



DATA COLLECTION

WORKSHEETS

Graphing executive functioning behaviors can be an important tool for self-monitoring success. Use the attached data sheets and graphing forms as brainstorming to develop paper and pencil tools to teach your learner to self-monitor performance.

Behavior Log - Useful for recording behaviors with a longer duration (e.g., homework sessions, physical activity, etc.) and tracking progress towards a time-based goal.

Daily Tally Sheet - Useful for recording the instances of one or two behaviors that happen at higher frequency (e.g., checking smartphone messages, getting distracted from work tasks, cursing or verbal outbursts, etc.) It's best to record Behavior 1 as the target behavior to decrease and Behavior 2 as a target behavior to increase or replace the self-monitoring behavior with. Tally each instance in the column and graph the total number of instances that the behavior occurs each week.

Graphing Sheet - Once your learner has recorded data, encourage them to graph using a paper and pencil chart or a digital graphing tool (Excel, Google Sheets, etc.). This helps learners visually understand if they are progressing towards their goal and how quickly they're on track to achieve it.

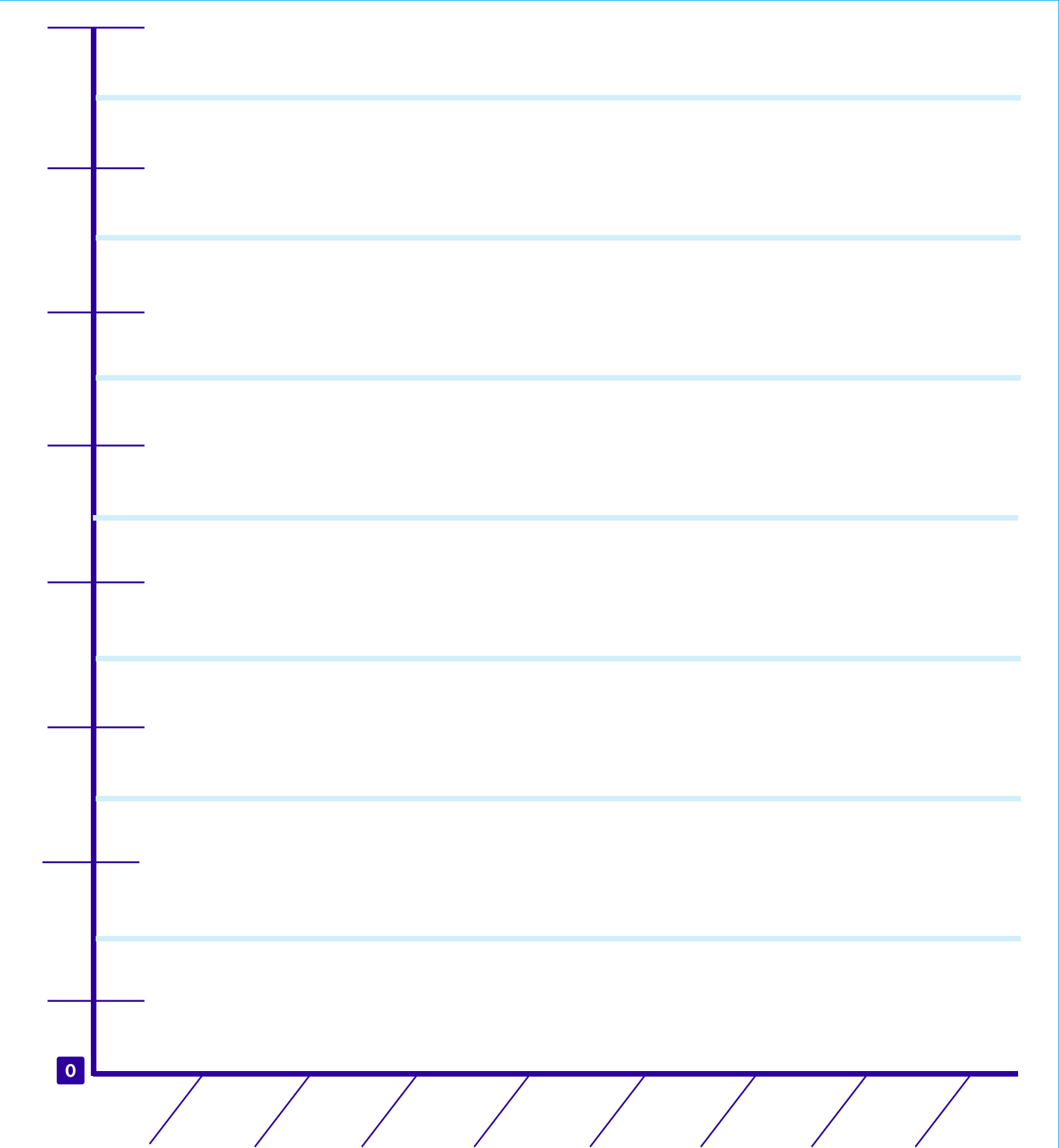
DAILY TALLY SHEET

WEEK OF:

	DATE	BEHAVIOR 1:	BEHAVIOR 2:	DAILY TOTAL
 Mo				
 Tu				
 We				
 Th				
 Fr				
 Sa				
 Su				
WEEKLY TOTALS:				

GRAPHING SHEET

BEHAVIOR 1:
BEHAVIOR 2:



EXERCISE #76

CHECK-IN, CHECK-OUT

BACKGROUND:

The check-in, check-out (CICO) method is an evidence-based intervention shown to be helpful for students who struggle with low-risk classroom behaviors like paying attention, blurting out, or using appropriate language. It can also be used at home and in the workplace to help learners self-monitor and stay on track with expectations.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Gather the materials and identify a quiet, distraction-free environment for 10-15 minutes to complete the pre-work with your learner. Decide the behavior you will address, identify when to target CICO and the daily CICO goal.
2. Then, conduct the following steps of the CICO system:
 - **Initial Check-In.** The learner completes a “check-in” with their mentor at the start of the work or school day. This check-in meeting aims to review the behavioral goals, collaboratively set goals for the day, and provide encouragement for the goals that were decided earlier.
 - **Monitoring, Evaluation, and Feedback.** Throughout the activity or day, the mentor observes the learner's behaviors. Then, using the expectations listed on the learner's points card as a reference, the learner and mentor meet together to share regular feedback. In addition to giving regular verbal feedback, the mentor uses the “points card” to assign points when the learner meets behavioral goals.
 - **Check-Out.** At the end of the activity or the day, the learner meets with the mentor with whom they began the day. Together, they assess the total on their “point card” and discuss if the daily goals and target behaviors were reached. If learner met their goals, the mentor provides verbal praise (or supplementary reward/privilege). If the point goal was not met, the mentor offers supportive encouragement or role-plays ways to succeed on the next opportunity.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for check-in, check-out should be individualized to the learner. It can be helpful to start with more frequent check-ins throughout the day and then gradually expand. It can also be helpful to start with lower points totals and increase. Finally, continue to fade out check-in check-outs until the learner self-monitors their own behavior without needing adult support on 2 opportunities.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner does well with visuals, pair check-in, check-out with progress monitoring graphs (see Exercise #75) to log points and behavior changes.

SKILL AREAS:



SELF
MONITORING



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: All

MATERIALS:

- Printed copy of Check-In, Check out points card (see p. 242)
- Timer or stopwatch
- Incentive/Prize (optional)

DATE:

NAME:

My behavior goals:

Points: 0 = 3+ reminders 1 = 1-2 reminders 2 = No reminders 3 = Best Work!

CHECK IN	ACTIVITY	TARGET A:	TARGET B:
#1			
#2			
#3			
#4			
#5			

Today's Points Goal:

Today's Total Points:

DATE:

NAME:

My behavior goals:

Points: 0 = 3+ reminders 1 = 1-2 reminders 2 = No reminders 3 = Best Work!

CHECK IN	ACTIVITY	TARGET A:	TARGET B:
#1			
#2			
#3			
#4			
#5			

Today's Points Goal:

Today's Total Points:

SAMPLE CHECK-IN, CHECK-OUT POINTS CARD

DATE: **JUNE 1**

NAME: **JULIAN**

My behavior goals: **A: I CONTROL BLURTING OUT ANSWERS IN THE CLASSROOM.**
B: I RAISE MY HAND IF I NEED HELP.

Points: 0 = 3+ reminders 1 = 1-2 reminders 2 = No reminders 3 = Best Work!

CHECK IN	ACTIVITY	TARGET A:	TARGET B:
#1	MORNING ARRIVAL	2	1
#2	MATH	2	2
#3	LUNCH	3	2
#4	INDEPENDENT WORK	2	2
#5	AFTERNOON BREAK	2	3

Today's Points Goal: **60% OF TOTAL**

Today's Total Points: **21 OF 30**



EXERCISE #77

LONG-TERM VISION

BACKGROUND:

Part of self-monitoring skills is learning how to keep moving towards goals, evaluating progress towards those goals, and making adjustments to meet them. To do that, your learner must have an idea of where they're heading. Creating a long-term vision for your learner can help them evaluate if short-term goals progress towards their long-term goals.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Easy

MATERIALS:

- Long-Term Planning Worksheet (p.245)
- SMART goal sheets (p.14) (optional)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the Long-Term Planning Worksheet (p. 245). It can also be helpful to gather any SMART goal planning worksheets (p. 14) your learner is currently working on and some blank SMART goal worksheets.
2. Begin by selecting a broad area or category of life skills to create goals for. This can include topics like "school," "job," or "friendships." It's okay to do long-term vision planning in multiple areas but select one area to work on at a time.
3. After identifying a category, begin by identifying and defining what success would look like in five years. Encourage your learner to think about 'wildly successful' and specific and measurable behaviors that are occurring. An example goal for school: "In 5 years, I've graduated high school."
4. Once the long-term vision is identified, draft some notes about what may need to happen in the short run for that goal to occur.
5. Write those SMART goals in the corresponding date range, working backward from the long-term goal. For example, for the graduation goal to occur, perhaps your learner writes a 1-year vision of "I've passed chemistry and algebra."
6. Work backward until your learner has created SMART goals they can work on in the next 3-6 months that lead back to the long-term vision.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

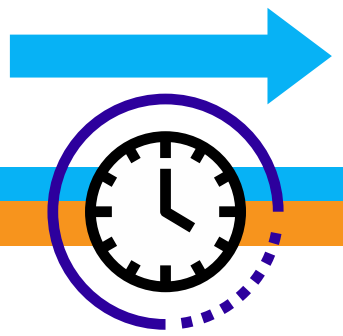
Long-term vision planning should be conducted across different skill areas and completed every 12 months. Continue helping your learner with long-term vision planning until they demonstrate progress on 2-3 SMART goals that contribute towards achieving their three and five-year goals.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner needs additional ideas for long-term goals or short-term SMART goals to achieve them, review the Executive Functioning assessments at the start of each chapter for ideas on what to focus on.



LONG-TERM PLANNING



DATE:
LIFE/SKILL AREA:

WHERE I SEE MYSELF

IN 5 YEARS:

SMART GOALS TO GET THERE:

IN 3 YEARS:

SMART GOALS TO GET THERE:

IN 1 YEAR:

SMART GOALS TO GET THERE:

IN 6 MONTHS:

SMART GOALS TO GET THERE:

EXERCISE #78

WHEN THINGS GO RIGHT (AND WRONG)

BACKGROUND:

Without the self-monitoring skill to know when things are going right and when things are going wrong, it's hard for learners to make any adjustments for the future. So before we can expect learners to understand how to change their behavior, they first need to identify the status quo.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Identify a quiet, distraction-free place to complete this activity with your learner.
2. Place the two blank pieces of paper side by side on the table. At the top of one piece of paper, label the sheet "When Things Go Right" using green.
3. On the other sheet of paper, write "When Things Go Wrong" at the top header, using red.
4. Set the timer for 5 minutes, discuss with your learner how they know when things are going well and not so well. Write words on the sheets that describe feelings, behaviors, and how others respond when things are going well (or not so well.)
5. At the end of the 5 minutes, flip each sheet of paper over and write at the top "What I Can Do Next."
6. Set the timer for another 5 minutes. This time, work to identify tools and strategies your learner can do in each scenario. For example, when things go right, your learner can list "Celebrate my goals." or "Have extra free time." or "Spend more time with friends." Conversely, when things are not going well, encourage listing strategies like, "Try something new." or "Ask for help." or "Use my problem-solving playbook."
7. When completed, post the sheets in your learner's workspace or their weekly binder (see Exercise #31) to easily reference.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise include two parts. First, work with your learner to complete the strategies lists for when things go right and wrong. This can be completed once or revised frequently as your learner's executive functioning skills grow. Secondly, work with your learner until they can successfully implement the recorded strategies in at least 3 different scenarios.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

For ideas to record on the "When Things Go Right" list, check out Rewarding Success (see Exercise #12), Fun Planner (see Exercise #19), and Incentive Incentives (see Exercise #73). For ideas to record on the "Going Wrong" list, check out chapters on Problem Solving, Emotional Control, and Impulse Control.

SKILL AREAS:



SELF
MONITORING



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: Easy to
Moderate

MATERIALS:

- Two 8.5 X11" blank pieces of paper
- Markers/pens/colored pencils
- Timer



EXERCISE #79

BEHAVIOR LOG

BACKGROUND:

ABC data collection is one of the gold-standard methods for recording executive functioning behaviors. While parents and teachers have implemented programs for recording behavior for decades, research shows that learners can also be taught ABC data collection for self-monitoring. In addition, ABC data often reveal what exercises and interventions are helpful moving forward.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- ABC Data Collection Sheet (p. 248)

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print several copies of the ABC Data Collection Sheet (p.248). Identify an opportunity to practice and rehearse using the ABC sheet with your learner before starting data collection.
2. Start by creating a list of the behaviors your learner will self-monitor. Behaviors should be specific and measurable and something easy for both you and your learner to observe.
3. Review the components of the sheet:
 - a. Antecedent = What happens in the environment immediately before the behavior.
 - b. Behavior = The target behavior or behaviors being observed.
 - c. Consequence = What happens in the environment immediately after the behavior occurs.
4. Work with your learner to practice and rehearse using the data collection sheet until they can self-monitor and record an entire sheet of sample behaviors reliably.
5. Next, set a data collection time frame. Often it's helpful to record ABC data in a smaller segment of the day (e.g., homework time, morning routine, etc.) rather than an entire day. Repeat the data collection for several days or weeks if needed.
6. Once collected, review with your learner what patterns emerge from the data collection. For example, do certain events trigger the behavior consistently? What events never happened before the behavior? Are there patterns in the time of day, or who else is in the environment? What consistently are the consequences when the behavior occurs?
7. Use the answers to these questions to identify and evaluate interventions, environmental changes, or other exercises that could help your learner develop new skills and behaviors.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

ABC data collection can be used for a variety of different behaviors. First, work with your learner to pre-teach the self-monitoring, and then expand until they can analyze the trends in ABCs to increase or decrease the target behavior.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

Some learners find it helpful to combine ABC data collection with graphing. Use the visuals in Progress Monitoring (see Exercise #75) to create a visual display of the results from ABC data collection.



ABC DATA COLLECTION

A = Antecedent (What's Happening BEFORE the behavior)

B = Behavior (Describe the Behavior)

C = Consequence (What Happens AFTER the behavior)

DATE:

TIME

ANTECEDENT

BEHAVIOR

CONSEQUENCE

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

⋮

EXERCISE #80

BOUNCE BACK

BACKGROUND:

Part of self-monitoring is learning to bounce back or move forward after a setback. If your learner struggles with making mistakes giving up easily, or needs support moving forward after a roadblock, use this active learning exercise to generate solutions to help your bounce back.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Gather your materials and identify 10-15 minutes in a quiet, distraction-free space to discuss with your learner.
2. Identify a recent time when your learner had a setback or when your learner struggled to bounce back. Spend a few minutes discussing what happened and what was difficult about it.
3. In the next 3-5 minutes, brainstorm strategies that your learner may have found helpful in recovering or moving forward from that situation. Then, discuss some of the advantages and disadvantages of each strategy.
4. Select the favorite strategies from the list, and have your learner transfer them to the surface of a small rubber basketball using a permanent marker.
5. The next time your learner struggles to move on, encourage them to "shoot hoops" to solve the problem or bounce back. Each time the basketball comes back to them, review the strategy written on the ball and how it might help them overcome their current challenge.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

Mastery criteria for this exercise include creating the basketball of strategies and implementing those strategies in difficult situations. Then, review and provide support until your learner can use the ball to brainstorm and select a solution to 3 new problems they encounter.

EXPANSION IDEAS:

If your learner benefits from a physical learning activity like the Bounce Back exercise, consider creating a basketball with other social skills, emotional control skills, or problem-solving skills. When your learner needs to brainstorm what to do next, encourage them to "shoot hoops" to review the strategies on their basketballs.

SKILL AREAS:



SELF
MONITORING



EMOTIONAL
CONTROL

SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

- Small rubber basketball
- Basketball Hoop
- Permanent Marker



EXERCISE #81

END OF THE MONTH REVIEW

BACKGROUND:

Even though we emphasize proactive planning in executive functioning, it's also important for individuals learning to use executive functioning strategies to reflect backward on how planning and organization went. Use this End of Month Review exercise to reflect on the previous month as a strategy for planning.

SKILL AREAS:



SKILL LEVEL: Moderate to Advanced

MATERIALS:

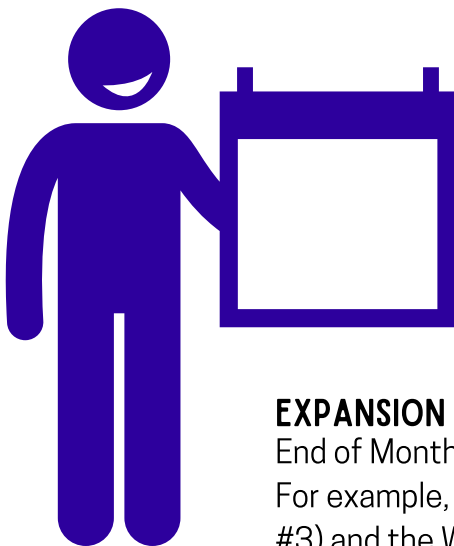
- End of Month Review worksheet (p. 251)
- Previous month's calendar, behavior logs, and checklists.

INSTRUCTIONS:

1. Download and print the End of Month Review Worksheet (p. 251). Identify a quiet, distraction-free environment for 10-15 minutes on the worksheet to work with your learner.
2. Begin by identifying the biggest events, activities, and projects from the previous month. Then, ask your learner to reflect on each of these tasks and evaluate how successful the outcomes were.
3. Also, identify what your learner liked best about the previous month. Use this as a way to evaluate motivation and build more positive events into the upcoming month.
4. Once the primary events and activities are reviewed, identify with your learner what tools were used to help them succeed with activities, along with roadblocks that hindered progress.
5. Finally, after reflecting on the previous month, begin using the information gathered to plan for the next month. Identify what activities your learner has to look forward to and the required tools necessary to succeed.

MASTERY CRITERIA:

The End of the Month Review process can be adapted to many different learners. Begin by supporting your learner to evaluate the month with help in each area. Then continue to fade support until your learner can evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of the previous month independently. Mastery criteria for this exercise include 3 consecutive months of evaluating progress and adapting the next month's activities accordingly.



EXPANSION IDEAS:

End of Month Review can be combined with many different exercises in the book. For example, use it as part of the Weekly Planning Meeting Agenda (see Exercise #3) and the Weekly Binder (see Exercise #31). In addition, if needed, use the End of Month Review as an opportunity to practice other exercises in other executive functioning areas.



MONTHLY REVIEW

Month:

1

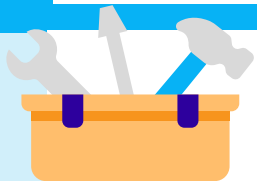
What were the biggest events, projects, assignments, and personal things that happened this month?

2

What was my favorite moment of this past month?

3

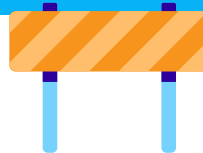
What was my biggest success?



TOOLS

What tools did I use to succeed this month?

What tools was I missing this month?



ROADBLOCKS

What roadblocks did I encounter this month?

How did I navigate them?

LOOKING AHEAD

What three things do I want to do better next month?

1

2

3

What tools will I need to succeed next month?





ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

For more information about executive functioning, social skills, life skills coaching, and how to implement exercises in this workbook, visit these resources:



Life Skills Advocate Coaching - If you need additional support and help to teach executive functioning skills, Life Skills Advocate offers in-person and virtual coaching services.

Life Skills Advocate Blog - Additional resources on parenting, teaching, and executive functioning skills, updated weekly from top experts in the field.

Executive Functioning 101 Hub - A comprehensive guide to executive functioning skills, including additional research and strategies to teach new skills.



Helping Your Teen Set SMART Goals - An in-depth email course for parents and teachers to help teens take actionable steps towards reaching and achieving their goals.



Raising a Wannabe Youtube Star - An email course for parents to help teens and young adults create and evaluate realistic goals; directed towards teens with goals to be an online influencer.



Adulthood Like A Champ Workbook - Assessment and strategy workbook to help diverse learners identify and prioritize life goals.



Real-Life Social Skills Academy - Step-by-step video course for teaching conversations and social skills to diverse learners.



Autism in Action Podcast - Podcast for parents and teachers for the latest research, resources and information on navigating the world of autism.



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ABOUT THE AUTHORS



MEET CHRIS HANSON

Based in the Puget Sound area, Chris has over 8 years of experience as a special educator where he developed a thriving high school life skills and community-based learning program in the Kent School District. In September of 2019, he started Life Skills Advocate, a transition support company where he provides local and virtual executive functioning, life skills coaching, academic and vocational coaching for neurodivergent teens, adults, and their families.



MEET AMY SIPPL

Amy Sippl is a Minnesota-based, Board Certified Behavior Analyst (BCBA) and freelance content developer specializing in helping individuals with autism and their families reach their best possible outcomes. Amy earned her Masters's Degree in Applied Behavior Analysis from St. Cloud State University and also holds undergraduate degrees in Psychology and Family Social Science from the University of Minnesota – Twin Cities. Amy has worked with children with autism and related developmental disabilities for over a decade in both in-home and clinical settings. Her content focuses on parents, educators, and professionals in the world of autism—emphasizing simple strategies and tips to maximize success. To see more of her work visit amysippl.com.